

# From single-atom coherent spin control to probing two-body interactions in ultracold alkaline-earth species

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Tous les fichiers svg :

# Dedication

For those who hate looking at a template with 500 lines of code and an extra 300 lines commented out.

# Declaration

# Acknowledgements

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# Introduction

In the history of science, multidisciplinary research has repeatedly shown the value of crossing field boundaries.

The Saha-Langmuir equation, linking ionization states to local temperature and pressure, was originally developed for physical chemistry. Yet it transformed astrophysics through the work of Cecilia Payne-Gaposchkin [5], who established that stars are predominantly composed of hydrogen and helium. Similarly, X-ray crystallography—devised to probe crystal lattices in solid-state physics—was applied by Rosalind Franklin and Raymond Gosling to determine the helical structure of DNA [6], contributing directly to molecular biology. In the same way, the discovery of radioactivity, polonium, and radium by Marie and Pierre Curie connected physics, chemistry, and medicine [7].

Following this interdisciplinary approach, ultracold atomic physics emerged as a platform for quantum simulation. As proposed by Richard Feynman [8], quantum simulators use controllable atomic systems to study complex many-body problems in condensed matter that remain difficult to model on classical computers. Over the past two decades, cold atom experiments have built a continuous line of progress at the boundary of these fields. I. Bloch *et al.* first demonstrated the transition from a superfluid to a Mott insulator state in an ultracold Bose gas [9], establishing optical lattices as a genuine platform to simulate strongly correlated materials such as transition metal oxides. Building on this proof of principle, systems governed by the Hubbard model were later implemented with both bosons and fermions, enabling the observation of magnetic ordering such as short-range Néel order [10, 11]. Resolving such subtle spatial correlations directly required single-atom, single-site resolution: the quantum gas microscopy technique developed by M. Greiner and I. Bloch [12], first demonstrated on  $^{87}\text{Rb}$  condensates and later extended to fermionic systems, made it possible to directly image the antiferromagnetic correlations mentioned above.

Alkaline-earth atoms stand out as a particularly well-suited species to explore these domains further, owing to properties that make them attractive for quantum simulation, optical metrology, and molecular physics alike.

## Interest and properties of $^{87}\text{Sr}$

Strontium is an alkaline-earth element whose stable isotopes are documented in the literature (e.g., [4, 13, 14, 15]). The bosonic isotopes ( $^{88}\text{Sr}$ ,  $^{86}\text{Sr}$ , and  $^{84}\text{Sr}$ ) have zero nuclear spin ( $I = 0$ ).

This work focuses on the fermionic isotope  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ , which has a natural abundance of 7.0%. Unlike its bosonic counterparts,  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  possesses a nuclear spin  $I = 9/2$ , giving

access to multi-level quantum dynamics and  $SU(N)$ -symmetric interactions (see a few lines below).

In the  $^1S_0$  ground state, the electronic angular momentum is zero ( $J = 0$ ), making the atom almost insensitive to magnetic field fluctuations. However, because there is no electronic magnetic moment, static magnetic fields cannot easily drive spin transitions directly. Optical methods are therefore required to address the nuclear spin states.

Finally, the decoupling between the nuclear spin and the electronic shell in the ground state leads to an  $SU(N)$  collisional symmetry: elastic scattering properties of two Zeeman states  $m_F$  and  $m'_F$  are independent of the nuclear spin projection  $m_F$  and  $m'_F$ . As a direct consequence, elastic collisions cannot redistribute population among spin states – an arbitrary spin mixture, once prepared, is protected against collisional spin relaxation. This is what makes the optical spin-manipulation and detection techniques presented below reliable: any spin dynamics observed can be attributed to the applied fields rather than to collisional decoherence of the prepared state.

## Metrology

Fermionic strontium first attracted interest for metrology because, unlike its bosonic counterparts, spin-polarized samples are protected against collisional shifts of the clock transition frequency by the Pauli exclusion principle [16]. It is now widely used in optical frequency standards, connecting precision measurement with atomic physics:

- **Ultra-narrow clock transition:** The  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_0$  transition features a narrow natural linewidth ( $\sim 1$  mHz) shielded from magnetic perturbations due to  $J = 0$  in both states [16]. H. Katori and collaborators identified a *magic wavelength* ( $\lambda_{\text{magic}} \approx 813$  nm) where the AC Stark shifts of  $^1S_0$  and  $^3P_0$  cancel, enabling trapping in optical lattices without shifting the transition frequency [17].
- **Beating the Standard Quantum Limit (SQL):** Measurement protocols using quantum logic, heterodyne detection, or spin-squeezing aim to reduce phase uncertainty below the SQL ( $\Delta\theta \propto 1/\sqrt{N}$ ) [18]. For example, J. Ye and co-workers reported clock fractional instabilities at the  $10^{-18}$  level [19]. In their experiment, a coherent spin state is prepared via a  $\pi/2$  pulse. Cavity-mediated non-destructive measurement generates a spin-squeezed state that reduces phase noise. A second pulse completes the Ramsey sequence, achieving phase uncertainty below the SQL with a squeezing parameter  $\xi^2 = 0.63 < 1$ .

## Photoassociation and dissipative quantum engineering

Optical control of short-range interactions also connects atomic physics with molecular spectroscopy:

- **Interaction control:** Interatomic interactions in degenerate quantum gases can be modified through molecular spectroscopy via photoassociation [20, 21], using optical Feshbach resonances to adjust the  $s$ -wave scattering length. Nevertheless these manipulations come with photon scattering responsible of gas heating.

- **Dissipation-assisted state preparation:** Controlled dissipation, such as two-body losses induced by photoassociation, can be used to stabilize target quantum states. Theoretical works (e.g., [22]) indicate that engineered dissipation can prepare Dicke states for precision measurements below the SQL.

## Thesis Outline

This manuscript covers experimental atomic cooling, quantum measurement schemes, and ultracold molecular spectroscopy.

The first chapter details the experimental sequence used to prepare a degenerate  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  gas, from initial laser cooling to nuclear spin state preparation. Physical models and operating parameters are presented for Transverse Cooling, the Zeeman Slower, Magneto-Optical Traps (MOT), and Evaporative Cooling. This chapter also describes a custom optical spectrum-filtering setup and diagnostic procedures developed for Extended-Cavity Diode Lasers (ECDL, MOGLabs).

The second chapter presents the quantum measurement platform constructed during this thesis, integrating the direct article we produced [1]. We characterize the coherence time of the nuclear spin qudit using Ramsey interferometry, then implement a dual-Ramsey scheme to extract two physical parameters within a single experimental cycle. Finally, we examine non-commuting observables in an initial 2-dimensional Hilbert space we extend to 4-dimensions subspace and map the protocol onto Positive-Operator-Valued Measures (POVM).

The third chapter reports on the spectroscopy of molecular lines in  $^{87}\text{Sr}_2$ . Following an overview of photoassociation and ultracold dimer physics, we describe the inelastic collisions of fermions and analyze the technical challenges encountered during their production and detection.

# Chapter 1

## Gas preparation and spin control

In this chapter, I describe each stage of the cooling and loading process from a practical “user guide” perspective, concluding with an explanation of the spin manipulation schemes tailored to our experimental goals: coherent control of quantum systems, precision measurement, and photoassociation spectroscopy of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ .

Preparation of the cold gas follows the standard scheme of ultracold gas experiments, combining successive stages of laser cooling with a final phase of evaporative cooling in an optical trap. Starting from a thermal atomic beam, the aim of this sequence is to progressively reduce the atoms’ velocity spread and increase their phase-space density, until quantum degeneracy is reached.

The gas preparation begins with an atomic flux effusing from an oven held at  $T = 490^\circ\text{C}$ , with a mean forward velocity of  $v \simeq 500$  m/s. The first cooling stage, 2D transverse cooling (TC), reduces the transverse velocity spread of this beam to  $\simeq 20$  m/s, at an estimated temperature  $T \simeq 1$  mK – somewhat above the Doppler limit of the  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^1P_1$  transition, since TC deliberately operates in the low-intensity regime discussed below.

Meanwhile, the Zeeman slower and blue Magneto-Optical Trap (MOT) lasers remain on for  $t_{\text{BlueMOT}} = 8$  s, both operating on the broad  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^1P_1$  transition (see Fig. 1.1), which both require a high magnetic gradient.

Because the transition is not closed, atoms accumulate in  $^3P_2$ . The dipole of the atoms trapped in this metastable state help to capture them with a magnetic trap set to  $\Delta B = 51$  G/cm for a coil current of 170 A. This trap is crucial for two reasons: it enables to accumulate the more atoms in the metastable state which demand few seconds but also to avoid losing them during the process when they are not addressed by the blue MOT anymore.

They are then repumped in 3.2 ms by a frequency sweep across multiple hyperfine states of the  $^3P_2 \rightarrow ^3D_2$  transition, to recover approximately 1:4 of the 1:20000 atoms that decayed in metastable -instead of  $^3P_1$ - and immediately recaptured in a MOT on the narrow line. By the end of this stage, approximately 30 million atoms are captured spread in about a centimeter in space.

The atoms are subsequently cooled on the narrow  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_1$  intercombination transition, in two successive red MOT stages: 182 ms of Sawtooth Wave Adiabatic Passage (SWAP) and broadband cooling followed by 250 ms of narrower-band cool-

ing (see below). Throughout both stages, a second “stirring” beam is applied in parallel with the main MOT beam to counteract a loss channel intrinsic to the red MOT’s  $\sigma^+/\sigma^-$  configuration (see below). The first stage, operated at a magnetic gradient  $\Delta B \simeq 1$  G/cm, brings the cloud to  $T \simeq 200$   $\mu$ K; the resulting Boltzmann-distributed gas has an in-situ spatial spread of  $\simeq 1$  mm. The second stage, at the same gradient, further cools the same 30 million atoms to an average temperature of  $T \simeq 30$   $\mu$ K, with a size of 300  $\mu$ m.

The final cooling step is a single-frequency (monofrequency) red MOT, operated at  $\Delta B \simeq 2.5$  G/cm at the crossing point of the two arms of an Optical Dipole Trap (ODT), occupying about 30  $\mu$ m. Two configurations are used depending on the results targeted in this thesis: in Chapter 2, the atoms are additionally loaded into an optical lattice formed at the crossing point, reaching a colder temperature of  $T \simeq 3$   $\mu$ K before the gas is further evaporated reaching deep quantum degeneracy at  $T \simeq 100$  nK, giving  $T/T_F = 0.25$  for a mean geometric pulsation  $\bar{\omega} = 2\pi \cdot 35$  estimated at the beginning of the evaporation, in a round surface of about 10  $\mu$ m diameter.

In Chapter 3, the atoms are held in one or two arms of the ODT only, within a round region of  $\simeq 100$   $\mu$ m, reaching  $T \simeq 3$   $\mu$ K with an atom number of 400 000.

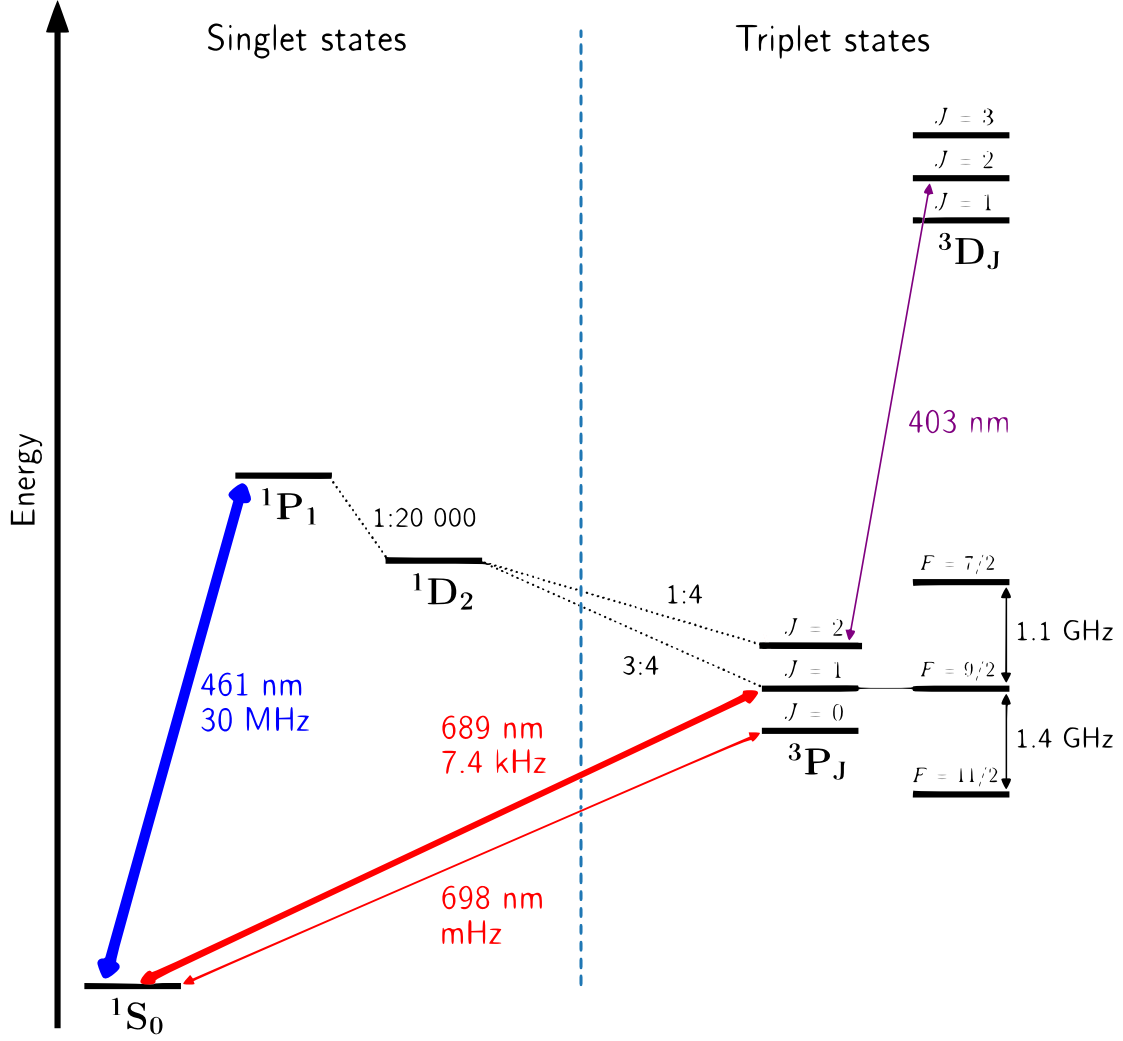


Figure 1.1: Extracted from [3] Energy spectrum of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  including fine and hyperfine interactions. In blue the 461 nm transition used for TC, Zeeman cooling, blue MOT stage and imaging. The purple arrow indicates the repump line at 403 nm from the metastable state  $^3P_2$  used for the atoms leaking from the intermediate  $^1D_2$  state. In red the transition to  $^3P_1$  at 689 nm used for all stages of the red MOT, optical pumping, spin manipulation, coherent manipulation (see Chap.2), photoassociation (see Chap.3, through the different hyperfine states  $F = 7/2, 9/2, 11/2$ ). The 698 nm transition indicates the clock transition which we do not use in this experiment.

Fig 1.2 is a representation of the entire experimental setup that summarizes the speed of the atoms, real magnetic gradient, the temperature and the size of the gas for every cooling stage.

The complete timing sequence – magnetic field ramps, laser intensities, and laser frequencies – for every stage described in this chapter is summarized in Fig. 1.3.

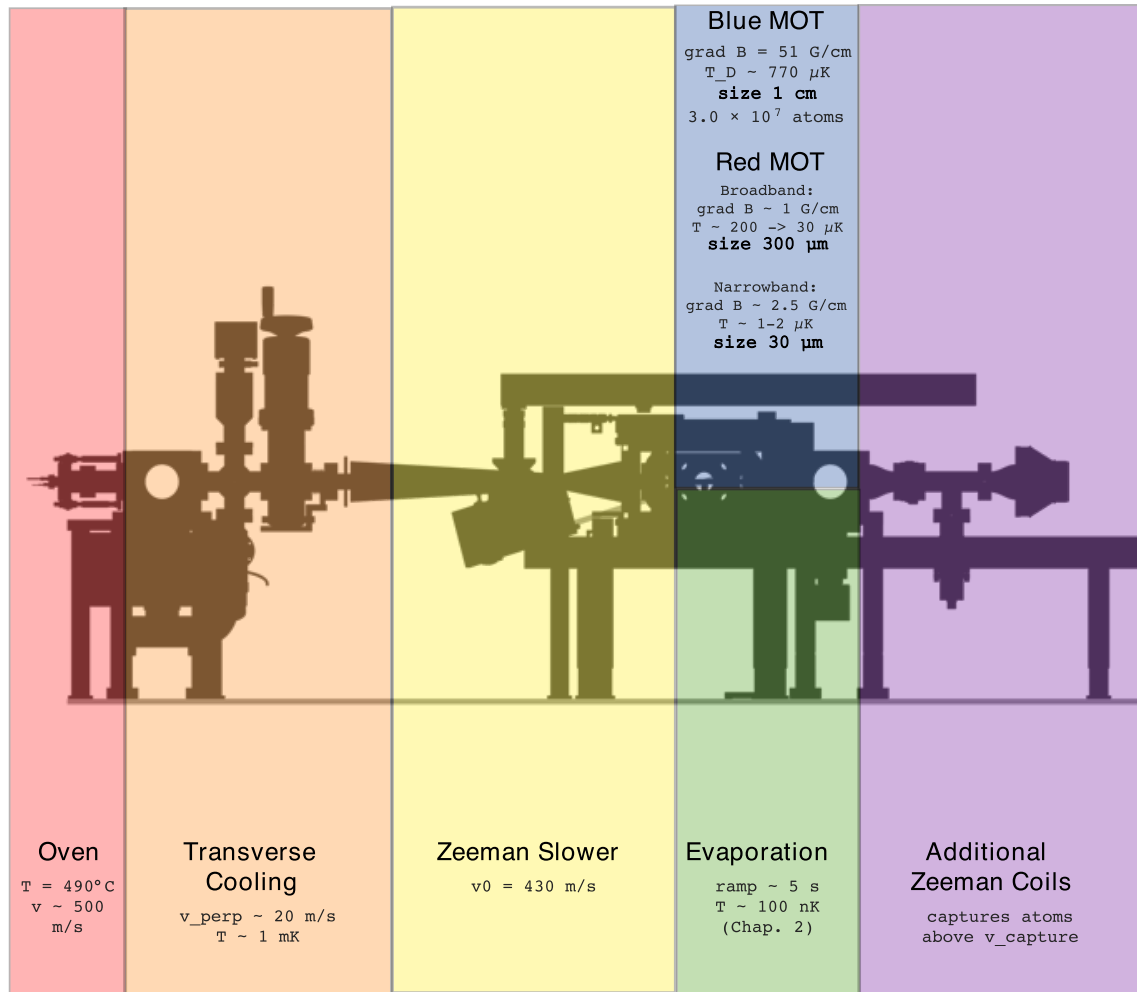


Figure 1.2: Extracted and modified from [2] Experimental full setup for the cooling and trapping of the atoms with figures on the velocity, temperature and typical magnetic gradient on each stage.



## 1.1 Fermi gas preparation

### 1.1.1 Blue optical setup

Solid strontium is vaporized in an oven heated to 490°C, outputting an atomic beam through a cluster of fine capillaries that provide initial spatial collimation.

The first cooling stages operate on the main  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^1P_1$  transition using a master-slave laser architecture (see Fig. 1.4). The master laser is an Extended-Cavity Diode Laser (ECDL, New Focus Vortex) frequency-stabilized via saturated absorption spectroscopy on  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  [2]. It seeds three high-power slave laser diodes, forcing them to inherit the master's narrow linewidth and central frequency while delivering the high output power needed for the cooling beams.

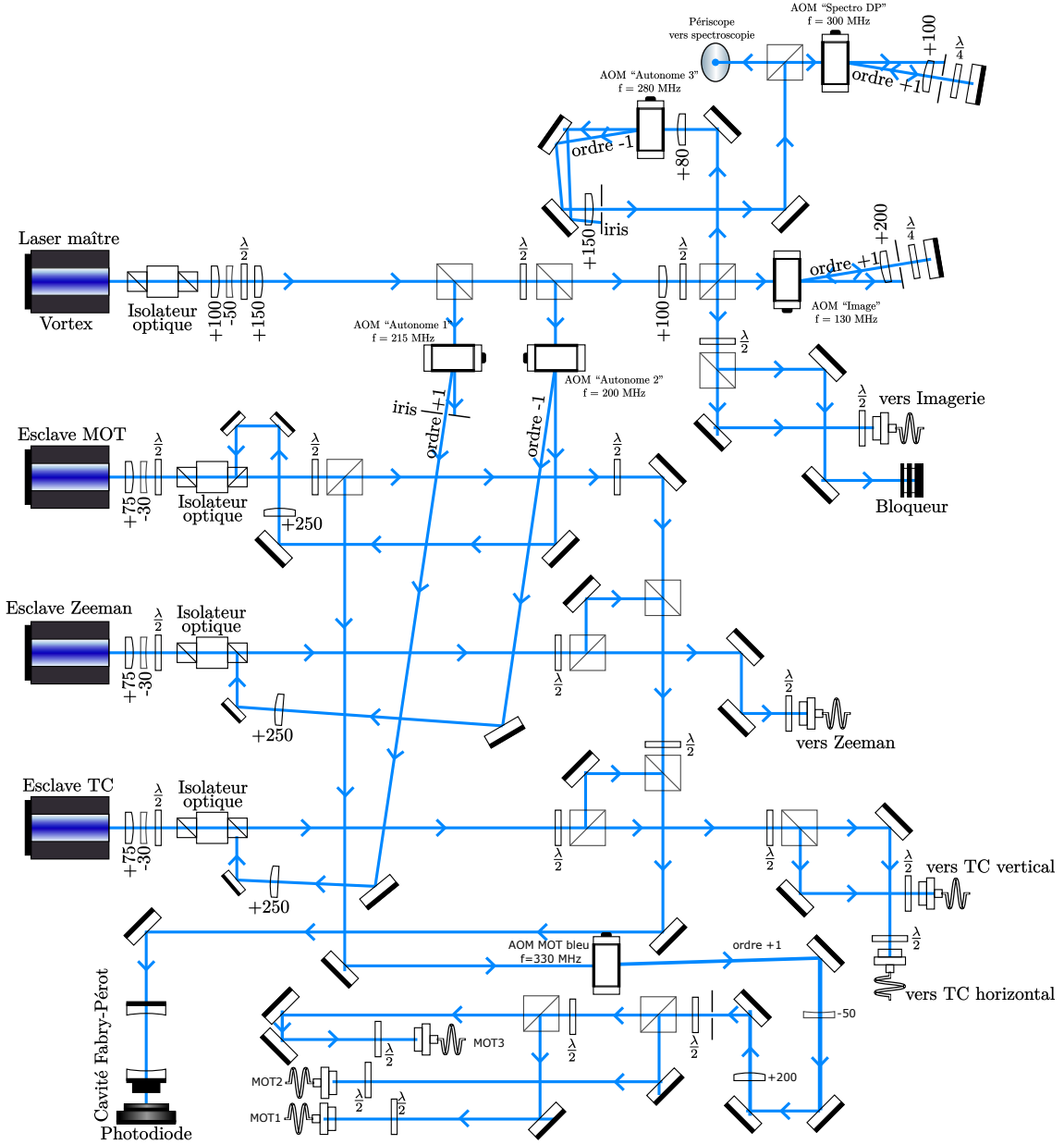


Figure 1.4: Optical layout of the 461 nm blue laser system for transverse cooling, Zeeman slowing, and blue MOT.

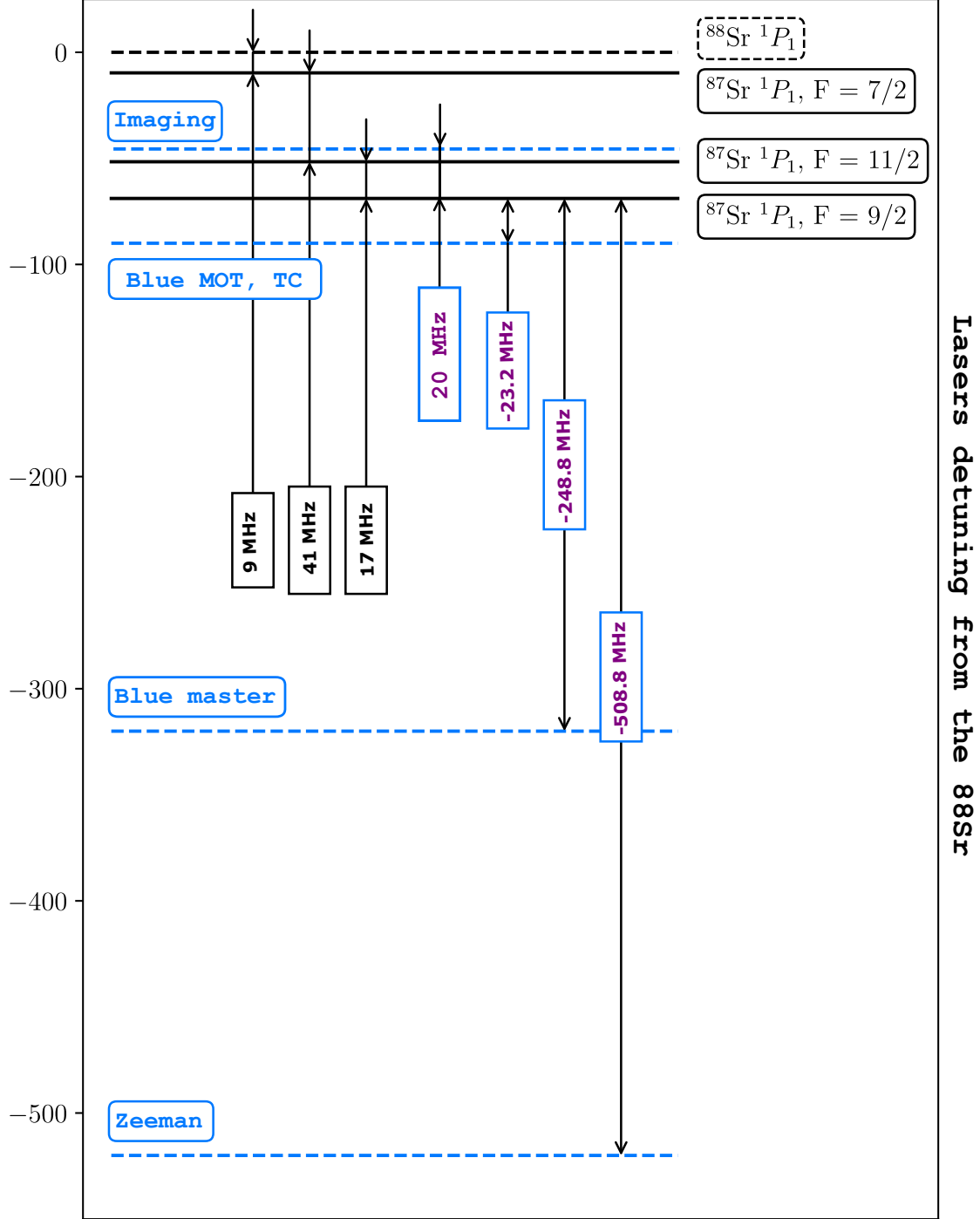


Figure 1.5: Adapted from P.Bataille thesis [23] Diagram of the frequencies of each laser composing the blue chain of the blue MOT broadband cooling. Blue dashed lines indicate the tunable frequencies of the lasers. Plain black lines indicate the transitions of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  and  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  isotopes. The frequencies refer mostly to the optical frequency at the output of the

### 1.1.2 Transverse cooling

Following extraction from the oven capillaries, the atomic beam is further collimated using 2D transverse cooling (TC). This stage employs two orthogonal pairs of counter-propagating laser beams perpendicular to the main longitudinal atomic propagation axis ( $z$ -axis), reducing the transverse velocity spread  $v_{\perp}$  via photon recoil momentum ( $\hbar k_{\perp}$ ). The perpendicular velocity is reduced to about 20 m/s.

#### 1.1.2.1 Operating principle and radiation pressure

The collimation relies on Doppler cooling. An atom moving with a transverse velocity  $\vec{v}_{\perp}$  experiences a Doppler shift  $\Delta_D = -\vec{k}_{\perp} \cdot \vec{v}_{\perp}$ . As illustrated in Fig. 1.6, atomic velocity classes observe shifted transition resonances centered at  $\omega_0 \pm \vec{k}_{\perp} \cdot \vec{v}_{\perp}$ . When the laser frequency is red-detuned ( $\Delta < 0$ ) with respect to the atomic transition frequency ( $\omega_0$ , the center of the purple gaussian), the atom preferentially absorbs photons from the counter-propagating beam, generating a net damping force.

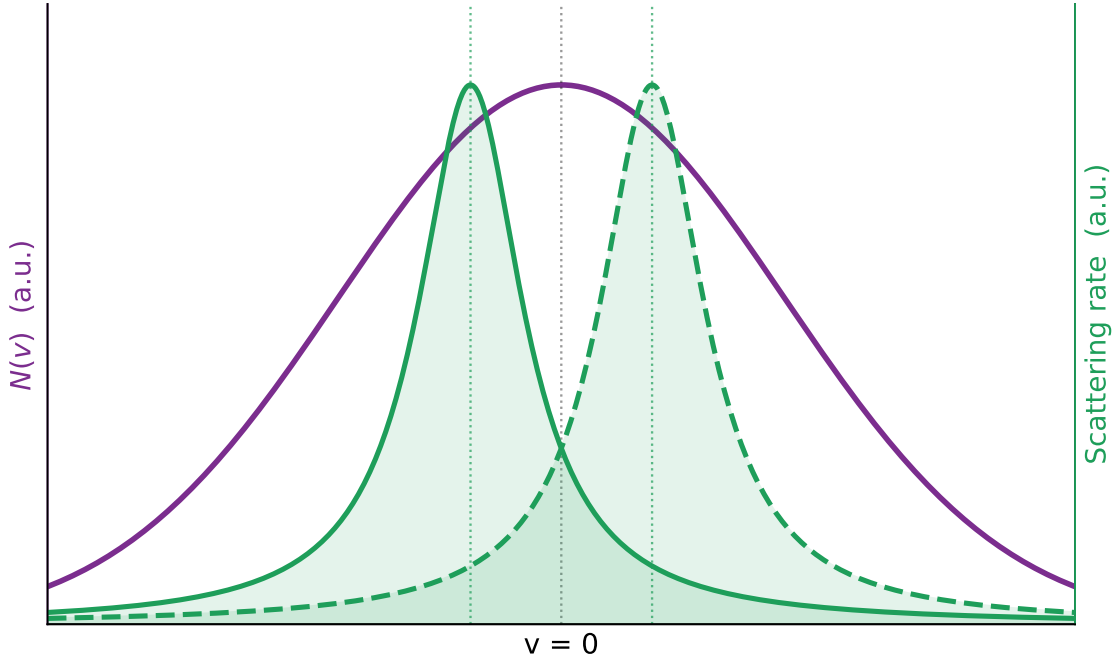


Figure 1.6: Illustration of the transverse cooling effect on the atoms arriving from the oven spread in different velocity classes.

In the low-intensity limit ( $s \ll 1$ ), standard Doppler cooling theory shows that the equilibrium temperature  $T(\Delta)$ , set by the competition between the velocity-dependent damping and the momentum diffusion from photon scattering, is minimized at a detuning of  $\Delta_{\text{eff}} = -\Gamma/2$ , yielding the Doppler temperature limit  $T_D = \hbar\Gamma/(2k_B)$ .

#### 1.1.2.2 Experimental setup and laser configuration

For this stage, we drive the broad-linewidth  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^1P_1$  transition ( $\Gamma/2\pi = 30.5$  MHz,  $I_{\text{sat}} \approx 40$  mW/cm<sup>2</sup>). The laser frequency  $f_{\text{TC}}$  is generated by shifting the main blue

master frequency using an acousto-optic modulator (AOM) driven at  $f_{\text{TC}}^{\text{RF}}$ :

$$f_{\text{TC}} = f_{\text{Blue,Master}} + f_{\text{TC}}^{\text{RF}} \quad (1.1)$$

The horizontal arm is operated at roughly three times the intensity of the vertical arm, with  $I/I_{\text{sat}} = 0.25$  in the horizontal arm: there is no physical reason why it is this way but we observe the best cooling for this ratio. Both arms nonetheless remain below saturation ( $I < I_{\text{sat}}$ ) over an interaction area of approximately  $10 \text{ cm}^2$ . The TC laser remains active throughout the subsequent blue-cooling stages to ensure continuous atomic-flux collimation.

### 1.1.2.3 Detuning and power optimization

While ideal two-level theory predicts an optimal detuning of  $\Delta = -\Gamma/2$ , experimental constraints alter this optimum:

- **Power limitations over large beam areas:** Operating near saturation ( $I \sim I_{\text{sat}}$ ) would maximize the velocity capture range through power broadening and larger radiation pressure forces. However, illuminating the  $10 \text{ cm}^2$  interaction area at saturation would require over 400 mW of optical power. Consequently, the system operates in the low-intensity regime ( $I \ll I_{\text{sat}}$ ).
- **Optimal detuning shift:** Experimental characterization reported in F. Faisant's thesis [24] demonstrated that maximum collimation efficiency (measured by downstream atom yield) is achieved for low intensity at  $\Delta = -\Gamma/4$  rather than  $-\Gamma/2$ , as shown in Fig. 1.7. Indeed considering the residual random motion of the atoms modifies the expression of the total average force: minimum temperature is reached for higher intensities. This plot also illustrates how the maximum atom number gain improves with total beam power.

Future upgrades in progress include replacing the current TC slave diode with a higher-power diode and re-optimizing  $\Delta_{\text{eff}}$  to further enhance atom capture. Following transverse collimation, the atomic beam enters the Zeeman slower stage along the main longitudinal axis.

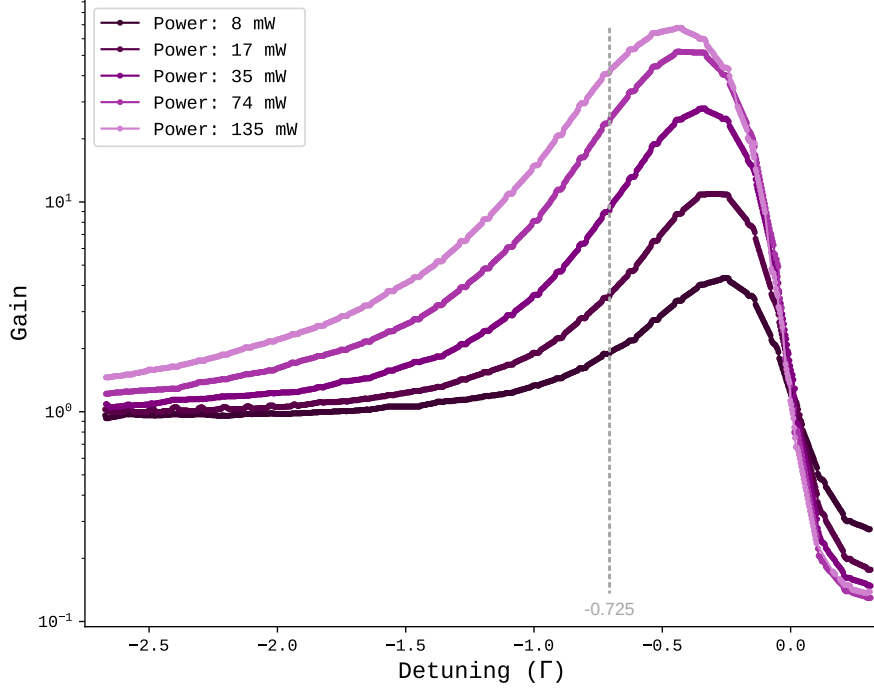


Figure 1.7: Transverse cooling performance as a function of laser detuning and power (adapted from [24]). Curves of atom number gain for different optical powers on TC are showing optimum that are not centered on the same detuning.

### 1.1.3 Zeeman cooling

Following transverse collimation, atoms are decelerated longitudinally using a Zeeman slower [25]. The mechanism relies on a counter-propagating laser beam maintained on resonance with the decelerating atoms as they travel through a spatially varying magnetic field gradient  $B(z)$  generated by a tapered solenoid.

To compensate for the decreasing Doppler shift  $kv(z)$  as atoms slow down, the magnetic field  $B(z)$  shifts the Zeeman sub-levels to satisfy the resonance condition along the entire deceleration path:

$$\Delta_{\text{eff}}(z) = \omega_{\text{laser}} - \omega_0 + kv(z) - \frac{\mu_B g_J B(z)}{\hbar} = 0 \quad (1.2)$$

Here,  $\Delta_{\text{eff}}(z)$  is the local effective detuning experienced by the atom at position  $z$ ;  $\omega_{\text{laser}}$  and  $\omega_0$  are the angular frequencies of the slowing laser and of the atomic transition, respectively;  $k = 2\pi/\lambda$  is the laser wavevector;  $v(z)$  is the atom's longitudinal velocity at position  $z$ ;  $\mu_B$  is the Bohr magneton;  $g_J$  is the Landé factor of the excited electronic level; and  $B(z)$  is the local magnetic field produced by the Zeeman slower.

Only atoms entering the slower with a velocity below the capture velocity  $v_0 = 430$  m/s can satisfy Eq. 1.2 and thus be decelerated; faster atoms never come into resonance with the slowing beam and pass through unaffected.

Solving Eq. 1.2 for the required field profile gives

$$B(z) = \frac{\hbar}{\mu_B g_J} \left[ kv(z) + (\omega_{\text{laser}} - \omega_0) \right], \quad (1.3)$$

with  $\omega_{\text{laser}} - \omega_0 < 0$  (red-detuned laser) and  $v(z)$  decreasing progressively along the slower. Whether  $B(z)$  eventually changes sign depends on the chosen detuning  $|\omega_{\text{laser}} - \omega_0|$  relative to  $kv_f$ , where  $v_f$  is the target exit velocity: for  $|\omega_{\text{laser}} - \omega_0| > kv_f$ , the field must cross zero and become negative before the atoms reach  $v_f$ .

Because the atom's direction of motion does not change, this sign change reflects only the resonance condition of Eq. 1.2, not a reversal of the atomic trajectory: atoms continue to decelerate in the same direction throughout. Supplementary coils of increasing radii, placed past this zero crossing, produce the required negative field to keep the already-slowed atoms in resonance down to the final capture velocity suitable for MOT trapping.

### 1.1.4 Blue MOT

The Magneto-Optical Trap (MOT) provides simultaneous spatial confinement and cooling.

The blue MOT combines a magnetic quadrupole field (generated by anti-Helmholtz coils centered on the vacuum chamber, driven at 170 A to produce a gradient of  $\Delta B = 51$  G/cm) with three orthogonal pairs of counter-propagating 461 nm laser beams carrying opposite circular polarizations ( $\sigma^+/\sigma^-$ ) [26].

The position-dependent Zeeman shift lifts the degeneracy of the  $m_F$  sub-levels:

$$\Delta E(z) = m_F g_F \mu_B B(z) \quad (1.4)$$

Combined with the  $\sigma^\pm$  polarization of the counter-propagating, red-detuned beams, this position-dependent shift brings only one beam into resonance on either side of the trap center ( $z = 0$ ), creating a restoring force toward  $z = 0$  alongside the velocity-dependent radiation pressure force. The vertical beam waist is twice smaller than the two horizontal one and the mean intensity of each axis is  $I/I_{\text{sat}} = 0.3$  (13 mW/cm<sup>2</sup>).

During this stage, the cloud reaches the Doppler temperature limit [27]:

$$k_B T_D = \frac{\hbar \Gamma_{1S_0 \rightarrow 1P_1}}{2} \quad (1.5)$$

Due to the broad linewidth of the 461 nm transition ( $\Gamma/2\pi = 30.5$  MHz), this Doppler temperature ( $T_D \approx 770$   $\mu$ K) remains significantly higher than the single-photon recoil limit  $T_r$ .

The atoms are transferred in  $1P_1$  state that is determined by the equation evolution of the atom number:

$$\frac{dN(t)}{dt} = \alpha \Phi - \gamma_{\text{loss}} N(t) \quad (1.6)$$

where  $\Phi$  is the incident atomic flux on the MOT capture region,  $\alpha$  is the dimensionless capture efficiency (the fraction of that flux actually trapped, depending on experimental parameters),  $\gamma_{\text{loss}} = \gamma_{\text{vacuum}} + \gamma_{\text{leak}}$  respectively the loss rate due to the imperfection of the vacuum and the rate leakage to the metastable state. Then the number of atom in time evolves as:

$$N(t) = N_{\text{sat}}(1 - e^{-t/\tau}) \quad (1.7)$$

$N_{sat} = \alpha\Phi\tau$  when the transition reaches its maximum value. Since the blue MOT lifetime is dominated by the leak into the metastable state and amounts to a few tens of milliseconds [28], saturating the blue MOT atom number only requires waiting for a few such lifetimes.

The experimental accumulation time, however, is set by a different consideration: reaching the maximum number of atoms trapped in the metastable state, which takes 8.2 s. Although the blue-MOT population itself saturates within a few tens of milliseconds, only a fraction of the atoms leaking out of the  $^1P_1$  cycle end up trapped in the long-lived metastable state on each pass – the rest decay back to the ground state and re-enter the blue-MOT cycle, where they must leak again before being retained (see branching ratios below). Accumulating a large fraction of the atoms into the metastable reservoir therefore requires many such cycles, hence the much longer 8.2 s duration. Throughout this accumulation, the magnetic field gradient is kept at its maximum, acting as a magnetic trap that confines the atoms in the metastable state, whose magnetic dipole moment is non-zero.

### 1.1.5 Repumper

A repumping laser system recovers these accumulated atoms into the cooling cycle: of the roughly 1:20000 photon-scattering events on  $^1P_1$  that decay via  $^1D_2$  rather than back to the ground state, about 1:4 reach the long-lived  $^3P_2$  state addressed here (lifetime  $\tau \approx 500$  s), with the rest returning through  $^3P_1$ . Without repumping, atoms trapped in  $^3P_2$  remain dark to the 461 nm light and are permanently lost from the cooling cycle.

#### 1.1.5.1 Hyperfine structure of Strontium-87

Because fermionic  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  possesses a nuclear spin  $I = 9/2$ , its electronic states exhibit a rich hyperfine structure that must be addressed for efficient repumping.

Repumping is provided by a 403 nm external-cavity diode laser (TOPTICA). To address multiple  $F$  hyperfine sub-levels (see Fig. 1.8), the laser frequency is rapidly swept over a 3 GHz bandwidth for 3.2 ms.

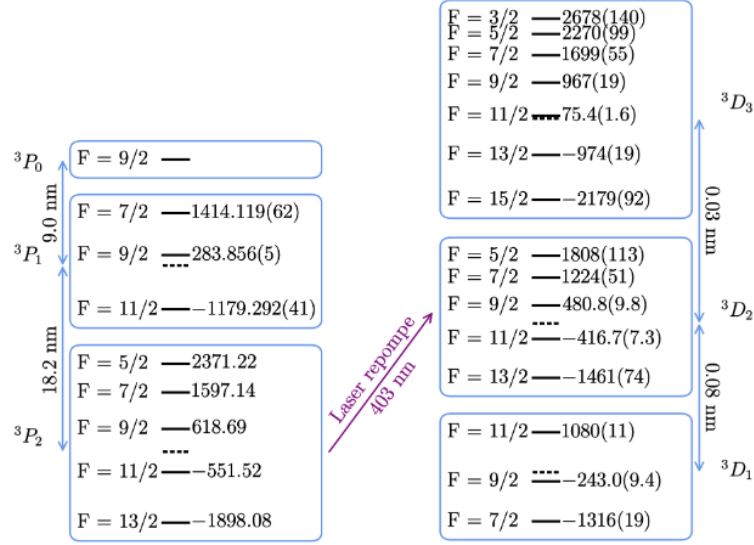


Figure 1.8: Energy level diagram of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  of the transition  $^3P_2$  to the hyperfine states of the  $^3D_J$  at 403 nm cooling.

### 1.1.5.2 Optimization of the repumper sweep

The  $^3P_2$  hyperfine levels are unequally populated during blue MOT decay due to their differing  $g_F$  Landé factors, affecting their magnetic trapping efficiency [28].

To recover this population into the cooling cycle, the sequence proceeds as follows: the 461 nm beam is first extinguished at the end of the blue MOT phase, preventing recovered atoms from being re-excited and recycling back onto the blue transition; the 689 nm red MOT lasers are then switched on, so that atoms are captured as soon as they return to the ground state; finally, the 403 nm repumper is pulsed for 3.2 ms at  $I \approx 15 \text{ mW/cm}^2$ , starting 9.3 ms after the red MOT lasers are switched on, and the red MOT is left running afterwards. The repumper frequency is scanned over a range optimized around 3 GHz to selectively cover the  $F = 11/2$  and  $F = 13/2$  states; scanning a wider range would reduce total atom recovery by decreasing the dwell time on these critical transitions.

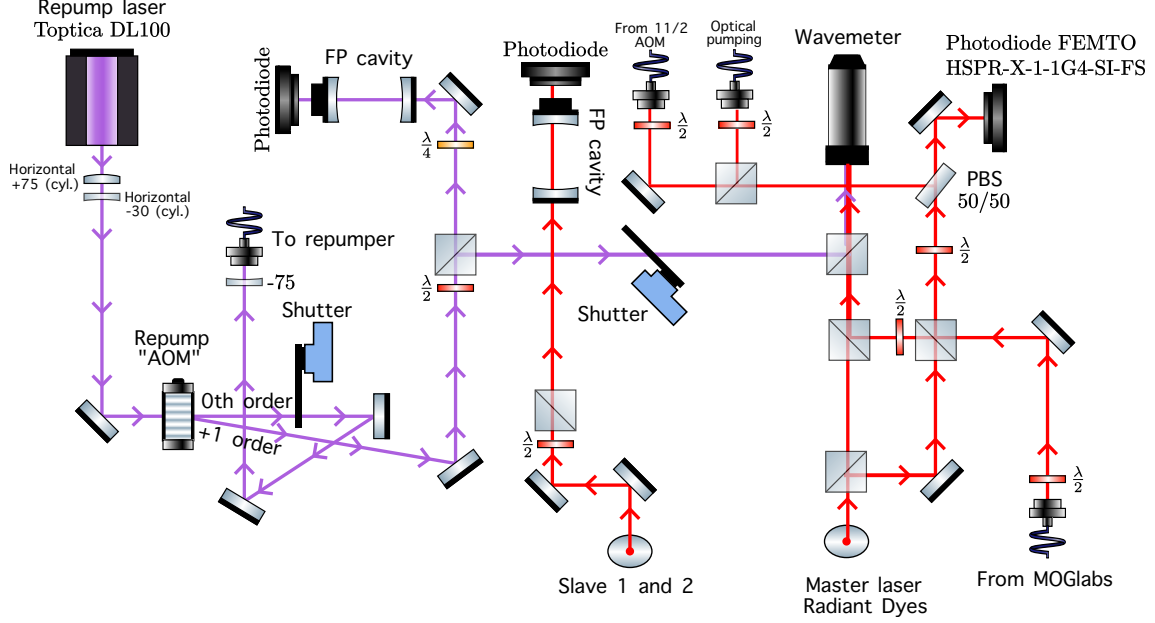


Figure 1.9: Optical setup for the repump and the beat-lock setup of the MOGLabs laser onto the Radiant Dyes.

### 1.1.6 Laser cooling on the intercombination line : the “red MOT”

#### 1.1.6.1 Optical setup

Because the blue MOT temperature is bounded by  $T_D \approx 770 \mu\text{K}$ , further cooling requires transferring atoms to the narrow intercombination transition  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_1$  at 689 nm ( $\Gamma = 2\pi \times 7.4 \text{ kHz}$ ).

For this transition, the formal Doppler limit ( $T_D = \hbar\Gamma/mk_B = 177 \text{ nK}$ ) falls below the single-photon recoil limit ( $T_r = \hbar^2k^2/2m = 462 \text{ nK}$ ). Consequently, the ultimate red MOT temperature is bounded by the photon recoil limit.

The 689 nm light is generated by a commercial laser locked to an ultra-stable optical cavity referred as “Red lock” in Fig.1.11 that contains all the frequencies of the red chain. The red master laser, from which the MOT, STIR, and optical pumping beams are all derived, has an optical frequency -220 MHz detuned from the  $^{88}\text{Sr}, ^3P_1$ . The ‘Red lock’ is the summation of the ‘AOM Inj Slave 1’ that enables to access GHz away transitions from the bosonic state, with the RF frequency of the ultrastable cavity AOM.

Double-pass AOMs then fine-tune the frequency of MOT and Stir beams individually before splitting into three spatial counter-propagating beam pairs, bringing the actual atom-light detuning down to the much smaller values used for trapping (see below).

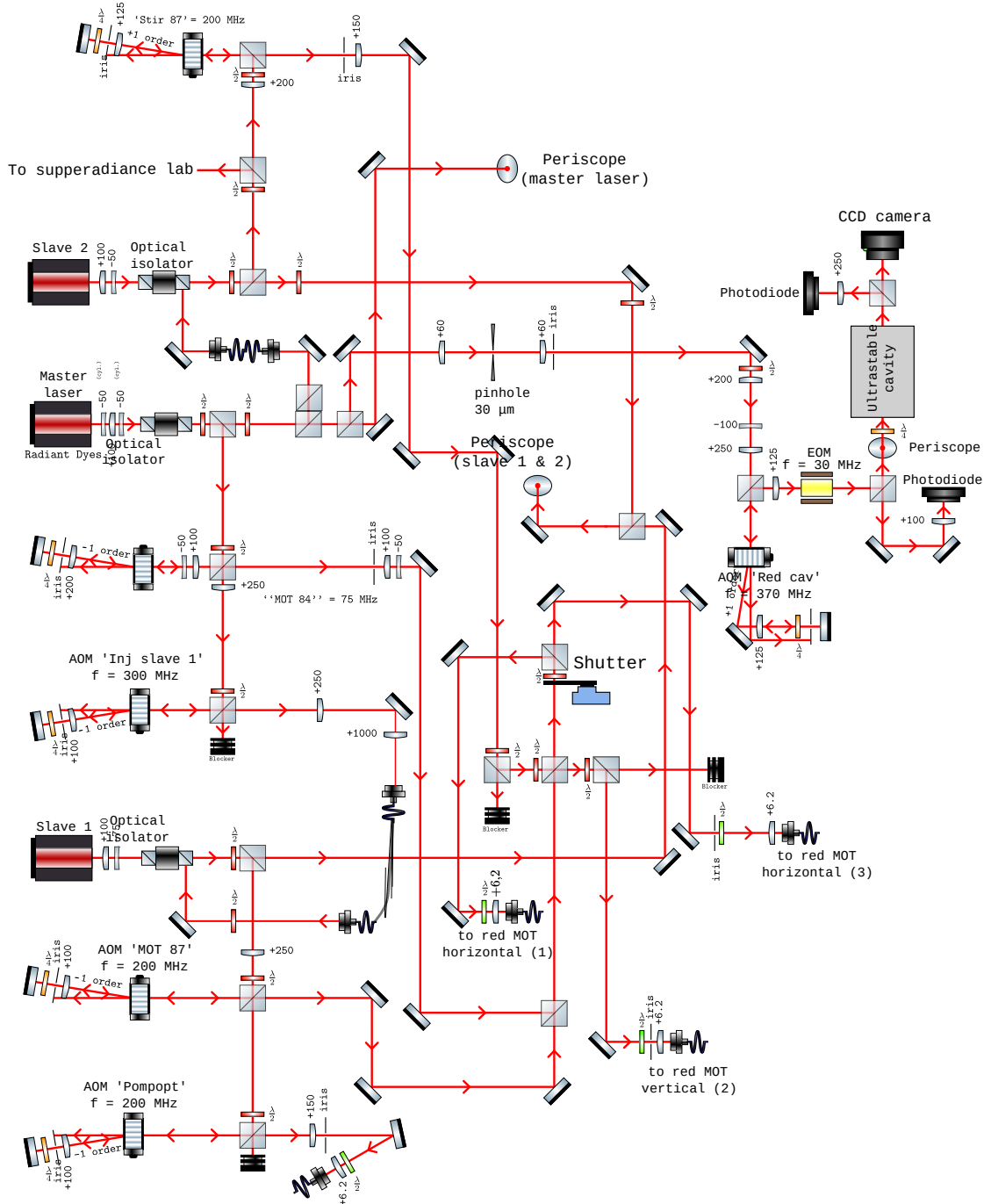


Figure 1.10: Optical setup of the 689 nm laser cooling system.

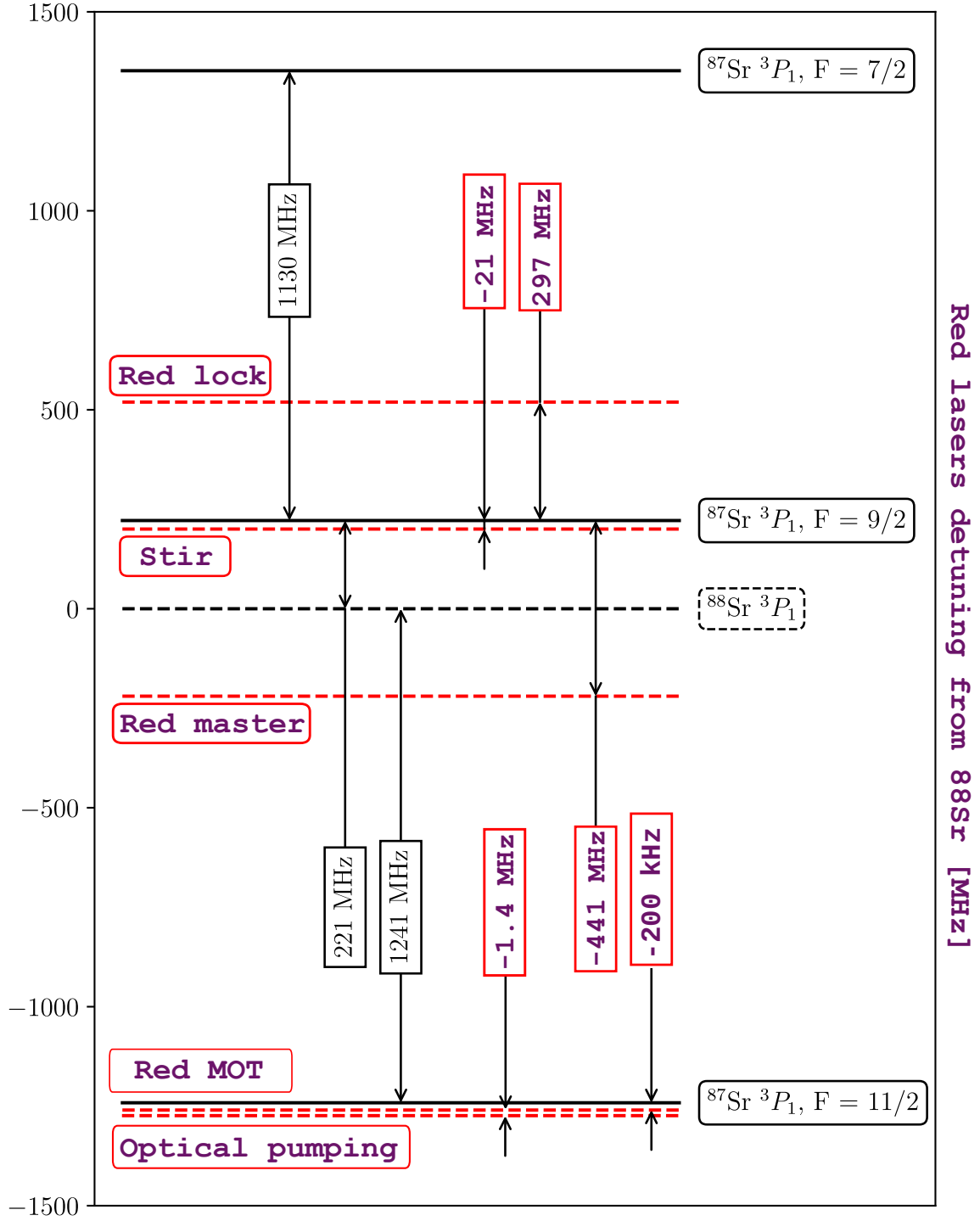


Figure 1.11: Frequencies of the red lasers used for the red MOT cooling stages and optical pumping. The red dashed lines correspond to the tunable frequencies, the dark plain lines for the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  hyperfine states of transition  $^3P_J$  and the  $^{88}\text{Sr}$

### 1.1.6.2 Swap cooling, broadband MOT to narrowband

At the end of the blue MOT, approximately 30 million atoms have been captured; their spatial spread ( $\approx 300 \mu\text{m}$ , reached at the end of the SWAP stage) and thermal energy exceed the capture velocity of a single-frequency 689 nm MOT. To capture these thermal atoms, a broadband MOT is implemented on the  $^1S_0 (F = 9/2) \rightarrow ^3P_1 (F = 11/2)$  transition under a weak magnetic field gradient ( $\Delta B \simeq 1 \text{ G/cm}$ , bias

coil voltage  $V_A = 0.50$ ), operated in two successive stages. In parallel a redistribution of the spin is assured by a stirring laser, its function explained in the following subsection.

In the first stage, lasting 182 ms, SWAP (Sawtooth Wave Adiabatic Passage) cooling is applied [29]. As illustrated in 1.12 two counter-propagating beams have their frequency swept through resonance, then reset almost instantaneously back to the initial frequency of the ramp. The ramp drives two sequential, stimulated transfers: first absorption from the beam the atom is moving towards. The laser gets on resonance with the Doppler shifted atom at  $\omega_L - kv$ . The frequency of the laser still increasing then becomes resonant with the opposite polarized laser which affects the atom with a new velocity  $v'$  after the absorption: by emission into the opposing beam  $2\hbar k$  are removed of momentum per sweep without relying on spontaneous emission. The fast reset, in contrast, is deliberately non-adiabatic so that it drives no transfer, and hence no momentum kick, back the other way; a symmetric ramp would instead undo the cooling just achieved.

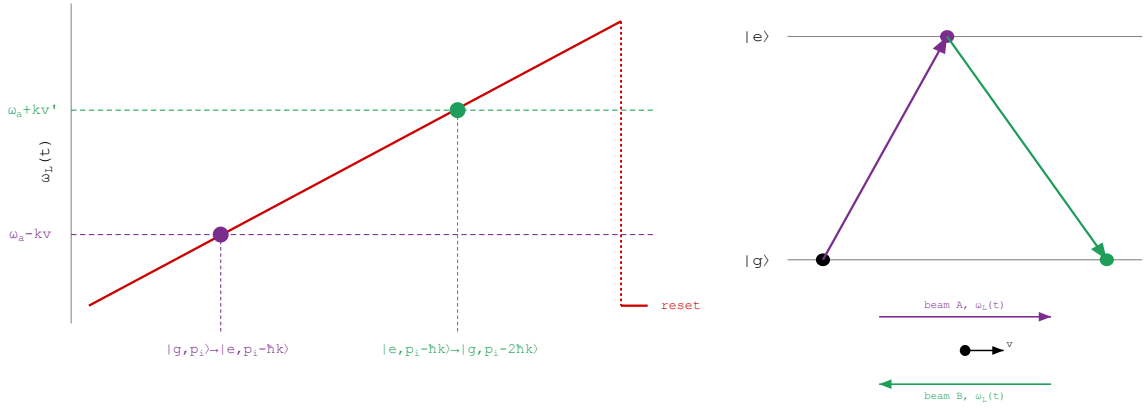


Figure 1.12: Mechanism of SWAP cooling, adapted from [29]. Left: over one slow rise of the sawtooth  $\omega_L(t)$ , the laser successively crosses the two Doppler-shifted resonance conditions  $\omega_a - kv$  and  $\omega_a + kv'$ , driving first an absorption then a stimulated emission into the opposing beam; the fast reset transfers no population. Top right: the corresponding two-level picture, showing the atom transiently promoted to  $|e\rangle$  before returning to  $|g\rangle$  with a net momentum change of  $-2\hbar k$ . Bottom right: geometry, with the atom (velocity  $v$ ) between two counter-propagating beams sharing the same swept frequency  $\omega_L(t)$ .

The trapping beam (MOT) is swept between RF frequencies 111.9 and 110.4 MHz – corresponding to a real detuning from the  $^3P_1$  ( $F' = 11/2$ ) resonance (calibrated at 110.34 MHz on this AOM) of  $-6.24$  MHz to  $-240$  kHz – while the stirring beam (STIR, see below) is swept between 105.25 and 103.7 MHz **[TODO: convert to real detuning from  $F' = 9/2$  once its resonance is measured on this AOM]**, both starting at an intensity of  $I_{A100}(MOT87) = 5 \text{ mW/cm}^2$  and  $I_{A100}(STIR) = 2 \text{ mW/cm}^2$ .

In principle, since SWAP relies on an adiabatic passage through resonance to generate a deterministic momentum kick on every sweep, the detuning should start blue of resonance, cross it, and end red-detuned by an amount that itself shrinks stage after stage as the cloud cools further. In practice, however, the implemented sweep

range given above ( $-6.24$  to  $-240$  kHz) remained entirely red-detuned relative to the  $F' = 11/2$  resonance and never actually crossed it – indicating that this parameter was not fully optimized (already represented in the sequence scheme 1.3).

After 9.3 ms, the repumper pulse described above interrupts the SWAP of the MOT and STIR sweeps for 3.2 ms; the MOT and STIR sweeps then resume for the remainder of the 182 ms stage. As the cloud cools and compresses during this stage, the modulation amplitude  $\Delta f$  is progressively ramped down together with the optical power, which reaches  $I_{A85} = 4.3 \text{ mW/cm}^2$  for the MOT beam and still  $I_{A85} = 2 \text{ mW/cm}^2$  for the STIR beam by the end of the stage. Toward the end of this first stage, the sweep transitions into a broadband-capture phase, using a symmetric triangular ramp (no fast reset) to sweep continuously across a broader range of Zeeman sub-levels, as illustrated in Fig. 1.13.

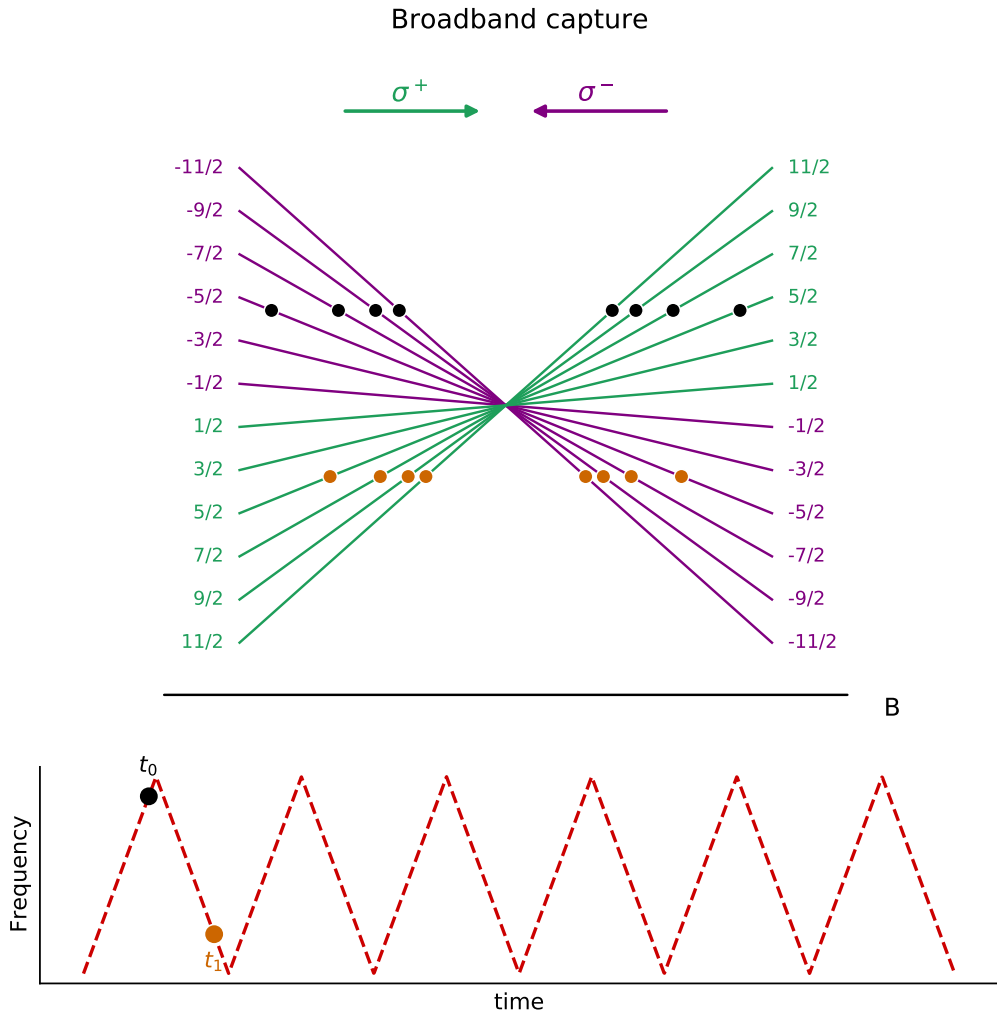


Figure 1.13: Broadband capture stage of the 689 nm red MOT (adapted from [30]). Top: Zeeman sublevels depending on the B field and position since  $B \propto x$ . Dark dots show the Zeeman states addressed at  $t_0$  by the laser rampe plotted on the bottom figure. The orange dots are the Zeeman states addressed at  $t_1$  by the same laser rampe.

In the second stage, lasting 250 ms and visible on the right of Fig. 1.13, the cool-

ing light is modulated with a conventional sawtooth ramp detuned from resonance – no longer swept symmetrically through it – operating as a standard frequency-modulated Doppler-cooling MOT that further compresses and cools the now colder, denser cloud. The MOT and STIR frequencies are ramped to their narrowband values of 110.395 MHz (a real detuning of  $-220$  kHz from the  $F' = 11/2$  resonance, measured after the slight magnetic-field adjustment described below) and 105.309 MHz respectively **[TODO: STIR real detuning from  $F' = 9/2$ , and the missing lower bound of the stage-2 STIR ramp, to be added]**, while the bias coil voltage is raised to  $V_C = 0.51$ . Over this stage, the optical power is reduced further, in two additional steps for the MOT beam – from  $I_{A85} = 2 \text{ mW/cm}^2$ , through  $I_{A32} = 1.6 \text{ mW/cm}^2$ , down to a final value of  $I_{A19} = 1 \text{ mW/cm}^2$  – while the STIR beam is reduced from  $I_{A85} = 2 \text{ mW/cm}^2$  to a final value of  $I_{A55} = 1.3 \text{ mW/cm}^2$ . By the end of this second stage, the cloud has cooled to an average temperature of  $T \simeq 30 \text{ } \mu\text{K}$  with a size of  $\simeq 300 \text{ } \mu\text{m}$ .

### 1.1.6.3 Stirring laser

The  $\sigma^+/\sigma^-$  configuration of the red MOT introduces an intrinsic loss channel arising from the large differential Landé  $g$ -factor between the ground  $^1S_0, F = 9/2$  and excited  $^3P_1, F' = 11/2$  hyperfine levels. As illustrated in Fig. 1.14, the position-dependent Zeeman shift ( $B \sim x$ ) brings the two counter-propagating beams into resonance with different  $m'_F$  sub-levels at the same position: the  $\sigma^+$  beam (green) addresses the closed transition  $m_F = 9/2 \rightarrow m'_F = 11/2$ , while, within the same laser linewidth (grey band), the  $\sigma^-$  beam (purple) simultaneously becomes resonant with the neighbouring, open transition  $m_F = 9/2 \rightarrow m'_F = 7/2$ . This dual resonance is not by itself a loss mechanism: the relative probability of the two processes, set by their Clebsch-Gordan coefficients, favors the restoring transition by a ratio as high as 55:1 in the most extreme case, so that the force averaged over many scattering events remains restoring [30].

The condition for stable operation of a  $F \rightarrow F + 1$  MOT transition requires the double inequality  $F/(F + 1) < g_e/g_g < F/(F - 1)$  to hold [30]. For  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ , where  $g_e/g_g \sim 10^3$  due to the near-vanishing nuclear magnetic moment of the  $^1S_0$  ground state, this condition is violated by several orders of magnitude. As a consequence, the resonance condition  $(m'_F g_e - m_F g_g) \mu_B B(x) = h\Delta$  has a widely  $m_F$ -dependent slope: low- $|m_F|$  states cross the laser resonance window (grey band) over a broad range of positions, while the most Zeeman-shifted states cross it almost vertically, remaining within resonance over such a narrow range of  $x$  that they are, in practice, essentially unaddressed by a fixed-frequency beam (Fig. 1.15, left panel, akin to Fig. 2.8(d) of [30]).

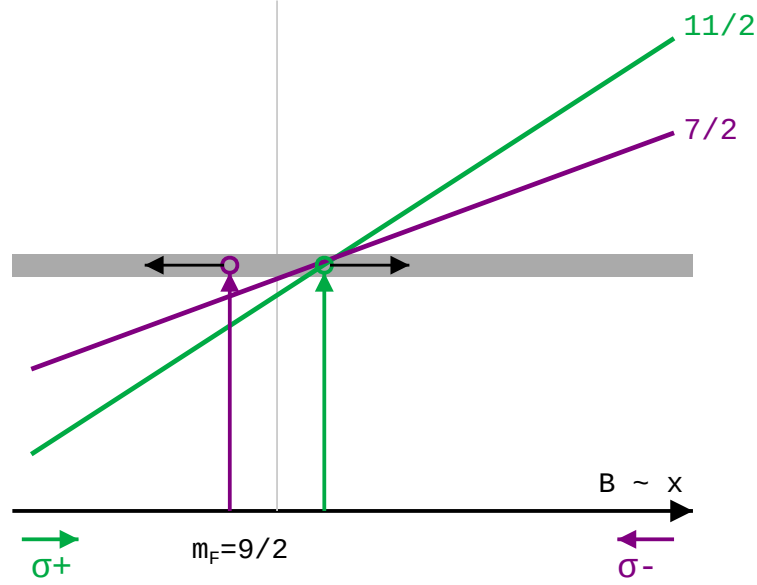


Figure 1.14: (Adapted from [30]) Illustration of the MOT effect on the  $m_F$  states of the hyperfine  $^3P_1, F = 11/2$  level. The position-dependent Zeeman shift brings the two counter-propagating beams into resonance with different  $m'_F$  sub-levels ( $\sigma^+$  with the closed transition to  $m'_F = 11/2$ ,  $\sigma^-$  with the open transition to  $m'_F = 7/2$ ) at the same position. The imbalance between the two processes, set by their Clebsch-Gordan coefficients, still favors restoring trapping locally (see text); the actual loss mechanism is discussed below.

The actual loss mechanism therefore appears when an atom finds itself on the *wrong* side of the trap for its  $m_F$  state. There, neither beam can come into resonance with it at all: the restoring force for an atom in  $m_F = 9/2$  is maximal on one side of the trap only, and on the other side this atom is lost from the trap entirely [30]. This is especially detrimental for the stretched states  $m_F = \pm 9/2$ , whose cycling transition is *closed* and which therefore have no spontaneous decay path to another  $m_F$  state that could rescue them once on the wrong side.

A dedicated stirring laser mitigates this geometric loss by driving the open  $^1S_0(F = 9/2) \rightarrow ^3P_1(F = 9/2)$  transition, superimposed on the trapping light and red-detuned such that its resonance region overlaps with that of the trapping transition (Fig. 1.15, left panel, akin to Fig. 2.8(d) of [30]). Because the differential Zeeman shift of  $F' = 9/2$  is about five times smaller than that of  $F' = 11/2$  [30], driving this transition changes both where and how broadly each  $m_F$  state can come into resonance: the resonance position shifts, potentially restoring resonance for atoms otherwise stuck on the wrong side of the trap, and the resonance region in  $x$  broadens by the same factor, making it far more likely that an atom actually scatters enough photons near resonance to be redistributed before drifting away. Since this  $F' = 9/2$  transition is open, each excitation-decay cycle can additionally redistribute the atom into a different  $m_F$  sub-level of the ground state.

In our implementation, we additionally sweep the stirring laser's frequency in a sawtooth pattern over time (Fig. 1.15, right panel): at any instant, the fixed instantaneous frequency is simultaneously resonant with several  $(m_F, x)$  pairs across the trap (left panel), and as the frequency sweeps, the ground-state  $m_F$  population is continuously and randomly redistributed. This continuous optical pumping brings atoms that would otherwise remain trapped in an unfavorable  $m_F$  state on the wrong side of the trap back within reach of the cycling transition, restoring efficiency to the cooling cycle.

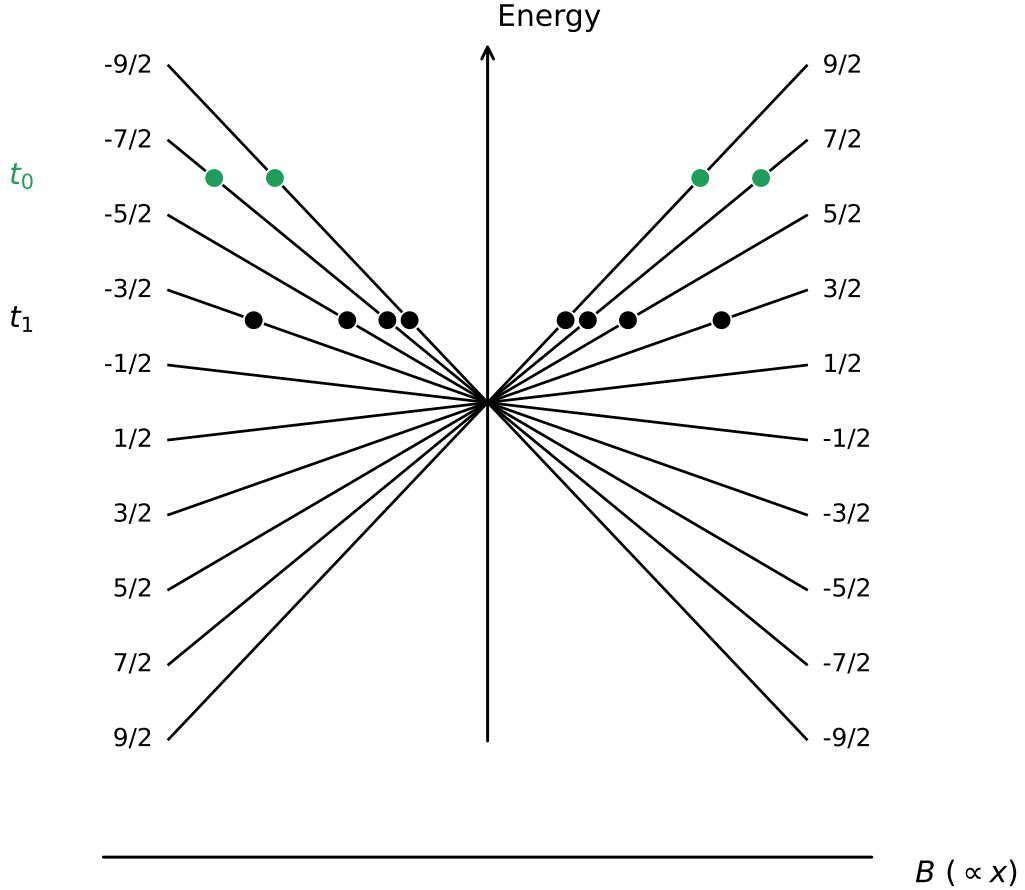


Figure 1.15: Spatial dependence of the resonance condition on each  $m_F$  sub-level, as a function of position  $x$  ( $B \propto x$ ) – adapted from the principle illustrated in Fig. 2.8(d) of [30]. Right: the stirring laser's frequency, swept in a sawtooth pattern *over time* in our implementation. At each instant  $t_0$ , the instantaneous frequency (right) is simultaneously resonant with several  $(m_F, x)$  pairs (left, black dots); sweeping this frequency over time thus randomizes the  $m_F$  population across the whole trap.

While the broadened resonance region alone increases the fraction of the trap addressed by the stirring light at any given detuning, a single, fixed stirring frequency still only brings each  $m_F$  state into resonance over a finite, localized range of positions around its own resonance point  $x_{\text{res}}(m_F)$ . An atom in a given  $m_F$  state located outside this window at a given time is simply not addressed, and nothing guarantees that its thermal motion within the trap will ever bring it there. In our implemen-

tation, we therefore additionally sweep the stirring laser's frequency in a sawtooth pattern over time (Fig. 1.15, right panel): as the frequency ramps, the resonance position  $x_{\text{res}}(m_F, t)$  for each  $m_F$  sweeps continuously across the trap, so that every  $m_F$  state is brought into resonance at every position over the course of one ramp. This guarantees full coverage of the  $(m_F, x)$  phase space, rather than relying on the atom's own motion to bring it within reach of a fixed, broadened resonance window.

#### 1.1.6.4 Narrowband MOT (Single-frequency MOT)

Once the cloud is sufficiently cold, frequency modulation is switched off to operate a single-frequency (monofrequency) MOT during a magnetic field ramp to  $V_D = 0.70$  ( $\Delta B \simeq 2.5$  G/cm). This stage reduces the temperature to 1–2  $\mu\text{K}$  (near the recoil limit) with a peak density of  $n \simeq 10^8$  at/cm<sup>3</sup> and a size of 30  $\mu\text{m}$ .

#### 1.1.6.5 Optimization of narrowband MOT Parameters

Cooling efficiency during the single-frequency stage depends on precise frequency, intensity, and timing parameters:

- **Broadband modulation amplitude:** The initial sweep covers  $\Delta f = 6$  MHz on the atoms to capture the Doppler distribution from the blue MOT.
- **Intensity ramp and power broadening:** High intensities  $I/I_{\text{sat}} = 400$  to 1600 provide a deep trap for initial capture, but causes power broadening ( $\Gamma_{\text{eff}} = \Gamma\sqrt{1 + I/I_s}$ ), raising the achievable Doppler limit. For single-frequency cooling, intensity is adiabatically ramped down over 45 ms to reduce power broadening while maintaining sufficient force to support the cloud against gravity.

### 1.1.7 Optical Dipole Trap (ODT) and evaporative cooling

#### 1.1.7.1 Loading the crossed ODT

Atoms are adiabatically loaded into the ODT while decreasing the intensity of the single-frequency 689 nm red MOT during a ramp lasting approximately 45 ms. From second-order perturbation theory, the light shift experienced by the energy levels yields the optical dipole potential:

$$U_{\text{dip}} = -\frac{\hbar|\Omega|^2}{4\bar{\Delta}} \quad (1.8)$$

[3], where  $1/\bar{\Delta} = 1/(\omega_{\text{laser}} - \omega_{\text{atomic}}) - 1/(\omega_{\text{laser}} + \omega_{\text{atomic}})$  is the effective detuning factor, and  $\Omega^2 = \frac{\Gamma^2}{2} \frac{I}{I_{\text{sat}}}$  is the Rabi frequency.

As seen from these expressions, the AC Stark shift induced by the dipole laser is state-dependent. As illustrated in Fig. 1.16, the potential estimated in [3] is deeper for the ground state  $^1S_0$  ( $U_{\text{dip}}(^1S_0) \simeq -1.5$  MHz) than for the excited state  $^3P_1$  ( $U_{\text{dip}}(^3P_1) \simeq -1.2$  MHz) at the center of the trap, resulting in a differential blue-shift of the  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_1$  transition (black line) compared to the frequency the atoms feel from the red MOT (red curve).

At the center, this shrinking gap is red-detuned from the MOT, enabling efficient cooling and confinement there. Away from the center, the laser is blue-detuned from

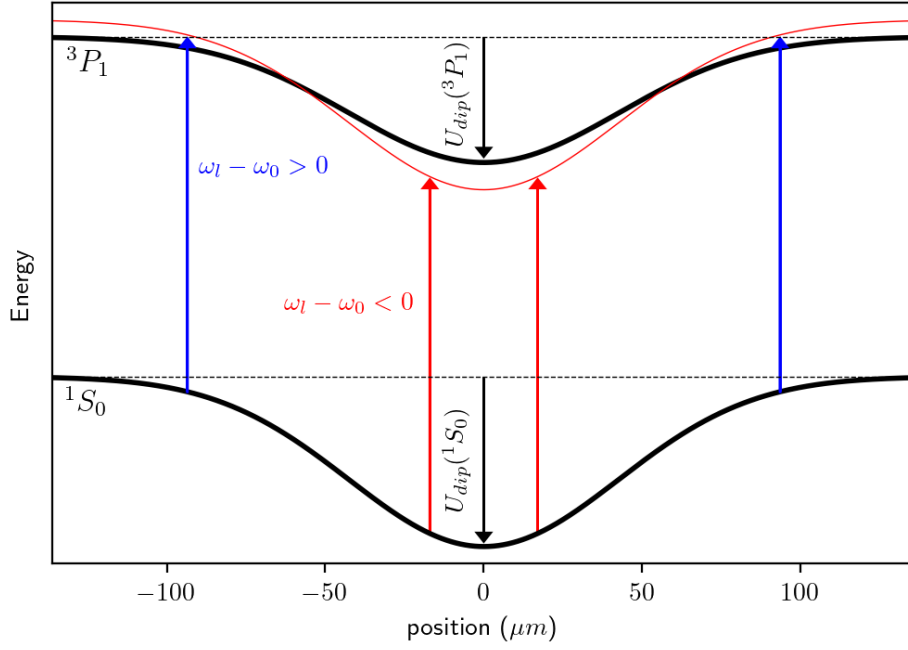


Figure 1.16: Simulation extracted from [3]. Principle of localized 689 nm MOT loading inside the crossed optical dipole trap due to the differential AC Stark shift between  $^1S_0$  and  $^3P_1$ .

the trap which gives kinetic energy to the atoms accumulated at the edges of the ground state trap: these are the ones with the most kinetic energy we want to get rid off to reach ultracold temperatures.

Following loading, the 689 nm red MOT is switched off, and forced evaporative cooling is performed purely by progressively lowering the ODT depth: the most energetic atoms overcome the (now shallower) potential barrier and escape the trap, while the remaining ones re-thermalize to lower temperatures via elastic collisions (Fig. 1.17). Incidentally, as the trap depth decreases, the differential AC Stark shift also shrinks, so the local transition frequency at the trap center relaxes back toward its unperturbed value – though since the MOT laser is off at this stage, this drift plays no role in the evaporation dynamics itself.

The results presented in the following two chapters were obtained with an atomic cloud located at the intersection of a horizontal beam, called the “Reservoir” (waist  $w_0^H = 150 \mu\text{m}$ ), and a vertical beam, called the “Dimple” (waist  $w_0^V = 80 \mu\text{m}$ ). The vertical beam axis is tilted at an angle of  $\simeq 30^\circ$  relative to the vertical to facilitate the escape of the hottest atoms from the trap.

In Chapter 2, the horizontal arm is tilted by  $\simeq 1^\circ$ . For the photoassociation results in Chapter 3, this tilt was canceled: it enables to have bigger volumes to trap the atoms from the crossing of the two arms (see 1.1.7.2).

Both  $^1S_0$  and  $^3P_1$  are shifted downward by the dipole trap potential, but  $^1S_0$  experiences a larger shift due to its higher polarizability, so the energy difference between the two states is way more important at the center of the trap than on the edges. The atoms addressed by the red MOT laser at the center of the trap are cooled with

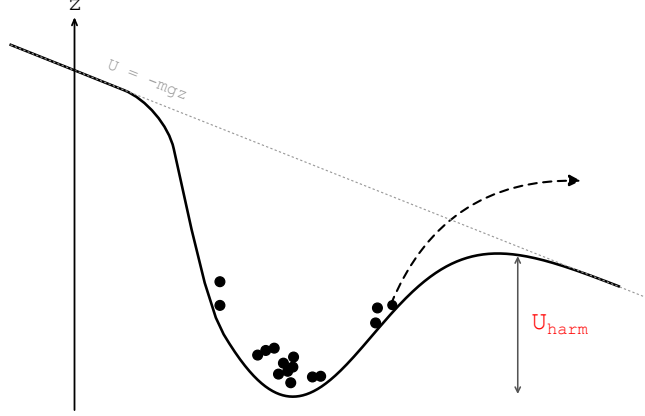


Figure 1.17: Evaporative cooling mechanism in a crossed optical dipole trap, illustrating the escape of high-energy atoms and subsequent re-thermalization.

the red-detuned laser while the slightly blue-detuned laser is heating the atoms with the more kinetic energy – located at the edges of the harmonic potential of the ODT – in order to keep only the coldest atoms.

#### 1.1.7.2 Optimization of the evaporation ramps

For a degenerate Fermi gas, the key parameter to optimize is the phase-space density (PSD), which scales as  $\text{PSD} \propto N\bar{\omega}^3/T^3$ , where  $N$  is the atom number,  $\bar{\omega}$  the geometrically averaged trap frequency, and  $T$  the temperature. While both arms of the dipole trap influence these parameters, their main physical contributions differ:

- **Tight vertical beam (“Dimple”):** Writing the atom number as  $N = nV$  (where  $n$  is the spatial density and  $V$  the trap volume), the elastic collision rate scales as  $\Gamma_{\text{el}} = n\sigma_{\text{el}}v_{\text{th}}$  with  $\sigma_{\text{el}}$  the elastic collision cross section and  $v_{\text{th}}$  the thermal speed of the atoms, enhancing collision rates for fast re-thermalization. This beam impacts mostly the temperature of the gas since it acts on the collision rate. The tightly focused waist of the dimple beam mainly dictates the local horizontal confinement, and contributes negligibly to the vertical confinement due to its near-vertical propagation axis [31].
- **Broad horizontal beam (“Reservoir”):** Owing to its narrow vertical waist, the reservoir beam sets the effective trap depth  $U$  against gravity-assisted atom loss, thereby controlling the evaporative truncation of the energy distribution and, in turn, the atom number [31]. Increasing the reservoir depth raises both  $N$  (less truncation, more atoms retained) and  $T$  (less evaporative cooling), and these two effects largely cancel out in the  $N/T^3$  ratio: the reservoir therefore has a much weaker net effect on the PSD than the dimple, whose action on  $\bar{\omega}^3$  is not compensated by an opposite change in  $N$ . Therefore the reservoir compensates alone the gravity effect on the cloud.
- **Ramp duration and adiabaticity:** The duration and adiabaticity of the evaporative ramps depend on the targeted state. Short evaporations are preferred when aiming solely for a large atom number at moderate temperatures

when it is necessary to detect atom number fluctuations, such as for our experiments on photoassociation (see Chapt.3). Conversely, reaching deep quantum degeneracy requires a multi-stage ramp lasting approximately 7 seconds which was necessary for the results of Chapt.2.

For further details on loading atoms into the optical crossed dipole trap, the reader is referred to the thesis of A. Litvinov [3]. An additional optical lattice, formed by a 1064 nm ALS laser, was initially implemented to enhance the phase-space density (PSD) of the atomic cloud prior to forced evaporative cooling. While this configuration was employed for the experiments presented in Chapter 2, it was subsequently discarded due to intensity fluctuations in the laser that induced significant heating.

### 1.1.7.3 Optical setup

The 1075 nm light from the IPG laser is split by a half-wave plate and polarizing beamsplitter into the two arms described above (Fig. 1.18). The horizontal arm forms the “Reservoir” beam: a pair of cylindrical lenses ( $f = -50$  mm and  $f = -75$  mm) shapes the elliptical beam into an anisotropic ellipse, with nominal waists of  $w^h = 147$   $\mu\text{m}$  (horizontal) and  $w^v = 34$   $\mu\text{m}$  (vertical) at the lens focal plane. However, the atoms sit  $\simeq 3.3$  mm beyond this focus rather than at the waist itself, so that the vertical waist they actually experience is somewhat larger,  $w^v \simeq 47$   $\mu\text{m}$ , while the horizontal waist remains close to its nominal value at this distance. The second arm forms the “Dimple” beam, focused by a spherical lens ( $f = 300$  mm) and crossing the reservoir arm at the position of the atoms, at  $\simeq 30^\circ$  from vertical; astigmatism in this arm means its two transverse waists are not equidistant from the atoms either (measured at  $\simeq 4.5$  mm and  $\simeq 7$  mm, respectively).

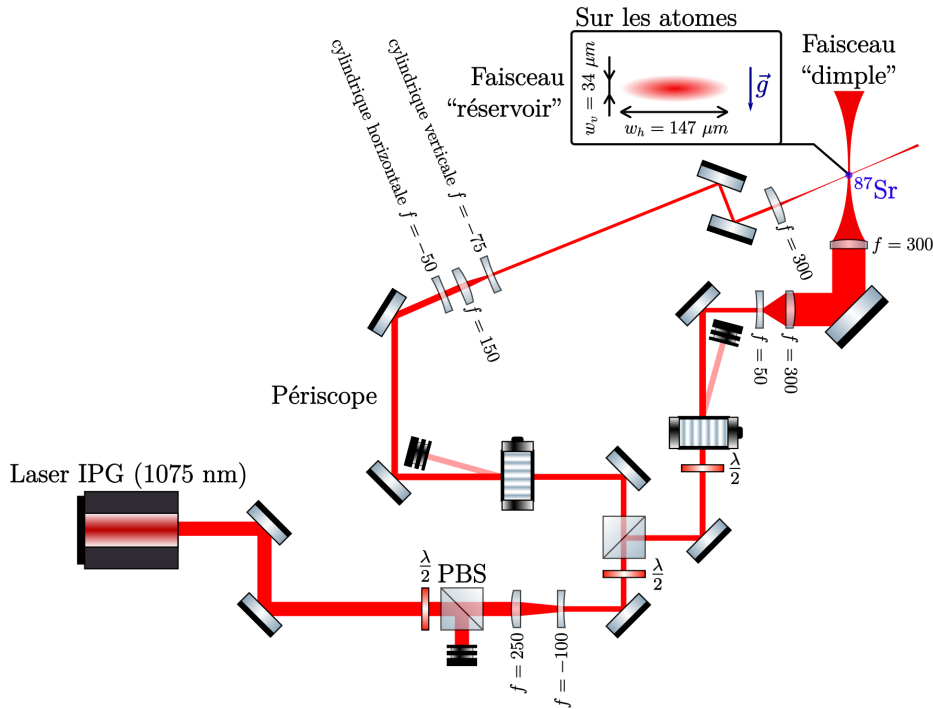


Figure 1.18: Optical setup of the 1075 nm crossed dipole trap laser system.

For the photoassociation measurements presented in Chapter 3, quantum degeneracy

is not required, and a high atomic density is favored instead; these experiments are realized with 400 000 atoms of spread  $\sigma \simeq 100 \mu\text{m}$  at a few  $\mu\text{K}$ , as introduced above.

## 1.2 Spin Selection

### 1.2.1 Optical Pumping

Optical pumping is implemented prior to the final evaporation stages to prepare the atomic gas in a tailored mixture of nuclear spin states ( $m_F$ ). Due to the  $SU(N)$  symmetry of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ , elastic  $s$ -wave collisions between identical fermions in the same  $m_F$  state are forbidden by the Pauli exclusion principle. Therefore, at least two distinct spin components must be present to enable elastic collisions and ensure efficient re-thermalization during evaporative cooling. Furthermore,  $SU(N)$  symmetry guarantees that elastic collisions conserve the nuclear spin state, preventing spin-exchange collisions during evaporation.

To perform state preparation, a bias magnetic field of  $6.05 \pm 0.05 \text{ G}$  is applied to lift the degeneracy of the  $^3P_1, F = 11/2$  hyperfine sub-levels via the linear Zeeman effect. The cloud is illuminated by a  $\sigma^-$ -polarized optical pumping beam tuned to the  $^1S_0(F = 9/2) \rightarrow ^3P_1(F = 11/2)$  transition. Its frequency is defined as:

$$f_{11/2} = f_{\text{Radiant Dyes}} \pm f_{\text{Slave 1}}^{\text{RF}} + f_{11/2}^{\text{RF}} \quad (1.9)$$

The sign goes depends on the wanted spin manipulation experiment (more details in chapter 3). The laser frequency is swept across 200 kHz around the targeted  $^3P_1, F = 11/2, m'_F$  sub-level – to compensate for day-to-day energy shifts arising from experimental fluctuations – depleting the corresponding  $^1S_0, F = 9/2, m_F$  ground-state population over about 5 ms at an intensity of  $\simeq 70 I_{\text{sat}}$ . Spontaneous emission, governed by the electric-dipole selection rule  $\Delta m_F = 0, \pm 1$ , then redistributes the excited atoms into adjacent, lower-lying ground-state sub-levels, leading to a progressive accumulation of population in the target spin states.

To prepare a specific mixture (e.g., a 2-spin mixture), unwanted spin populations are sequentially pumped out. One spin component, typically  $m_F = -9/2$ , is intentionally retained alongside the target mixture to maintain two-body elastic collisions for thermalization during evaporation. Once evaporative cooling is complete, this auxiliary component can be selectively removed using a short **'blast'** pulse. Under  $\sigma^-$  excitation on the  $F = 9/2 \rightarrow F' = 11/2$  transition, the  $m_F = -9/2$  state couples exclusively to  $m'_F = -11/2$ . Because no  $m_F = -11/2$  ground state exists, spontaneous emission from  $m'_F = -11/2$  can only decay back to  $m_F = -9/2$ , forming a closed cycling transition. The resulting continuous photon scattering exerts a strong radiation pressure that expels the  $m_F = -9/2$  population from the trap without disturbing the target single state or mixture. In practice, the blast pulse frequency is swept over a narrow range through resonance (rather than held fixed) to make the removal insensitive to small drifts in laser frequency or magnetic field calibration [23].

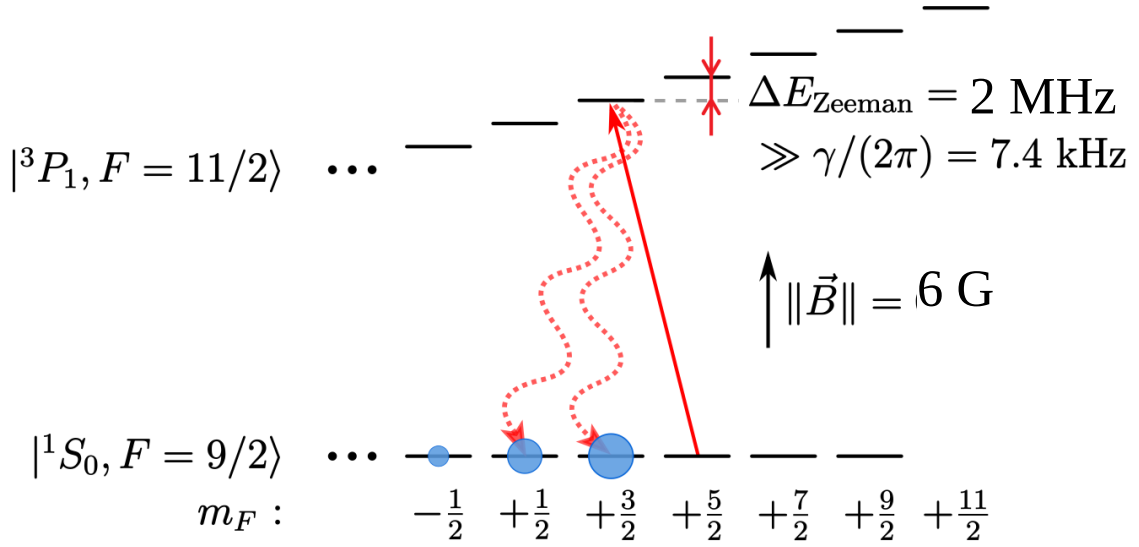


Figure 1.19: Optical pumping scheme on the  $^1S_0(F = 9/2) \rightarrow ^3P_1(F = 11/2)$  transition used to prepare a specific nuclear spin mixture. The red laser is ramped through the target energy level of  $^3P_1$ : the atoms decay to neighbours states  $m_F \pm 1$  of  $^1S_0$

## 1.3 Lasers for spin Manipulation

We developed a method demonstrated in [23] for coherent control within the ground state manifold of zeeman sublevels. it relies on tensor shifts enacted by a laser operating near 689 nm, and will be described in detail in chapter 2. At a later stage, we performed photoassociation experiments in the vicinity of the intercombination manifold, see chapter 3. Both experiments actually rely on the same laser system, that I will present here.

### 1.3.1 External Cavity Diode Laser (ECDL)

#### 1.3.1.1 Laser architecture

The spin-selective method presented in the article [23] reveals the importance of inducing a Tensorial Light Shift (TLS) to be added to the Zeeman degeneracy lift.

For this purpose, an External Cavity Diode Laser (ECDL) from MOGlabs was chosen, whose architecture is shown in Fig. 1.20. A diode operating near 689 nm is first collimated by a collimation lens, before its frequency is roughly selected by an interference filter. The beam is then focused by a cat's-eye lens onto a partially reflective mirror placed at its focus – represented by the dashed rectangular shape on the scheme. Together, this lens and mirror form a **cat's-eye retroreflector**: it compensates for any tilt of the wavefront introduced by the mirror, which would otherwise cause a loss of mode-matching with the light re-injected into the diode, and it closes the external cavity used to narrow and fine-tune the laser frequency. Most of the light reflected on the mirror sustains this resonant cavity, while the small transmitted fraction is collimated by an output lens and leaves the laser head through an optical isolator, with a linewidth below 100 kHz.

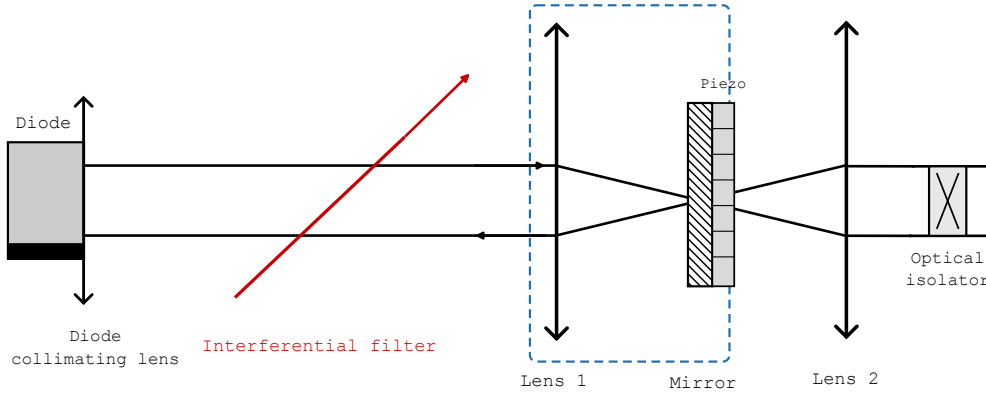


Figure 1.20: MOGlabs External Cavity Diode Laser (ECDL) architecture used for spin manipulation. A diode lasing at 689 nm is first collimated by a lens, then its frequency is roughly selected by an interference filter marked in red. The beam is focused by a second lens onto a partially reflective mirror (hatched rectangle): together they form a cat’s-eye retroreflector that closes the external cavity, feeding most of the light back for resonant frequency filtering while transmitting a small fraction onward. This output is collimated by a last lens and leaves the laser head through an optical isolator.

An internal PID controller robustly compensates for thermal and mechanical drifts of the cavity length as well as diode current fluctuations. The laser is subsequently beat-locked to a master optical reference adapted to the specific experimental requirements.

### 1.3.1.2 Problems encountered on the MOGlabs ECDL

For years, this ECDL exhibited a recurring instability that directly affected our experiments. We operate this laser far above threshold, at a fixed, high diode current chosen to maximize its output intensity on the external-cavity mode we lock to on a daily basis. As intracavity losses accumulated with time, however, the laser’s entire mode spectrum – the current-dependent map linking diode current to wavelength and output intensity – drifted: at this same fixed operating current, the mode we needed was no longer the one giving maximum intensity, so the laser no longer delivered its usual output power on the intended wavelength. Rather than changing the operating current, we instead had to open the laser head and reduce the intracavity losses; lowering the laser’s threshold in this way shifted the whole mode spectrum back, restoring the correspondence between our fixed operating current and maximum output intensity on the intended mode. This drift was eventually traced to two independent hardware issues, both responsible for a progressive loss of intracavity intensity:

- the interference filter had developed damage at its center, degrading the transmission of the light. It was replaced with a new filter supplied by the manufacturer.
- one of the cavity’s three piezoelectric actuators had failed. The full cat’s-eye assembly was therefore replaced with an MGEF adapter featuring a wider-

range frequency piezo.

Even after these repairs, a slow residual drift of the threshold persisted, now on a timescale of several days rather than hours. Gluing the cat's-eye assembly to the mount holding the diode and interference filter helped reduce this residual drift further, and keeping the laser switched off when not in use also limits it. If the stable mode eventually becomes inaccessible within the available diode current range, the threshold can still be lowered by gently adjusting the knobs of the mount holding the diode barrel. Because this realignment procedure slightly displaces the output beam, we added two optical fibers at the laser output: fiber coupling preserves the alignment to the rest of the spin-manipulation optical setup regardless of small beam-pointing changes.

## 1.3.2 Optical bench for coherent Raman manipulations

### 1.3.2.1 Physical Concept

The second chapter of this thesis focuses on spin manipulation within the  $SU(10)$  manifold of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ . This operation is realized via a two-photon Raman process driven by two laser beams red-detuned from the  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_1$  intercombination line.

Controlling the dimension of the effective Hilbert space from 1 to 10 requires independent addressing of individual spin states. The two-photon Rabi frequency  $\Omega$  coupling two ground-state sub-levels  $|g, m_F\rangle$  and  $|g, m'_F\rangle$  through intermediate excited states  $|e\rangle$  takes the form:

$$\hbar\Omega = \sum_e \frac{\langle g, m'_F | \vec{d} \cdot \vec{E}_2^* | e \rangle \langle e | \vec{d} \cdot \vec{E}_1 | g, m_F \rangle}{\Delta_e} \quad (1.10)$$

where  $\vec{d}$  is the dipole operator,  $\vec{E}_1, \vec{E}_2$  are the electric field amplitudes, and  $\Delta_e$  is the single-photon detuning relative to the intermediate state  $|e\rangle$ .

By applying the TLS, the energy difference between two consecutive spin projections  $m_F$  and  $m_F + 1$  becomes non-linear:

$$\Delta E_{m_F}^{m_F+1} = q(2m_F + 1) + \beta \quad (1.11)$$

where  $q$  parameterizes the quadratic (tensor) light shift and  $\beta$  represents the linear Zeeman contribution. This explicit dependence on  $m_F$  lifts the energy degeneracy between adjacent transitions, allowing spectral isolation and individual control of any given  $m_F \leftrightarrow m_F + 1$  pair.

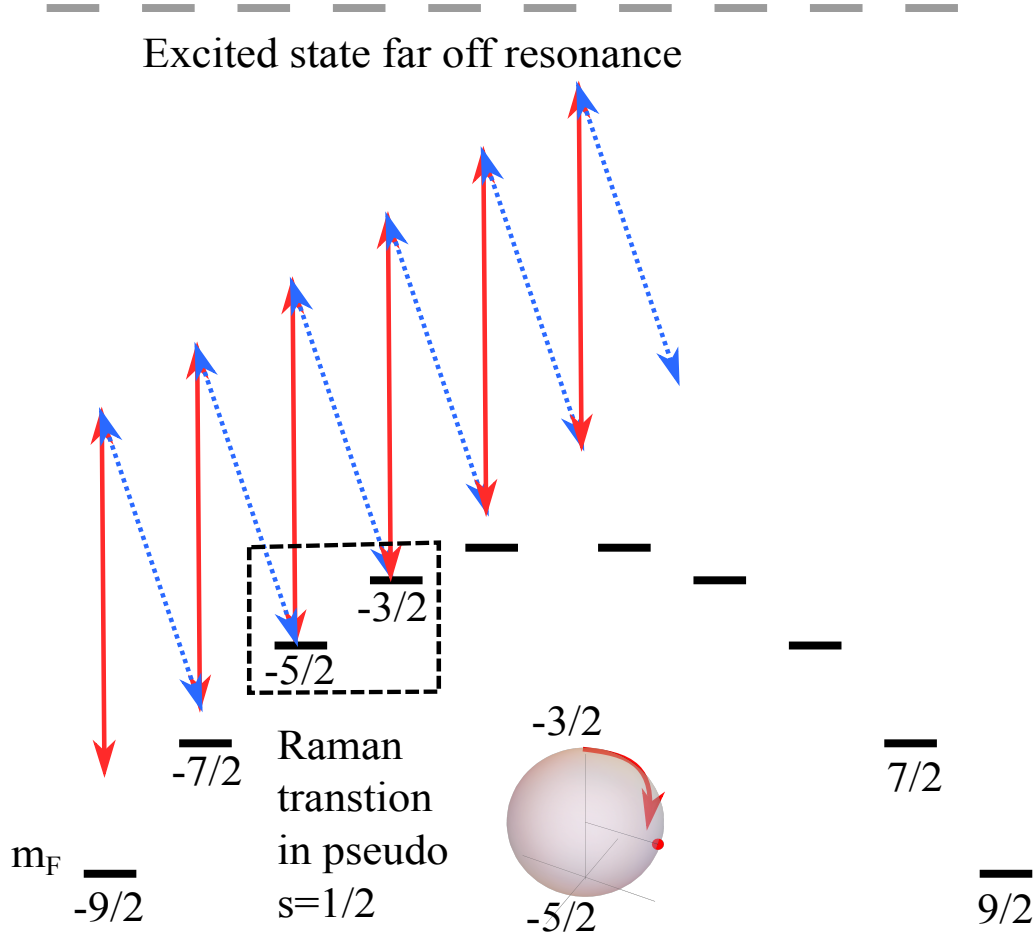


Figure 1.21: Spin manipulation scheme of [2]. The isolation of spin states is allowed by the tensorial shift of the ground states that makes neighbours  $m_F$  states isolated from the other resonances. The Bloch sphere represents the reduced Hilbert space of the selected qubit.

For more details this process is discussed in the second chapter of this thesis and also in the article of the group [23].

### 1.3.2.2 Experimental setup of the Raman and PA process

The two-photon process is driven by two distinct beams: a first beam derived from the “AOM TLS” laser (shown in red in Fig. 1.22) generates the TLS and supplies the first photon. A second beam, frequency-shifted by the “AOM Raman” (shown in blue), completes the Raman transition.

The TLS beam polarization is set parallel to the magnetic field ( $\pi$  transitions), producing a purely scalar/tensor light shift with no vector component. The Raman beam polarization is linear and orthogonal to the magnetic field, so that its decomposition onto  $\sigma^+$  and  $\sigma^-$  components drives the required  $\Delta m_F = \pm 1$  legs of the two-photon transition – one photon absorbed from the  $\pi$ -polarized TLS beam, one photon emitted into the  $\sigma^\mp$  component of the Raman beam. Both beams are copropagating in the same polarization maintaining fiber with perpendicular polarizations preserving any interferences that could affect the process. This configuration selectively

couples a single pair of states—for instance,  $|^1S_0, F = 9/2, m_F = -7/2\rangle \leftrightarrow |^1S_0, F = 9/2, m_F = -5/2\rangle$ —while remaining far off-resonance for all other  $m_F$  states. The two-photon Raman coupling strength scales as  $\Omega_R \propto \sqrt{I_D I_R}$ , while the spacing between adjacent Raman resonances scales as  $2q/h \propto I_D$ . Spectral isolation of a single  $m_F \leftrightarrow m'_F$  pair therefore requires  $I_R \ll I_D$ , so that neighbouring resonances remain spectrally resolved; in practice we use  $I_R/I_D \lesssim 10^{-4}$  [2].

The complete optical path for this two-photon process, together with the filtering cavity described in Sec. 1.3.3, is shown in Fig. 1.22.

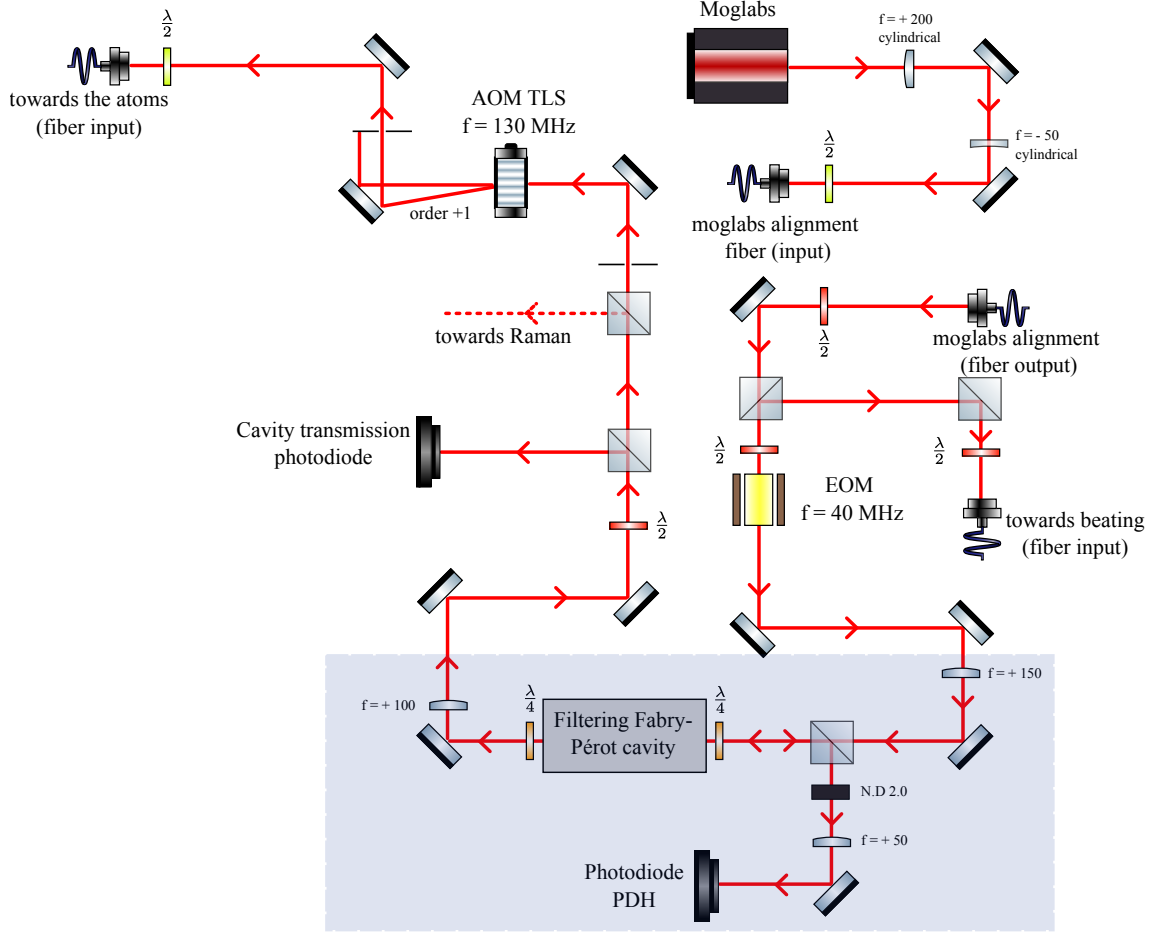


Figure 1.22: Complete optical setup including the Fabry-Pérot cavity and PDH stabilization loop.

To reduce amplified spontaneous emission (ASE) from the laser source – and thereby minimize stray light and photon-recoil heating during spin manipulation – the optical chain incorporates a custom-built, PDH-stabilized confocal Fabry-Pérot cavity, detailed in Sec. 1.3.3. The effect of the ASE has been observed by the heating of the gas while the laser was hundred’s of MHz off resonance of transitions where we expect really low spontaneous emission. This cavity was originally built with these Raman TLS experiments in mind; however, by the time its construction was completed the corresponding measurements had already been carried out, and the experimental effort had moved on to the photoassociation spectroscopy presented in Chapter 3 – for which the cavity turned out to be essential, given the higher

sensitivity of these measurements to stray light. It is intended to be used again for future extensions of the Chapter 2 spin-manipulation experiments.

### 1.3.3 Fabry-Pérot cavity and PDH Locking system

#### 1.3.3.1 Cavity design and assembly

A primary objective of the cavity injection scheme in our optical setup is to maximize overall transmission for spin manipulation. To achieve this, we constructed a confocal cavity configuration ( $d_0 = R_C$ , where  $d_0$  is the mirror separation and  $R_C$  is their radius of curvature), ensuring that all odd transverse modes are degenerate and resonate at the same frequency. If these modes were non-degenerate, off-resonance spatial components would be reflected at the input mirror, thereby reducing the total cavity transmission efficiency.

In addition to the confocal geometry, longitudinal mode resonance requires that the cavity length  $d_0$  satisfies the condition:

$$d_0 = n \frac{\lambda}{2} \quad (1.12)$$

where  $n$  is an integer and  $\lambda$  is the wavelength of the injection laser.

To fulfill these requirements, we selected curved mirrors with a diameter of  $D = 4.5 \pm 0.15$  mm and a radius of curvature matching  $d_0$ . The manufacturer specified a nominal mirror transmission of  $T_{\text{mirror}} = 1.28\%$ , though the effective system performance can be influenced by mechanical mounting constraints.

Proper cavity operation requires the mirrors to be aligned precisely parallel to each other and perpendicular to the optical propagation axis. In our initial implementation (Fig. 1.23 top), the mirrors were permanently glued into place. However, this approach introduced major technical issues over time: excess glue migrated onto the optical surfaces, degrading overall transmission, while alignment errors during gluing introduced an uncorrected angular tilt relative to the beam axis.

Because the original design provided no mechanical degrees of freedom to correct these misalignments, we redesigned the mounting mechanism. The updated cavity assembly is presented in Fig. 1.23 bottom. In this configuration, three adjustment knobs on a circular outer mount apply controlled pressure against the central cylindrical spacer housing the mirrors, with intermediate washers providing mechanical compliance. This allows for precise tilt control and fine adjustment of the mirror separation.

An additional parameter that has been adjusted during the construction is the mass of the mirrors: a first generation of the cavity has been constructed with heavier mirrors than actual ones, which presented mechanical resonance in the acoustic frequency range. The lock of the cavity was not robust. Then this new generation is made of smaller and light mirrors which pushes these resonances to higher frequency range we do not bother.

Once locked to the injection laser, the optimized cavity achieves a total power transmission efficiency of  $T = 0.63$ . This limited efficiency likely results from residual mechanical imperfections inherited from the original glued assembly: a slight angular mis-gluing of a mirror could tilt the cavity axis and cause part of the beam to

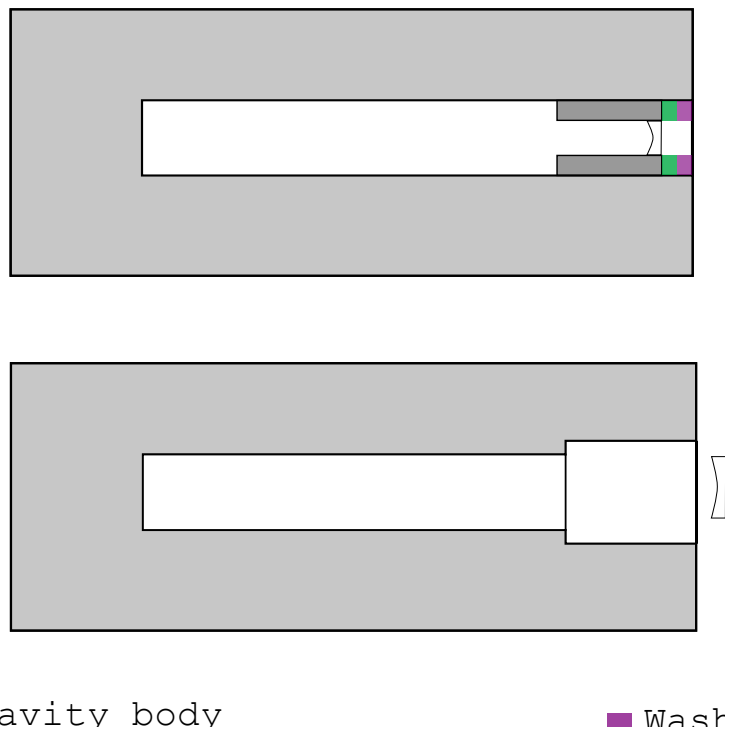


Figure 1.23: Top : Initial fixed cavity assembly using glued mirrors, lacking mechanical alignment degrees of freedom. Bottom : Upgraded and final cavity mount featuring three adjustment screws and compliant washers for precise angular and longitudinal alignment

clip inside the cavity, while leftover glue or dirt on the mirror surfaces could add further scattering losses. Despite this imperfect transmission, the cavity's spectral properties remain well characterized. The Free Spectral Range (FSR) of the cavity is given by:

$$\text{FSR} = \frac{c}{2d_0} = 3 \text{ GHz} \quad (1.13)$$

with a measured finesse of:

$$\mathcal{F} = \frac{\text{FSR}}{\delta\nu} = 310 \pm 15 \quad (1.14)$$

where  $\delta\nu$  represents the full width at half maximum (FWHM) of the transmitted resonance peak measured on a photodiode for the odd transverse modes.

### 1.3.3.2 Pound-Drever-Hall locking system and PID controller analysis

The cavity is frequency-locked to the laser using the Pound-Drever-Hall (PDH) technique, as detailed by Black [32] and schematized in Fig. 1.24. The scheme utilizes an Electro-Optic Modulator (EOM) to generate sidebands at frequencies  $f_0 \pm f_M$  around the optical carrier  $f_0$ , with a modulation frequency of  $f_M = 40.48 \text{ MHz}$ . The modulated electric field incident on the cavity is expressed as:

$$E_{\text{inc}}^{\text{mod}} \approx E_0 [J_0(\beta)e^{i2\pi f_0 t} + J_1(\beta)e^{i2\pi(f_0+f_M)t} - J_1(\beta)e^{i2\pi(f_0-f_M)t}] \quad (1.15)$$

where  $J_0(\beta)$  and  $J_1(\beta)$  are the zeroth- and first-order Bessel functions of the first kind, and  $\beta$  is the modulation index.

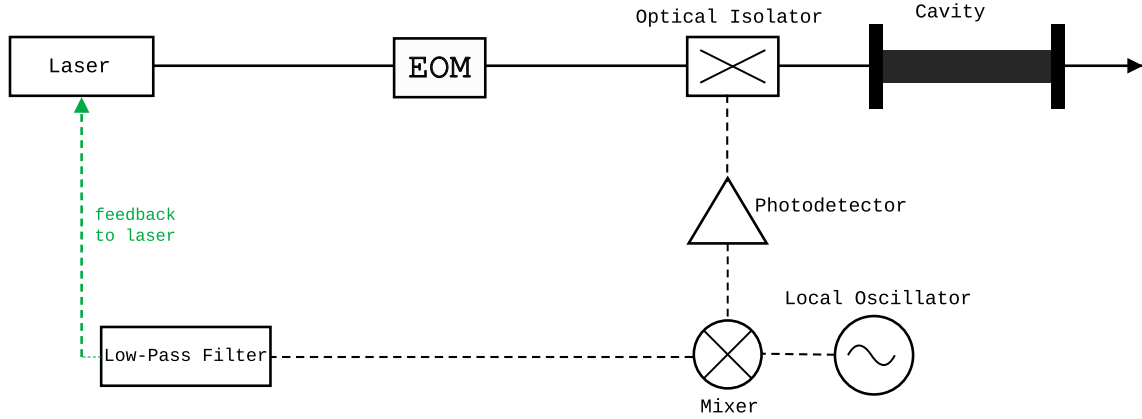


Figure 1.24: Schematic of the Pound-Drever-Hall locking system, extracted and adapted from [32]. The laser is firstly passing through an EOM that is modulating the electric field at frequency  $f_M$ , creating two sidebands at frequency  $f_{\text{laser}} \pm f_M$ . The carrier at  $f_{\text{laser}}$  and the sidebands are passing through the filtering Fabry-Pérot cavity which is reflecting the light going back to the entrance of the cavity. A beamsplitter serving as an optical isolator is reflecting the light to a photodiode. Then this signal is mixed with a local oscillator to extract an error signal to which a low-pass filter is combined to keep only the signal for the locking.

The carrier enters the cavity and acquires a steep, frequency-dependent phase shift near resonance, whereas the sidebands are promptly reflected from the input mirror.

The interference between the reflected carrier and the sidebands is detected on a fast photodiode, demodulated at  $f_M$ , and low-pass filtered to extract the dispersive error signal (Fig. 1.25). The sharp linear slope around resonance provides a robust error signal highly sensitive to the sign of the frequency excursion. From this graph, one measures a signal-to-noise ratio of  $\text{SNR} = 187$ . Interestingly, the sideband resonance features were not distinctly visible on the scanning error signal, even when driving the EOM with a high modulation depth to maximize the  $J_1/J_0$  ratio.

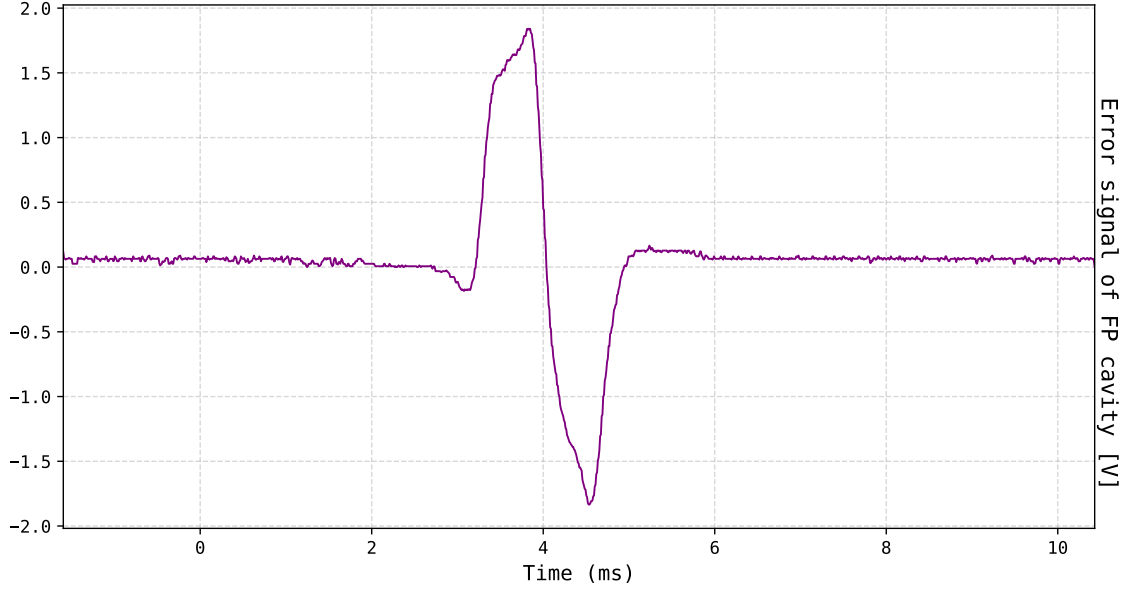


Figure 1.25: Pound-Drever-Hall (PDH) error signal obtained by scanning the cavity length across resonance, enabling the lock cavity for the filtering of MOGLabs laser.

Digital feedback control and noise analysis were implemented primarily using a Red Pitaya STEMLab board, driving a home-made PID controller with separate proportional and integral stages (Fig. 1.26), which we found sufficient for our setup. The PID parameters were optimized by injecting a broadband electronic noise signal into the cavity piezo driver and measuring the closed-loop transfer function. As seen in the frequency response plot (Fig. 1.27), operating the system with specific gain values excites mechanical resonances at low frequencies, with at 3 kHz the electronical bump that has similar amplitude for every gain but that is pushed to higher frequencies while the gain increases. Consequently, the final feedback loop acting on the cavity incorporates a low-pass filter with a cut-off frequency of  $f_c = 40$  kHz, a proportional gain strictly bounded between  $1 < K_p < 10$ , and an integral gain configured between  $0 < K_i < 8 \text{ s}^{-1}$ .

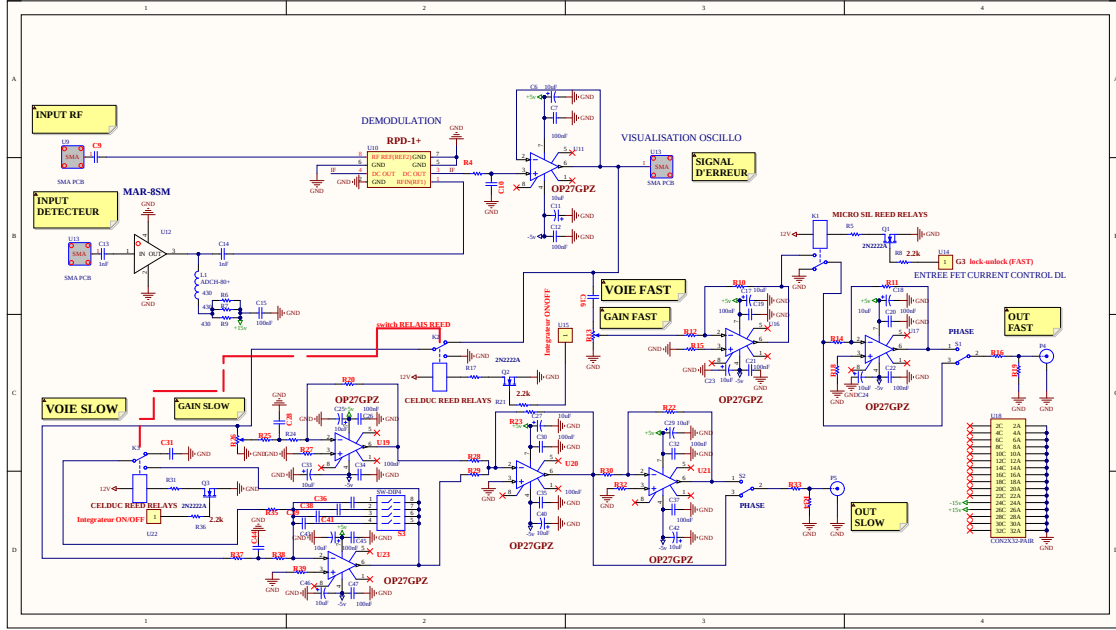


Figure 1.26: Homemade PID scheme constructed by the Fabrice Wiotte from electronic workshop of LPL. It is composed of separate proportional and integral stages, which we considered sufficient for our setup.

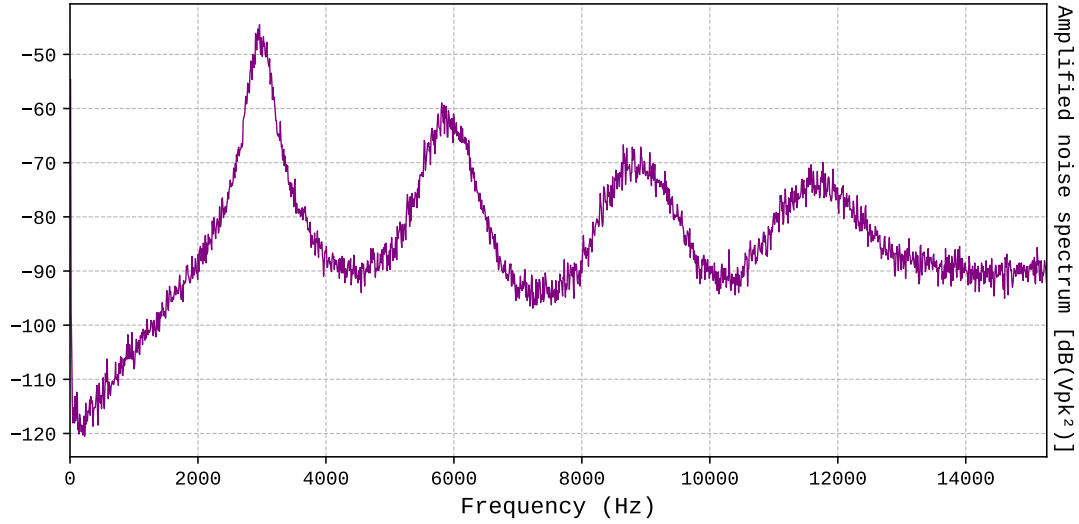


Figure 1.27: Closed-loop noise analysis and mechanical resonance identification using the Red Pitaya with a gain that is amplifying parasitic noise, such as the mechanical resonance of the piezo at  $f = 35$  kHz.

## 1.4 Spin Measurement Scheme

Total atom numbers are determined via standard absorption imaging on the broad  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^1P_1$  transition at 461 nm using a Vortex laser. State-resolved spin detection follows the momentum-transfer (“spin-kick”) technique detailed in [2].

The measurement sequence proceeds as follows:

1. Atoms are illuminated by a vertical, retro-reflected laser beam with opposite circular polarizations ( $\sigma^+/\sigma^-$ ), as illustrated in Fig. 1.28(a), addressing the  $|^1S_0, F = 9/2\rangle \rightarrow |^3P_1, F = 11/2\rangle$  transition at an intensity of 5 mW/cm<sup>2</sup>, giving Rabi couplings  $\Omega \simeq 2\pi \times 220$  kHz (scaled by the relevant Clebsch-Gordan coefficients). A magnetic field of 16 G is applied along the beam propagation direction, splitting adjacent  $m'_F$  sub-levels of  $^3P_1, F = 11/2$  by 6.0 MHz – far larger than the 7.4 kHz transition linewidth. The atoms are held against gravity in a weakly confining (125 Hz) horizontal dipole trapping beam during the momentum transfer.
2. A state-selective pulse tuned to a specific  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_1, F = 11/2, m_F$  transition –in the presence of linear Zeeman shift– adiabatically transfers targeted spin populations (Fig. 1.28(b)). The laser frequency is swept, with decreasing frequency only, over a span of 1.4 MHz within 300  $\mu$ s.
3. Each absorption-stimulated emission cycle imparts a coherent  $2\hbar k$  momentum kick to the selected  $m_F$  state.
4. Following a time-of-flight (TOF) expansion duration  $t = 6.6$  ms (set for the gas to stay in camera plane), spatial separation between spin components is observed in the absorption image (Fig. 1.28(d)).

Unaddressed spin states remain at the central position of the cloud. In contrast, states subject to the momentum transfer form distinct spatial wavepackets shifted to the left or right depending on the direction of the resonant momentum kick (e.g.,  $m_F = -3/2$  and  $m_F = -7/2$  in Fig. 1.28(d)).

To ensure efficient population transfer, the optical pulse sweep rate must satisfy the adiabaticity criterion across the avoided crossing between coupled adiabatic states (Fig. 1.28(c)).

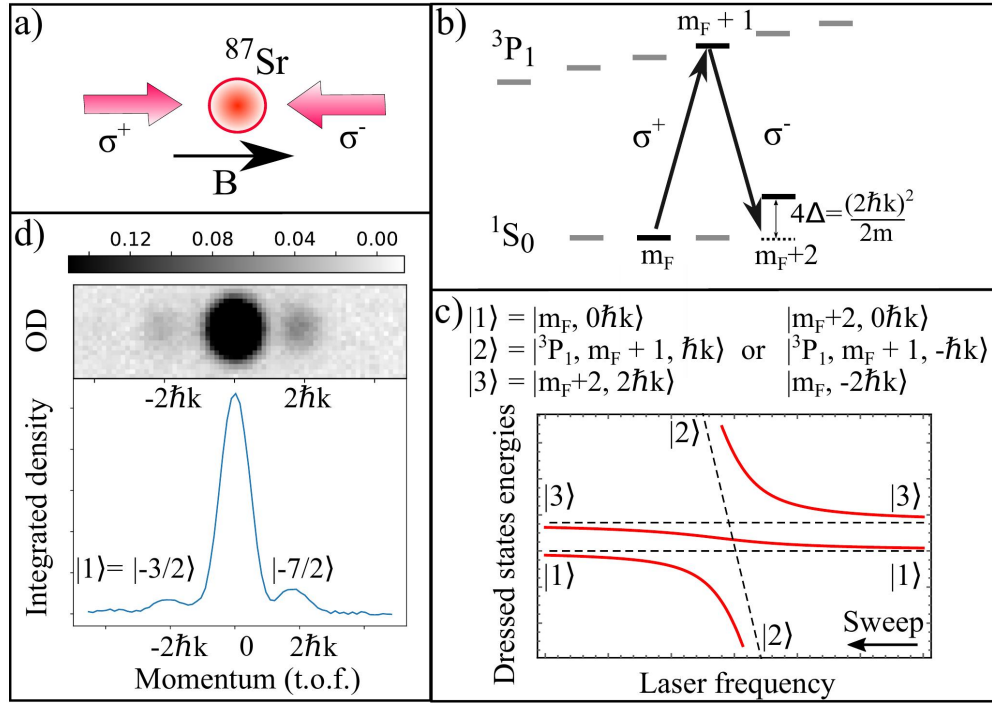


Figure 1.28: Principle of spin-selective detection via coherent momentum transfer. (a) Counter-propagating beam geometry of the lasers used for the TLS and two-photon Raman scheme. (b) Energy levels scheme of the Raman process, with recoil energy shifting the  $m_F + 2$  level. (c) Avoided crossing due to the coupling of the states, necessitating adiabatic transfer. (d) Resulting TOF absorption image showing spatially separated spin components and the corresponding momentum distribution.

# Chapter 2

## Quantum state measurement and characterization in qudit systems

This chapter presents the experimental results published in Ref. [1], centered on the coherent manipulation of the 10-dimensional nuclear spin Hilbert space ( $2I+1 = 10$ ) of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  atoms. By exploiting a tensor light shift to isolate tailored subsystems, we demonstrate control ranging from robust pseudo-spin qubits to high-dimensional qudits ( $D = 3$  to 10) displaying multi-second coherence times. Based on this platform, we implement multi-state interferometric schemes over four nuclear levels for multi-parameter sensing. Following section 2.1.1 reproduces article, Section 2.2 is written for this manuscript and provides an extended theoretical derivation of the Positive-Operator-Valued Measures (POVMs) implemented in our non-commuting observables measurement scheme.

### 2.1 Article ‘Coherent control over the high-dimensional space of the nuclear spin of alkaline-earth atoms’ [1]

#### 2.1.1 Gas preparation and spin control

Large-spin particles open new possibilities for quantum technologies. In the context of quantum many-body physics and quantum simulators, the enlarged spin degrees of freedom correspond to a significantly larger Hilbert space, which leads to qualitatively new physics [33, 34, 35, 36, 37, 38, 39]. Large spins can also enhance quantum information processing [40] and quantum metrology [41, 42, 43, 44]. Conveniently, they emerge from several physical platforms, such as superconducting devices [45, 46], molecular magnets [47], ions [48], multi-mode photons [49], and atoms [50, 51].

Among large-spin atoms, fermionic alkaline-earth and alkaline-earth-like atoms (AEA) are particularly interesting for quantum metrology because they display a weak sensitivity to magnetic fields and possess narrow optical transitions that make them prominent for optical clocks with cold atoms [52]. These atomic species are also remarkable for quantum many-body physics, as the purely nuclear nature of their

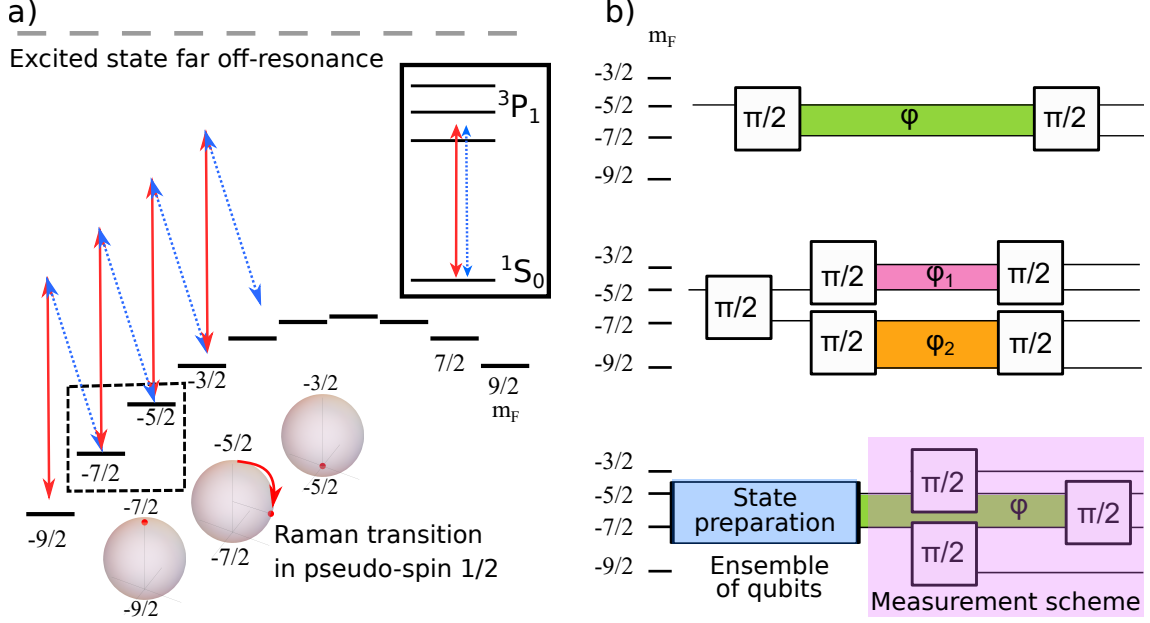


Figure 2.1: **Principle of the experiment.** (a) Atomic levels and laser coupling scheme. A  $\pi$ -polarized light beam tuned within the hyperfine structure of the  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_1$  transition (red arrows) creates an energy shift in the electronic ground state, with significant tensor component  $U_{TLS}(m_F) = q m_F^2$ . A second laser (here  $\sigma^-$  polarized) enables Raman transitions. Thanks to the tensor light shift, the Raman resonance conditions differ from each other, making it possible to drive Rabi oscillations between two isolated spin states (here  $|-5/2\rangle$  and  $|-7/2\rangle$ ), all other processes being off-resonant. The Raman operation can be understood as a rotation in a sub-Bloch sphere. A potential linear energy shift  $U_{linear}(m_F) = b m_F$  (in the illustration,  $b \simeq -3q$ ) does not directly affect the capacity to isolate a pair of states. (b) The three experimental schemes in this paper. Top: We operate a Ramsey interferometer between states  $|-5/2\rangle$  and  $|-7/2\rangle$ , decoupled from the other spin states. Middle: We operate two interferometers in parallel, demonstrating multi-parameter simultaneous sensing of the fields acting on the atoms. Bottom: we characterize the collective state of atoms in a superposition of two Zeeman levels ( $|-5/2\rangle$  and  $|-7/2\rangle$ ), identified as qubit states. The measurement sequence starts by applying two pulses that map the populations of the qubit states into ancillary states. Combining this with a final rotation in the qubit sub-Bloch-sphere, one can simultaneously measure two orthogonal components of the pseudo-spin of the ensemble of qubits.

spin in the ground state generates an  $\mathfrak{su}(N)$  symmetry that introduces frustration and should thus strongly impact quantum magnetism [53]. This possibility has attracted considerable attention from both theoretical [54, 55, 56] and experimental [35, 57, 58, 59] standpoints. To exploit the full potential of large-spin fermionic alkaline-earth atoms and to characterize the  $\mathfrak{su}(N)$  phases at low temperatures, it is crucial to develop tools that coherently control the spin states of atoms beyond simple spin precessions (see [60, 23, 61]).

In this paper, we use a tensor light shift [62] to control the resonance conditions of Raman transitions within the manifold of  $2F + 1 = 10$  Zeeman states of the spin- $F = 9/2$  ground state of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ . The quadratic energy shift  $\propto m_F^2$  enables

us to perform coherent manipulations between isolated pairs of  $m_F$  states with a fidelity better than 99 %. These operations demonstrate control over unitary transformations deriving from  $\mathfrak{su}(N = 2F + 1)$  generators, beyond the usual precession operations deriving from the spin- $F$  representation of the  $\mathfrak{su}(2)$  group. Taking advantage of this new possibility and the atoms' insensitivity to magnetic fields, we operate a Ramsey interferometer between two isolated hyperfine states and demonstrate Ramsey fringes with no discernible loss of contrast over 3s. We further exploit the large spin of the atoms with two new types of interferometers. In the first implementation, we operate two Ramsey interferometers simultaneously and in parallel, using two independent pairs of spin states within the hyperfine structure. This configuration allows simultaneous measurement of two independent parameters (here corresponding to the effective quadratic and linear Zeeman shifts). In the second implementation, we mirror two physical spin states that make a qubit into two ancillary spin states. Selective unitary transformation ("rotation") of the two qubit states and the measurement of all four states then permit the simultaneous measurement of two non-commuting observables of an ensemble of qubits.

### 2.1.2 Implementation of $\mathfrak{su}(N)$ generators.

One key idea of this paper is to implement coherent rotations between two and only two arbitrary spin states chosen among the  $N$  spin states of an  $N$ -component Fermi mixture. Rabi oscillation between such a selected pair of states corresponds to rotations driven by infinitesimal generators of the  $\mathfrak{su}(N)$  spin algebra, described by an operator  $\sigma_{m_F, m'_F}^x$ . The restriction of  $\sigma_{m_F, m'_F}^x$  to the Hilbert space  $\{|m_F\rangle, |m'_F\rangle\}$  is the Pauli matrix  $\sigma^x$ , while all its other elements are zero. The evolution operator after a sequence reads  $\sim \exp(-i\theta\sigma_{m_F, m'_F}^x/2)$ , where  $\theta = \int \Omega_R(t)dt$  is called pulse area and  $\Omega_R$  is the Rabi frequency. The evolution operator describes a rotation in the restricted Hilbert space associated with the two selected spin states, and is the identity in the orthogonal space consisting of all other levels. Thus, it is distinct from the more usual manipulation of a spin  $\vec{F}$  by precession around a magnetic field,  $\exp(-i\vec{\alpha}\cdot\vec{F})$ , which involves a combination of the three generators  $\vec{F} = (F_x, F_y, F_z)$  of the spin- $F$  representation of the  $\mathfrak{su}(2)$  algebra. This new tool enables complete control over the spin degrees of freedom, which is necessary to characterize phases of  $\mathfrak{su}(N)$ -symmetric quantum matter at low energy (see e.g. [63]) and for computing applications leveraging the vast Hilbert space provided by large spins (see e.g. [40]).

It is challenging to intuitively represent the state of large-spin atoms and the  $\mathfrak{su}(N)$  generators of rotations we implement since a spin  $F > 1/2$  possesses a rich inner structure that the usual Bloch sphere fails to represent fully. This structure can be captured by, for example, the Majorana stellar representation [64] (see also [65, 66, 67]). However, the motion of the Majorana stars driven by coherent manipulations is generally quite complicated and does not always allow a clear physical interpretation. Qualitatively,  $4F$  angles ( $2F$  points on a sphere) are sufficient to describe the state. A simple representation, that can be well-suited to visualize some of our interferometric experiments, is to consider each two-level sub-space of adjacent Zeeman levels  $(m_F, m_F + 1)$  in a Bloch sphere representation and consider the set of  $2F = N - 1$  Bloch spheres as a representation of the state. For each Bloch sphere, the latitude represents the relative populations while the longitude represents the relative phase of the spin wavefunction in the two relevant states.

Experimentally, we perform rotations on a sub-Bloch sphere between selected pairs of nuclear-spin states, either  $m_F \longleftrightarrow m'_F = m_F + 1$  or  $m_F \longleftrightarrow m'_F = m_F + 2$  - see Fig. 2.1. To this end, we introduce two-photon Raman couplings. We rely on a quadratic dependence of the light shift as a function of  $m_F$  (tensor light shift, TLS), to resonantly drive only one of the two-photon resonances, whereas the other couplings are off-resonant and have negligible impact on the atomic state evolution. Provided the Raman coupling is much smaller than the TLS, we can spectrally resolve any pair of  $m_F$  states (with  $\Delta m_F = 1, 2$ ), beyond what was achieved by the approach in Ref. [61], which only allowed coherent oscillations between  $m_F = F$  and  $m_F = F - 1$  (or  $m_F = -F$  and  $m_F = -F + 1$ ). Our work is thus analogous to the proposal in Ref. [68] but with Raman couplings instead of radio-frequency couplings between adjacent Zeeman sublevels. It is also very similar to the experiment on the solid-state platform in Ref. [47], where a hyperfine interaction, instead of an external field, lifts the degeneracy.

Pulsing the Raman coupling drives precession on one selected sub-Bloch sphere around the x axis (by phase convention). Furthermore, at any time, all of the sub-Bloch spheres experience  $\sigma_z$  precession at different rates determined by the detuning of the Raman beat note (controlled by an RF local oscillator) to the corresponding two-level transition. In this article, we explore three independent interferometric schemes restricted to a given Hilbert subspace (see the right panels of Fig. 2.1). They illustrate the new possibilities for quantum sensing or simulation that emerge when using simple combinations of coherent rotations between pairs of spin states, complementing previously demonstrated schemes using large-spin atoms [41, 44, 67]).

The intercombination line  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_1$  of the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  isotope is particularly favorable to engineer large tensor shifts with only weak spontaneous emission, thanks to the high ratio of about  $10^5$  between the hyperfine splitting in  $^3P_1$  and the inverse lifetime of these hyperfine states [69]. Using the much narrower  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_2$  transition might lead to even better performances. Our scheme should readily adapt to other alkaline-earth-like atoms and to other species with similarly rich electronic structures (Yb, Cd, Hg, Er, Dy, ...). Finally, compared to the recent results in Ref. [70, 71], where the spins of erbium and strontium atoms, respectively, are manipulated through coherent oscillations on a narrow optical transition, our scheme also benefits from *not* relying on a clock-like optical transition. This, we achieve because the Raman transitions negligibly populate lossy excited states.

### 2.1.3 Experimental setting

All the experiments described in the following sections start with a spin-polarized ultracold Fermi gas of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ . To produce this gas, we first laser cool and hold within a dipole trap a 5  $\mu\text{K}$ -cold sample of atoms in the  $5s^2^1S_0$  ground state, fully depolarized across the ten spin states of the  $F = 9/2$  manifold. We then use optical pumping on the  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_1$ ,  $F = 11/2$  intercombination line to empty all spin states but two (typically, the  $m_F = -9/2$  and  $m_F = -5/2$  states). We thus prepare a stable spin mixture since the  $\mathfrak{su}(N)$  symmetry prevents spin-changing collisions. Ref. [23] gives more details on this optical pumping. We next use forced evaporative cooling to obtain an ultracold gas at a temperature of about

100 nK. Finally, we apply a state-selective radiation-pressure pulse to remove atoms in the  $m_F = -9/2$  state, with no noticeable heating of the remaining  $m_F = -5/2$  sample. We achieve such state selection by a 4.5 ms light pulse tuned to the  $|^1S_0, m_F = -9/2\rangle \rightarrow |^3P_1, F = 11/2, m_F = -11/2\rangle$  transition in a magnetic field of 4.5 G. The polarized gas, of about  $10^4$  atoms, is then kept in a uniform magnetic field  $B\vec{e}_z$  with  $B = 5.2$  G that defines the quantization axis and produces a linear Zeeman splitting of 960(5) Hz. With less than 1% of the atoms in each Zeeman state other than the one chosen, the residual spin entropy is below 0.5 (while a fully random spin state has entropy  $\log(10) = 2.3$ ).

After this preparation, we coherently manipulate the atoms' nuclear spin using an external-cavity laser diode whose frequency is tuned within the hyperfine structure of the  $^3P_1$  state, 600 MHz to the red of the  $|^1S_0, F = 9/2\rangle \rightarrow |^3P_1, F = 9/2\rangle$  line. We produce two phase-coherent laser beams with independently controlled frequencies from a single laser split into two paths with independent single-pass acousto-optic modulators. The first beam's primary role is to engineer a quadratic energy shift  $U_{TLS}(m_F) = q m_F^2$  of the Zeeman states labeled by their spin projection  $m_F$ . We will refer to this beam as the "Tensor Light Shift (TLS)" beam. The second beam, labeled the "Raman" beam, acts together with the first (in most of the paper) to drive Raman transitions between two Zeeman states when their frequency difference matches the energy difference between states. We drive the AOMs using two AD9852 direct digital synthesizers synchronized on a shared 20 MHz clock. The beam frequency difference thus has a long term relative instability directly set by the shared clock (RIGOL DG1022), at the 5 ppm level. They are recombined on the same path with orthogonal linear polarizations through a single-mode optical fiber before being sent onto the atoms with a beam waist of 320  $\mu\text{m}$ . This configuration also renders recoil effects negligible.

We set the TLS beam polarization almost co-linear to the magnetic field, corresponding to  $\pi$  transitions in this quantization axis. We ramp its power up to typically 5 mW in 3.5 ms, slowly enough that the atoms' spin state adiabatically follows the slight change of quantization axis. We stabilize the beam intensity to a sub-percent level at the millisecond timescale, using a photodiode positioned after the beam has crossed the atoms. The Raman beam polarization is linear and orthogonal to the magnetic field, allowing  $\sigma^+$  and  $\sigma^-$  transitions. Throughout this article, we mainly apply  $\delta m_F = 1$  spin-changing Raman transitions from absorption and stimulated emission of one  $\pi$  photon from the TLS beam and one  $\sigma^-$  photon from the Raman beam. By setting the two-photon detuning resonant with such transitions, the  $\sigma^+$  Raman beam photons only drive widely off-resonant processes thanks to the TLS beam's quadratic shift  $U_{TLS}(m_F)$  and ultimately remain spectators. Moreover, the  $\sigma^-$  transitions addressed by the Raman laser have higher Clebsch-Gordan coefficients and coupling strengths when manipulating  $m_F < 0$  states. In an alternative scheme, the Raman laser is bichromatic, and drives alone  $\delta m_F = 2$  two-photon spin-changing transitions using its two circular polarization components. The two optical frequencies are generated on the same AOM by a bichromatic RF drive, produced by frequency mixing.

At the end of an experiment cycle, we adiabatically ramp down the TLS beam and measure the spin-state distribution by spin-selective momentum transfer [23], simultaneously extracting and probing two spin states of choice ( $m_F - 1$  and  $m_F + 1$ )

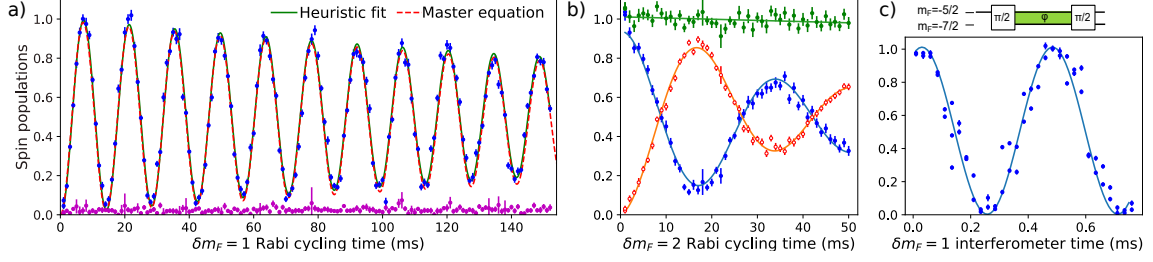


Figure 2.2: **Encoding a qubit on two nuclear spin states.** a) Rabi oscillations between  $m_F = -3/2$  (blue) and  $m_F = -5/2$  (not shown), driven by a  $\delta m_F = 1$  Raman coupling. Here  $\hbar\Omega_R/2q$  is small enough that the neighboring states  $m_F = -7/2$  (magenta) and  $m_F = -1/2$  (not shown) are unaffected. The green line is a heuristic fit to the data with a damped sine, yielding a  $1/e$  damping time of 298 (17) ms. The dashed red line is the result of a master equation simulation with two adjustable parameters: the Raman coupling strength and the coherences decay rate. It is almost indistinguishable from the damped sine. (b) Rabi oscillations between  $m_F = -3/2$  (blue, filled circles) and  $m_F = -7/2$  (red, empty circles) driven by a  $\delta m_F = 2$  Raman coupling. Green dots show the total population in these two states. Both populations are measured simultaneously. Solid lines are fits with damped sinusoidal oscillations, yielding a  $1/e$  damping time of 40(5) ms. (c) Ramsey interferogram realized between states  $m_F = -7/2$  (blue dots) and  $m_F = -5/2$ , driven by a  $\delta m_F = 1$  Raman coupling. The line is an optimal distance regression fit with a sinusoidal interferogram. In all of this figure, each data results from a single shot, and error bars reflect the population measurement statistical uncertainty. Furthermore, in plots (a) and (b), the detection efficiencies  $\eta(-3/2)$  are slightly recalibrated to bring maximal  $m_F = -3/2$  population estimates down to 1.

for each measurement. Spin populations presented throughout the paper are relative to the total atom number. For this, we calibrate the detection efficiencies  $\eta(m_F)$  for each spin state on clouds prepared in that single spin state. For  $m_F = -7/2$ ,  $-5/2$ , and  $-3/2$ , we find  $\eta(m_F) = 0.65$ ,  $0.70$ , and  $0.51$ , respectively<sup>a</sup>. However,  $\eta(-3/2)$  fluctuated throughout the experiments shown here, as evidenced by some population estimates larger than one. In such cases, we recalibrate  $\eta(-3/2)$  by up to 6 % to bring extremal population estimates down to 1.

### 2.1.4 Coherent manipulation of a nuclear-spin qubit

*Rabi oscillations between two isolated hyperfine states.* We now turn to the experimental demonstration of coherent manipulations between selected pairs of states within the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  ground state manifold, which realizes evolutions driven by  $\mathfrak{su}(N)$  generators  $\sigma_{m_F, m'_F}^x$  and  $\sigma_{m_F, m'_F}^z$ . We first show Rabi oscillations between two Zeeman sublevels, then characterize the coherence of quantum superpositions by Ramsey interferometry.

We first demonstrate Rabi oscillations with  $\delta m_F = 1$ . To this end, we prepare the gas in the  $m_F = -5/2$  state and turn the quadratic light shift on  $U_{TLS}(m_F) = qm_F^2$ . For  $\delta m_F = 1$  Raman transitions, this splits the resonance conditions of the various

<sup>a</sup>The detection efficiencies are probably limited by a lack of optical power and by using rather warm clouds with momentum spread comparable to the optical recoil.

Raman processes by multiples of  $2q/h$  ( $h$  is the Planck constant). Consequently, as illustrated in Fig. 2.1, tuning the Raman beam frequency to one of the resonance conditions (e.g., the process  $-5/2 \rightarrow -3/2$ ) produces a state evolution that can be approximated as generated by a Pauli operator coupling two and only two states. To reach this regime, the separation between adjacent resonances  $2q/h$  (proportional to the TLS beam intensity  $I_{TLS}$ ) must be larger than the two photon Raman coupling strength ( $\Omega_R \propto \sqrt{I_{TLS}I_R}$ , where  $I_R$  is the Raman beam intensity), which implies  $I_R \ll I_{TLS}$ . In practice we use  $I_R/I_{TLS} \leq 10^{-4}$ .

In the presence of the TLS beam, we pulse the Raman beam at a fixed frequency and monitor the spin state evolution. In Fig. 2.2a, we demonstrate the Rabi oscillation dynamics driven between the states  $m_F = -5/2$  and  $m_F = -3/2$ . Here  $q/h = -320$  Hz and  $\Omega_R/2\pi = 71$  Hz. We observe well-pronounced coherent oscillations with a short-time contrast consistent with 1, while the population in the neighboring, not targeted state  $-7/2$  grows by less than 1% over almost 11 Rabi oscillations. The amplitude of the oscillations exhibits a slow exponential decrease with a characteristic time  $\tau_{decay} = 298(17)$  ms  $\simeq 21 \frac{2\pi}{\Omega_R}$ . As we do not observe significant population diffusion to other states, this damping rate limits the fidelity of a  $\pi/2$  pulse to 0.994. The shot-to-shot fluctuations of the Rabi pulse area away from  $\pi/2$  (calibrated from complementary experiments) are even less limiting to the fidelity ( $> 0.998$ ). This demonstration of an evolution well approximated by  $\exp(-i\theta\sigma_{m_F, m_F+1}^x/2)$  constitutes a key result of this article, enabling the various experiments described in the following sections.

We also demonstrate Raman transitions with  $\delta m_F = 2$  using a slightly different scheme: we detune the Raman beam 1 MHz below the TLS beam and modulate its frequency in two sideband components (suppressing the carrier frequency). In this manner, its two opposed  $\sigma^\pm$  polarization components drive  $\delta m_F = 2$  transitions, with a detuning controlled by the modulation frequency. We performed this experiment at a much lower  $q/h = -95$  Hz (because of the aging of a laser component). In Fig. 2.2b, we observe the Rabi oscillation induced between the states  $-7/2$  and  $-3/2$ . The two spin populations, monitored in parallel, exhibit complementary oscillations at frequency  $\Omega_R/2\pi = 29(3)$  Hz with a damping time of 40(5) ms. The total population in the two states decays by 3% within the damping time, so the damping mainly reflects a loss of coherence, not diffusion to other spin states. The limit imposed by this damping on the fidelity of a  $\pi/2$  pulse can thus be estimated at 0.90, much lower than what we achieve on the  $\delta m_F = 1$  Raman processes. The cause of this more significant damping compared to the  $\delta m_F = 1$  coupling experiment is unknown - possibly the laser degrading, which also resulted in the lower value of  $q$ . Still, this experiment demonstrates a complementary set of two-level rotations. They are not required to have complete control over the atomic state, but, in principle, an extended set of generators of evolution can be advantageous for some manipulations (assuming similar fidelities). Furthermore, combining  $\delta m_F = 1$  and  $\delta m_F = 2$  transitions enables conceptually new kinds of experiments, such as engineering dynamics in a spin space with periodic boundary conditions, with phenomena related to Berry phases and non-Abelian gauge fields [72, 60]. In the remainder of the paper, we will use exclusively  $\delta m_F = 1$  transitions as the basic building block for interferometers.

*Coherence of the Rabi oscillations.* Let us characterize the coherence properties of

the nuclear qubit - first in the presence, then in the absence, of the Raman driving field. In the Rabi oscillations presented in Fig. 2.2a, each point is the outcome of an individual realization. The observed damping is seen without averaging different experimental realizations, which implies that it is associated with loss of coherence rather than fluctuations. This decoherence may result from a spatial inhomogeneity or from spontaneous emission. To establish which one dominates, we measure the heating rate of atoms exposed to TLS light in the dipole trap. We find it to be three times higher than the expected heating rate associated with spontaneous emission assuming the laser is monochromatic. We attribute this to a frequency noise pedestal in our laser spectrum due to amplified spontaneous emission (ASE) that causes *resonant* photon scattering. We then model the Rabi dynamics by a master equation describing the evolution of an atom in the laser and magnetic fields. We calculate the separate spontaneous emission terms from and to each spin state, such that the model captures decoherence and spin-state diffusion. To heuristically capture the effect of ASE, we scale these rates of coherence decay and spin diffusion by a factor of three. Typical coherence decay rates are  $\sim 1 \text{ s}^{-1}$ , and population transfer rates  $\sim 0.5 \text{ s}^{-1}$ . However, the simulation with these parameters does not produce the evolution observed in Fig. 2.2a, nor does artificially scaling the impact of spontaneous emission by a different factor. Instead, we note that there is TLS/Raman beam inhomogeneity, and empirically add a decay of coherences between spin states  $(m_1, m_2)$  with rate  $\Gamma_q \times |m_1^2 - m_2^2|$ . With  $\Gamma_q = 1.2 \text{ s}^{-1}$ , we recover excellent agreement with the data, as shown in Fig. 2.2a. We estimate independently, by simulations with a random distribution of  $(q, \Omega_R)$ , that the observed dynamics is consistent with an inhomogeneity of  $q$  and  $\Omega_R$  of about 1.2 % in standard deviation. Across a  $5 \mu\text{m}$ -radius cloud, this can be induced by a beam off-centered by  $w/4$ , where  $w = 320 \mu\text{m}$  is the waist.

*Coherence of the hyperfine qubit Ramsey interferometer.* We then test the coherence of the qubit in the absence of Raman drive. For this, we implement an interferometer. Keeping the TLS beam on, we apply a set of two resonant  $\pi/2$  pulses, separated by a temporal interval  $T$  - thus realizing a standard Ramsey sequence restricted to the Hilbert space of a qubit, see the top sequence schematic of Fig. 2.1b. During this time interval  $T$ , we alter the local oscillator frequency that controls the phase difference between TLS and Raman beams. The Ramsey interferometer is sensitive to the phase  $\phi$  defined by  $\frac{d\phi}{dt} = \Delta E_{m_F, m'_F}(t)/\hbar - \delta_{RF}(t)$ , where  $\Delta E_{m_F, m'_F}$  is the energy difference between the two qubit states and  $\delta_{RF}(t) = \omega_R - \omega_{TLS}$ . The quantities  $\omega_{TLS}/2\pi$  and  $\omega_R/2\pi$  are the (potentially time-dependent) TLS and Raman beam laser frequencies.

Figure 2.2c shows the fringe pattern as a function of  $T$  for qubits encoded in the two nuclear-spin states  $m_F = -5/2$  and  $m_F = -7/2$ . Here,  $q/\hbar = 190 \text{ Hz}$  and  $\Omega_R/2\pi = 93 \text{ Hz}$ . The well-resolved oscillations come from the accumulated differential phase in the qubit states, resulting in a rotation (controlled by  $T$ ) along the sub-Bloch sphere equator. We observe fully contrasted oscillations for the best data, which demonstrates that the coherence of the qubit is well preserved.

We now systematically study the contrast and noise of Ramsey interferometers as a function of  $T$  to characterize the sources of decoherence. We will highlight that the main detriment to the qubit's coherence is the TLS beam and that we can adiabatically remove it to recover coherence over seconds. We present this study in

Fig. 2.3. We focus on two effects: decoherence, which reduces the interferometric contrast, and phase fluctuations. In principle, the sources of fluctuations in the data are (i) atomic quantum projection noise; (ii) measurement uncertainties associated with fitting the spin-separated optical density pictures; (iii) reproducibility of the  $\pi/2$  pulses; iv) fluctuations of the phase integrated by the interferometers. For our data, the quantum projection noise (i) is smaller than the measurement noise (ii) by typically a factor of 3, so we neglect it. Fluctuations of the area of “ $\pi/2$ ” pulses (iii) are estimated from repeating a sequence without closing the interferometer. We find a standard deviation of the pulse area of 0.063(5) rad (which sets a fidelity upper bound for a  $\pi/2$  pulse at 0.999). However, their effect in a *closed* Ramsey sequence remains smaller than the measurement uncertainty. On the interferogram shown in Fig. 2.3b, we notice that the residuals to a sinusoidal model are much larger than the fluctuations expected from combining the effect of (i), (ii), and (iii). We attribute this to uncontrolled fluctuations of the interferometer phase. To estimate their RMS amplitude, we numerically generate trial noisy models of the experiment, including all sources of fluctuations, and compare them with the data<sup>b</sup>. In this optimization, the interferometric contrast and the variance of phase fluctuations are the adjustable parameters.

Fig. 2.3c and d show the outcome of this analysis. As shown in Fig. 2.3c, the contrast (defined as peak-to-peak signal amplitude) decays as a function of  $T$  with a  $1/e$  decay constant of 54(5) ms. Like the damping of Rabi oscillation, this decay most likely results from the TLS inhomogeneity rather than photon scattering. The observed decay is significantly faster than that of the Rabi oscillations seen in Fig. 2.2a. This illustrates the sensitivity of Ramsey interferometers, which are directly sensitive to detunings  $\Delta$ , in contrast to generalized Rabi frequencies, generically  $\sqrt{\Omega_R^2 + \Delta^2}$ .

A second observation is that a random phase is integrated for each realization of the interferometer. At the smaller dark time  $T = 5$  ms, its standard deviation is about 0.35 rad and gradually increases with  $T$ , as shown in Fig. 2.3d. It is about 1.4 rad after 100 ms. We attribute this to polarization fluctuations in the TLS beam, as we will demonstrate in Sec. 2.1.5.1. One could reduce these fluctuations by polarization filtering, although our setup, where we co-propagate the TLS and Raman beams in the same optical fiber, is inadequate for this.

Thus, simply removing the tensor light shift for most of the duration  $T$  of the interferometer should significantly mitigate decoherence and phase noise. After the initial Rabi pulse, we adiabatically turn off the TLS in 2 ms, and bring it back on in the last 2 ms before the second  $\pi/2$  pulse. The atom’s environment during the interferometer is now primarily the magnetic field and a dipole trap with negligible spin-dependent light shift. The observed decoherence is considerably suppressed, with no visible contrast decay after 3 seconds. The phase noise also grows with  $T$  at a much slower rate. Phase fluctuations of  $\simeq 0.3$  rad are acquired during the 4 ms with TLS, but the phase-noise contribution of the remaining time without light only reaches 1 radian after about 2 seconds. Although the RMS phase fluctuations are not exactly linear with  $T$ , they can qualitatively be interpreted as an insta-

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<sup>b</sup>We look for a trial model for which a least-square sinusoidal fit estimates the same amplitude and with the same residuals as the data. Note that the peak-to-peak amplitude of the sinusoidal fit is generally smaller than the contrast of the interferogram: an interferogram with complete loss of control over the phase will be fitted with zero amplitude and large residuals.

bility of the Raman detuning of  $\sim 0.08$  Hz when integrated (averaged) over two seconds. The frequency instability of the DDS-controlled  $\delta_{RF} = \omega_R - \omega_{TLS}$  is, in principle, one order of magnitude smaller. Thus, the phase noise probably reflects magnetic field fluctuations of about 0.4 mG at the second timescale, consistent with the specifications of the current supplies for the coils.

In this section, we have demonstrated coherent control of a qubit defined over two selected Zeeman sublevels using  $\sigma_{m_F, m_F+1}^x$ ,  $\sigma_{m_F, m_F+2}^x$ , and  $\sigma_{m_F, m_F'}^z$  rotations. Our demonstrations have been restricted to the manifold  $m_F \in \{-9/2, -7/2, -5/2, -3/2\}$ . Note that, when driving atoms in other states, we observed uncontrolled population transfers. We attribute this to the value of our magnetic field  $b \simeq -3q$ , which causes quasi-degeneracy and sign reversal of the Raman energy differences, see Fig. 2.1a. One could lift this issue and acquire complete control over the entire spin manifold, provided  $b > |q|(2F - 1)$ . Within the manifold of states used in this paper, we have shown the high sensitivity of the qubits' coherence and phases to the TLS beam fluctuations. Minimizing the exposure time to the TLS beam, we have demonstrated long-lived coherent superpositions over several seconds, without any magnetic shielding. Such coherence time is a feature of the minute Landé factor of the nuclear spins, basically immune to stray magnetic field gradients ( $g_I \mu_0 \nabla B < 10^{-4}$  Hz/ $\mu$ m), and of the extremely small vector and tensor polarisabilities in the closed-shell ground state, at the optical trapping wavelength (with spin-dependent shifts  $\simeq 10^{-4}$  Hz). It can be a great asset, e.g., for high-precision sensing in long-interrogation-time interferometers or quantum information storage.

### 2.1.5 Beyond pseudo-spin 1/2 schemes: qudit interferometry

The possibility to coherently couple two spin states among the  $N = 10$  available ones in ground-state  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  atoms enables coherent navigation over the whole ground-state manifold - for example, by simply concatenating a series of resonant pulses between isolated pairs of Zeeman states. Consequently, our experimental toolkit creates new possibilities that use more than two spin states in order to store or retrieve information. In this section, we experimentally investigate two of those new possibilities that use the large nuclear spin as a genuine qudit.

First, we will use well-defined linear-superposition states involving four spin states, in order to simultaneously measure more than one external field at each experimental realization. Such multi-parameter estimates are useful in the context of metrology [73]. Our work thus illustrates the potential of large-spin particles as original quantum sensors.

Second, we present a scheme that simultaneously measures collective observables that do not commute, in a single experimental realization. Building on Ref. [74], our scheme can characterize a many-body state where the coherences are stored in a subset of the fully available ground-state hyperfine manifold. The main idea is to extend the Hilbert space of the atoms for measurement purposes only; the measurement sequence involves mapping the state of the atoms into initially empty “ancillary” states and applying controlled rotations, which provides additional observables, and facilitates tomographic characterization of a quantum many-body state.

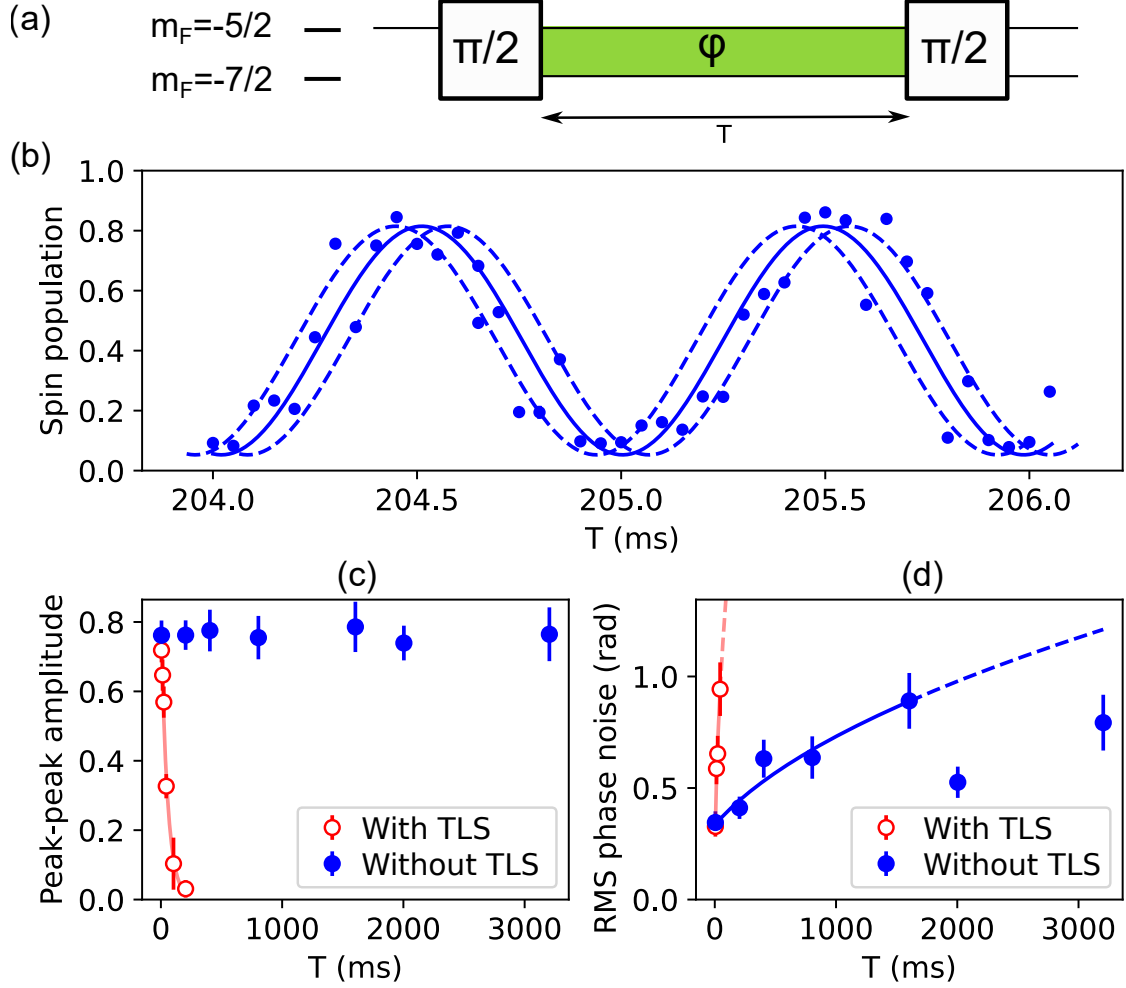


Figure 2.3: **Qubit coherence.** (a) Schematics of the interferometer. (b) Fringe pattern of a Ramsey interferometer operated between  $m_F = -5/2$  (measured) and  $m_F = -7/2$ , with, between the two pulses, 4 ms of exposition to TLS light and  $T-4$  ms of absence of any laser light. Error bars, combining population measurement uncertainty and expected impact of pulse area fluctuations, are comparable to the dots' size. The solid line is the underlying interferogram, barring phase fluctuations. The dashed lines interferograms are shifted by  $\pm$  one standard deviation of the phase fluctuations. (c) Contrast as a function of  $T$ . The red line is a fit to an exponential decay for the data with TLS beam on (red, empty circles), with  $1/e$  decay time of 54(5) ms. When the TLS beam is adiabatically turned off during the dark time (blue, filled circles), there is no observable contrast decay for at least 3 s. The shortest measured  $T$  (5 ms) corresponds to ramping down and almost immediately back up the TLS. (d) Phase noise of the interferometer as a function of  $T$ . Continuous lines are fits assuming  $Var(\phi) = \delta\phi_0^2 + Dt$ . We have  $\sqrt{D} = 0.14(1)$  rad/ms $^{1/2}$  with TLS, and  $\sqrt{D} = 0.021(2)$  rad/ms $^{1/2}$  without TLS.

### 2.1.5.1 Parallel Ramsey interferometers for simultaneous multiple-field sensing.

Performing simultaneous measurements using the same local quantum sensor is a new possibility with large-spin particles that is particularly interesting, for example, because the measurements can then benefit from common noise rejection (see

for example [75, 76, 77, 78]) or because it becomes possible to perform correlations analyses and thus learn from sources of noise (we will show an example in the following). Here, we present simultaneous measurements of two fields in each experimental realization. We drive two  $s = 1/2$  Ramsey interferometers in parallel, using two independent sets of pairs of Zeeman states within strontium's ground-state hyperfine manifold. Our scheme using sets of qubits *internally distributed* within the ground-state spin manifold has similarities with the architecture of *spatially distributed* interferometers studied in Ref. [79].

The protocol is shown in Fig. 2.4a. From an initially pure spin state in  $m_F = -5/2$  we apply a first  $\pi/2$  pulse that creates a coherent superposition equally distributed over  $\{-7/2, -5/2\}$  [80]. Next, each state enters the respective input port of two independent Ramsey interferometers, one engineered between  $\{-5/2, -3/2\}$  extracting a phase  $\phi_1$ , the other between  $\{-7/2, -9/2\}$  extracting a phase  $\phi_2$ . The experiment relies on a single RF local oscillator that controls the Raman detuning  $\delta_{RF}$ . The two interferometers are thus opened sequentially at times  $t_1$  and  $t_2$  by switching the Raman detuning from one resonance to the other, after which they accumulate phase for a time together, then are finally closed sequentially again. Both interferometers are open for the same duration  $T$ . The first interferometer's populations are thus sensitive to the phase

$$\begin{aligned}\phi_1 &= \frac{1}{\hbar} \int_{t_1}^{t_1+T} (E_{-5/2} - E_{-3/2}) dt - \int_{t_1}^{t_1+T} \delta_{RF}(t) dt \\ &= \frac{T}{\hbar} (4q - b) - T \langle \delta_{RF} \rangle_1,\end{aligned}\tag{2.1}$$

and the second interferometer's populations, to

$$\begin{aligned}\phi_2 &= \frac{1}{\hbar} \int_{t_2}^{t_2+T} (E_{-9/2} - E_{-7/2}) dt - \int_{t_2}^{t_2+T} \delta_{RF}(t) dt \\ &= \frac{T}{\hbar} (8q - b) - T \langle \delta_{RF} \rangle_2.\end{aligned}\tag{2.2}$$

Note that  $\langle \delta_{RF} \rangle_1 \neq \langle \delta_{RF} \rangle_2$ . The parallel operation of the Ramsey interferometers provides a measurement of both terms contributing to the single-atom ground-state energies, that are, the linear energy splitting  $b$  (due to both the magnetic Zeeman effect and the vector light shift) and the quadratic energy splitting  $q$  (due to the tensor light shift). As  $\langle \delta_{RF} \rangle_1$  and  $\langle \delta_{RF} \rangle_2$  are controlled (here with an accuracy below 0.02 Hz), the difference between the two interferometers' phases  $\phi_1 - \phi_2$  provides a measurement of  $q$ , which is insensitive to shot-to-shot fluctuations in  $b$ , while  $2\phi_1 - \phi_2$  provides a measurement of  $b$ , which is insensitive to shot-to-shot fluctuations in  $q$ <sup>c</sup>.

In Fig. 2.4b, we present the interferograms obtained by measuring the variation of the populations in  $m_F = -7/2$  and  $m_F = -3/2$ , relative to the total atom number, as a function of the interferometer time  $T$ . Here,  $q/\hbar \simeq -320$  Hz (independently deduced by spectroscopy) and  $\Omega_R/2\pi = 77$  Hz on the  $(-5/2 \rightarrow -7/2)$  line. Both populations are measured simultaneously at each experimental realization. During

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<sup>c</sup>Technically,  $q$  and  $b$  can also be time-varying during the interferometer sequence, and the interferometers are sensitive to their time-averages. Fluctuations of  $(q, b)$  at the timescale of  $T$  will be properly retrieved by the combined interferometers provided  $T \gg 1/\Omega_R$ , or if an additional laser frequency is used to engineer the Raman couplings simultaneously.

the time when both interferometers are simultaneously opened ( $\simeq T - 3.5$  ms), we set  $\delta_{RF}$  to  $2\pi \times 1$  Hz, off-resonant with both transitions. We observe that the periods of the two fringe patterns strongly differ, as  $E_{-5/2} - E_{-3/2} \neq E_{-9/2} - E_{-7/2}$ . From the two periods, we can deduce the mean quadratic and linear Zeeman splittings:  $\langle q \rangle/h = -303(8)$  Hz and  $\langle b \rangle/h = 1000(45)$  Hz - in agreement with independent estimates from Raman spectra. These are mean values over all realizations, as  $q, b$  can fluctuate from shot to shot. Upon knowing the fringe contrast and the two phases  $\phi_1, \phi_2$  with better than  $\pi$  accuracy, single realizations of the experiment provide parallel individual simultaneous measurements of  $\phi_1$  and  $\phi_2$ , from which we can deduce single-shot measurements of  $q$  and  $b$ . Given the interrogation time  $T \simeq 4$  ms and noise level of these data (affected by Rabi pulse area fluctuations, mostly of the first pulse), the respective precisions in  $q, b$  from individual points when at maximal slopes are  $h \times 1.8$  Hz and  $h \times 11$  Hz.

To illustrate this, we operate the interferometer at a fixed  $T$  chosen to be close to the maximum phase sensitivity of the interferometer (*i.e.*, close to mid-fringe for both signals). Fig. 2.4c shows a set of 93 measurements of the two phases ( $\phi_1, \phi_2$ ) taken consecutively. For each measurement, we directly reconstruct the deviations of  $b$  and  $q$  relative to the mean, as shown in Fig. 2.4d. These data demonstrate that the simultaneous nature of the measurement makes possible correlation analyses that would otherwise be impossible if the experiment were alternating between one interferometer and the other.

As an example of correlation analysis, we have used this data as follows. We observe that the parallel measurements of  $(q, b)$  do not seem 2D-Gaussian distributed. Instead, two classes of shots are identifiable. The two groups' separation in  $\langle q \rangle$  is  $-1.4(5)$  Hz, *i.e.*, a small fraction (0.4%) of  $\langle q \rangle$  and below the spread within a single group. In contrast, the separation in  $\langle b \rangle$  of  $23(3)$  Hz is significant and higher than the spread in a single group. We attribute this to an evolution of the TLS beam polarization that shifts between two configurations; and thus induces a fluctuating vector light shift with values clustering in two groups, while there should be no vector light shift for the ideal  $\pi$  polarization. By protecting the TLS optical fiber from airflow, only one group remains, and the fluctuations become consistent with measurement uncertainties (also impacted by the first pulse's area fluctuation). We acquire most of the data in this paper (including Fig. 2.4b) with fiber protection.

We now discuss the fundamental limit to the sensitivity of the measurements. In the experiments presented here, the dominant uncertainties on  $b$  and  $q$  arise from Rabi-pulse-area fluctuations and the atom number measurement precision. Nevertheless, the atomic quantum projection noise sets the fundamental limit to the achievable precision of measurements. A key question is what the tradeoff for parallelizing two measurements is. Each one uses, on average, half of the total atom number. In addition, we present in this paper a suboptimal measurement, as we measure only one output port of each interferometer at each realization. Not knowing the exact atom number fed into each interferometer in each realization increases the quantum-projection-noise limit for phase estimation by  $\sqrt{3}/2$ . However, in principle, we could measure all four states in each realization [81, 82, 23]. The fluctuations in the measurement of the two phases associated with the atomic quantum-projection noise are simply  $\sqrt{2}$  times stronger than when using all atoms on the same interferometer. This mild disadvantage vanishes if one considers that at least two runs of the

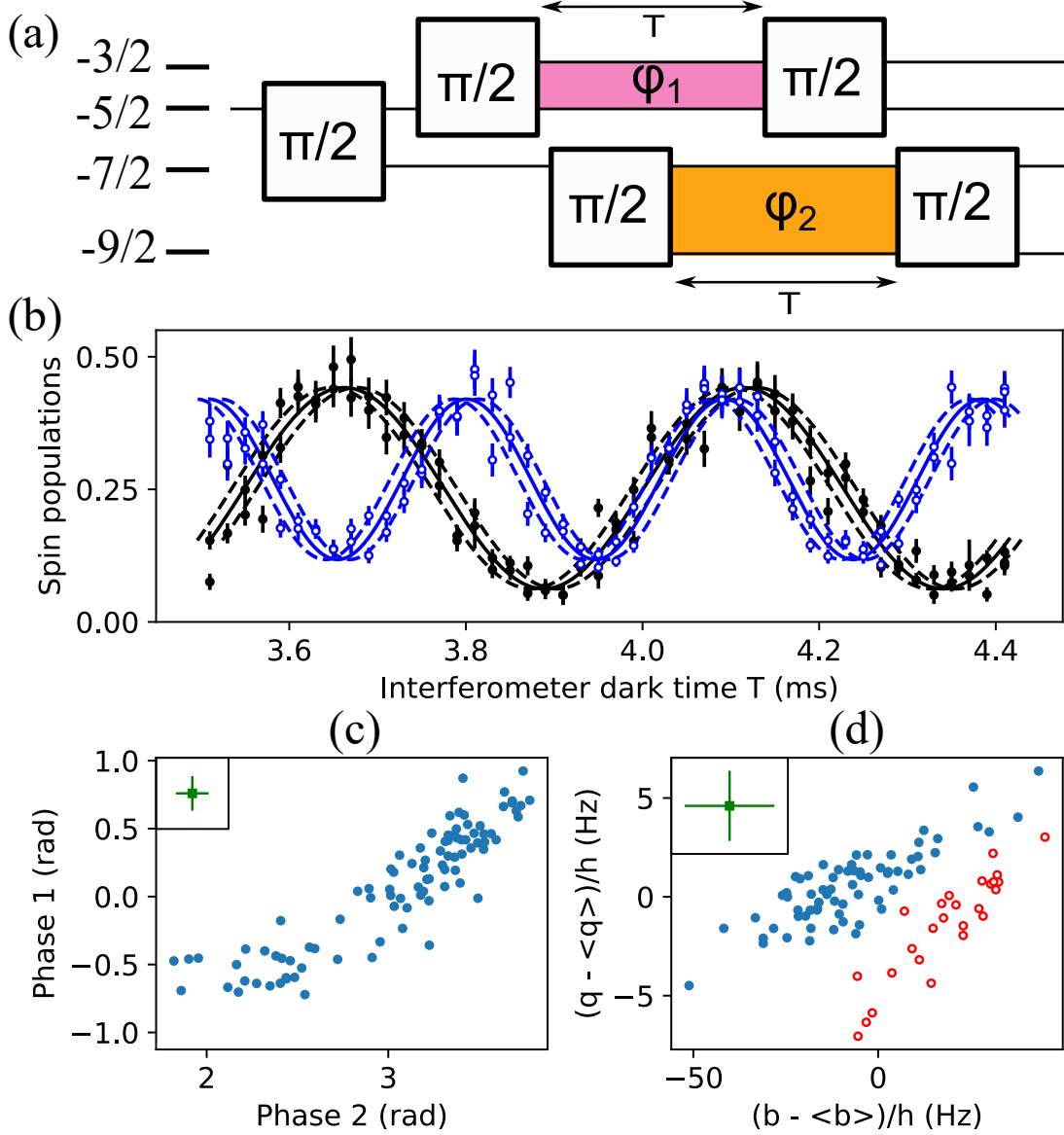


Figure 2.4: **Simultaneous sensing of two external fields.** a) Double interferometer pulse scheme. b) Measured interferogram. We vary the phases  $\phi_1$  and  $\phi_2$  together by tuning the interferometers' phase accumulation times  $T$ . We measure both states  $|-3/2\rangle$  (black, full circles) and  $|-7/2\rangle$  (blue, empty circles) in each realization. The differing periods highlight that two different energies are measured. The error bars combine population measurement uncertainties and the expected impact of Rabi pulse area fluctuations. The solid line is the underlying sinusoidal interferogram, barring phase fluctuations. The dashed-line interferograms represent shifts of  $\pm$  one standard deviation of the phase fluctuations. c) Correlation analysis of the two phases  $\phi_1$  and  $\phi_2$ , measured modulo  $2\pi$  by repeating experiments at a chosen phase with the highest slope for both interferometric signals. We show the median of the error bars (including measurement uncertainty and pulse area fluctuations) in the top-left corner. d) Reconstruction of the two fields  $(b, q)$ . The data split into two groups, identified by color and predominantly separated in  $b$  (the split corresponds to  $\phi_2 \leq 2.8$  rad). We cancel this experimental fluctuation for most data in the paper, including Fig. 2.4b, by protecting the TLS optical fiber from airflow.

experiment would be required to measure sequentially the two interferometers.

We finally discuss the three main systematic effects that could affect the phase measurements. First, the pulses of the two interferometers are interleaved temporally. Consequently, between the splitting and recombining pulses of the interferometer (1), we realize one Raman pulse addressing interferometer (2), and vice-versa. This interleaving creates AC Stark shifts  $\simeq \Omega_R^2/8q$  on the two levels probed by interferometer (1) of the same sign but not exactly compensating due to different Clebsch-Gordan coefficients in the Raman couplings. These shifts can be calculated, or minimized by ensuring the highest possible energy scale separation  $2q/\Omega_R$ . Second, when the Rabi frequencies are only slightly smaller than the energy difference between states, one should account for effects beyond the rotating-wave approximation, such as the Bloch-Siegert shift, and expect the interferometer to be sensitive to the initial temporal phase of the beat between the two Raman beams [83]. Third, in a scheme spanning many pulses and Zeeman states, off-resonant transfers between spin states can interfere with the resonantly driven population transfers. We will see in the next section evidence for this. Effectively, this affects the fringe patterns and phase estimation.

We have shown in this section an example of a sensor that parallelizes two measurements using an extended Hilbert space basis. Thanks to the simultaneity of the measurements, we have demonstrated that correlation analyses are possible. We illustrated it by tracking in parallel variations of the vector and tensor light shifts acting on the atoms. One can also interpret these experiments as a common-mode noise-rejection scheme, i.e., extracting precise values of  $q$  despite the fact that fluctuations of  $b$  affect all interferometers. Similar schemes for the simultaneous sensing of multiple fields could be devised, e.g., for measuring multiple spatial components of a vector (magnetic) field.

### 2.1.5.2 Simultaneous measurements of multiple collective atomic observables.

We will now explore a second possibility offered by the large spin-state manifold: increasing the number of observables accessible in one realization and characterizing the collective spin state of a quantum many-body ensemble.

Let us start by remarking that tracking two spatial components of a magnetic field by monitoring spin precession requires measuring the projection of the collective spin along at least two directions simultaneously. However, this is typically not possible due to the non-commutativity of the two spin-projection observables. More fundamentally, fluctuations of a collective spin in the two directions transverse to its mean orientation are critical to the precision of metrological applications [84, 85] but remain assessed along one given quantization axis at a time. Furthermore, measuring the collective spin properties enables tests of a large class of entanglement witnesses [86, 87, 88, 89]. We also point out that large-spin atoms are compelling due to numerous new scenarios involving entanglement witnesses [90, 91]. For large-spin atoms, only measuring the total population in each spin state can already reveal beyond mean-field dynamics [33, 92], and measuring collective spin fluctuations in a single axis can already be used to characterize correlations [39, 93]. Here, we will show that ensembles of large-spin atoms offer an opportunity for physics

with ensembles of effectively smaller pseudo-spins: measuring two orthogonal spin-projection operators - or generically, two non-commuting observables - in one given experimental realization.

The general idea is to use a larger space of states for each atom in the measurement sequence than during the experiment that came before it, so that a higher number of observables is available. These observables (e.g., populations) in the large Hilbert space commute with each other and can be simultaneously measured; but their expectation values and even higher order statistics reflect those of non-commuting observables of the state produced by the experiment.

One such scheme emerges if one can coherently map the internal states involved in the experiment into other, initially empty, ancillary states used for measurement purposes only. Reference [74] demonstrated this idea, using the complete hyperfine structure of alkali atoms to probe spinor properties in the  $F = 1$  manifold. We generalize this approach to the case of ground-state alkaline-earth atoms. In practice, we consider ensembles of effective qubits, i.e., pseudo-spins  $1/2$ , initially restricted to two Zeeman sublevels. To simultaneously measure two pseudo-spin projections, we first map each state of this qubit into ancillary spin states accessible in the  $F = 9/2$  manifold, using a partial coherent transfer. Then, using again the capacity to perform manipulations targeted on specific pairs of states (i.e., rotations on a sub-Bloch-sphere), we perform different basis transformations on the qubit states than on the ancillary states. The final measurement of populations thus contains information formerly inaccessible in the initial populations of the qubit states. We show a typical sequence in Fig. 2.5a.

For our experiments, we define the two qubit states,  $|\uparrow\rangle = |-5/2\rangle$  and  $|\downarrow\rangle = |-7/2\rangle$ . The initial state, which we produce to test the measurement protocol, is a coherent state of qubits  $|\psi\rangle^{(N_{at})} = ((|\uparrow\rangle - i|\downarrow\rangle)/\sqrt{2})^{\otimes N_{at}}$ , where  $N_{at}$  is the atom number. We produce it from a sample polarized in  $|\uparrow\rangle$ , by one  $\pi/2$  Raman pulse between the qubit states. With our phase convention, this coherent state is polarized against the pseudo-spin quantization axis “y”, i.e., the total pseudo-spin of the ensemble has projections  $\langle \vec{s}_{\uparrow,\downarrow} \rangle = (0, -N_{at}/2, 0)$ .

The measurement sequence then begins. First, two successive  $\pi/2$  pulses duplicate the  $|\uparrow\rangle$  amplitude to the ancillary state  $|a\rangle = |-3/2\rangle$  and the  $|\downarrow\rangle$  amplitude to the ancillary state  $|b\rangle = |-9/2\rangle$ , respectively. Second, we let the phases of all four states evolve in the presence of the TLS and magnetic field. In particular, the qubit sub-Bloch sphere effectively evolves by  $\exp(-i\phi\sigma_{\uparrow,\downarrow}^z/2)$ , where the angle  $\phi$  is controlled by the duration of the rotation and by the detuning between the RF clock and the qubit transition. Third, we apply a final  $\pi/2$  pulse between the two qubit states, corresponding to applying  $\exp(-i(\pi/2)\sigma_{\uparrow,\downarrow}^x/2)$ . At the end of the sequence, one would ideally measure the populations  $N_i$  of all four states. The population difference  $N_a - N_b$  provides an estimator for the many-body operator  $\hat{s}_{\uparrow,\downarrow}^z$ . Similarly,  $N_{\uparrow} - N_{\downarrow}$  provides an estimator for  $\hat{s}_{\uparrow,\downarrow}^\phi = \cos(\phi)\hat{s}_{\uparrow,\downarrow}^y + \sin(\phi)\hat{s}_{\uparrow,\downarrow}^x$ , the total pseudo-spin projection in one selected direction of the plane  $(x, y)$ . Both quantities are thus accessible in a single experimental run.

Let us describe more formally the measurement, which will enable us to discuss its statistics. We label  $U$  the one-body evolution operator corresponding to the series of three  $\pi/2$  pulses and phase evolution within the measurement sequence, outlined

in Fig. 2.5, with  $\phi = 0$  for simplicity. We apply the same evolution to all spins in parallel. Thus, the many-body evolution operator is factorizable onto all the modes of the atomic external degrees of freedom  $\lambda$ :  $U^{(N)} = \Pi_\lambda U_\lambda$ . We define two projective measurement operators,

$$\hat{O}^z = U^{(N)\dagger}(N_a - N_b)U^{(N)}, \text{ and} \quad (2.3)$$

$$\hat{O}^y = U^{(N)\dagger}(N_\uparrow - N_\downarrow)U^{(N)}. \quad (2.4)$$

They correspond to measuring all four atomic populations ( $N_a, N_b, N_\uparrow, N_\downarrow$ ) after the collective evolution described by  $U^{(N)}$  and computing the appropriate number differences. Assuming that before the measurement sequence, the only populated states are those of the qubit ( $\uparrow, \downarrow$ ), one can easily show:

$$\langle \hat{O}^z \rangle = \langle \hat{s}_{\uparrow, \downarrow}^z \rangle, \langle \hat{O}^y \rangle = \langle \hat{s}_{\uparrow, \downarrow}^y \rangle, \quad (2.5)$$

$$\hat{O}^z \hat{O}^y = \hat{O}^y \hat{O}^z. \quad (2.6)$$

Note that  $\hat{O}^z$  and  $\hat{O}^y$  do commute with each other, which highlights the simultaneous nature of the two measurements. Thus, measuring the four populations after the outlined sequence allows us to estimate the expectation values  $\langle \hat{s}_{\uparrow, \downarrow}^y \rangle$  and  $\langle \hat{s}_{\uparrow, \downarrow}^z \rangle$  in a single physical realization. Furthermore, we have shown using second quantization formalism that

$$\text{Var}(\hat{O}^{\{y,z\}}) = \text{Var}(\hat{s}_{\uparrow, \downarrow}^{\{y,z\}}) + N_{at}/4, \quad (2.7)$$

provided that only the qubit levels ( $\uparrow, \downarrow$ ) are populated before the measurement operations described by  $U^{(N)}$ . It is remarkable that the scheme only introduces an additive fluctuation term  $N_{at}/4$ , which could then be subtracted in quadrature to estimate  $\text{Var}(\hat{s}_{\uparrow, \downarrow}^{\{y,z\}})$  from the measurement of  $\text{Var}(\hat{O}^{\{y,z\}})$ . Note that  $N_{at}/4$  corresponds to the transverse spin variance of a coherent state.

Figure 2.5b shows the measured interferograms. Here,  $q/h = -330$  Hz and  $\Omega_R/2\pi = 76$  Hz on the  $(-5/2 \rightarrow -7/2)$  line. We control the phase  $\phi$  by varying the Raman detuning during a fixed span of 0.51 ms just before the last Rabi pulse. Ideally, one would simultaneously measure the populations in all four states [81, 82]. In our setup, only two spin states,  $m_F = -7/2$  ( $\downarrow$ ) and  $m_F = -3/2$  ( $a$ ), can be measured in the same experimental run, as it is the easiest for our spin-population measurement protocol [23]. We measure the spin state  $m_F = -5/2$  ( $\uparrow$ ) separately, whereas, in the current implementation, the Clebsch-Gordan coefficient is too weak to efficiently measure the state  $m_F = -9/2$ . Since we operate in the regime where the Rabi pulses are well resolved, we can consider that  $N_{-9/2} + N_{-3/2} = N_{at}/2$  and  $N_{-7/2} + N_{-5/2} = N_{at}/2$  and thus relate each population to a spin observable,

$$\langle \hat{s}_{\uparrow, \downarrow}^z \rangle = \langle U^{(N)\dagger} (2N_{-3/2} - N_{at}/2) U^{(N)} \rangle, \quad (2.8)$$

$$\langle \hat{s}_{\uparrow, \downarrow}^\phi \rangle = -\langle U^{(N)\dagger} (2N_{-7/2} - N_{at}/2) U^{(N)} \rangle. \quad (2.9)$$

However, the fluctuation of these observables will be higher than those of  $\hat{O}^z$  and  $\hat{O}^\phi$ , which are more optimal if all four states can be measured simultaneously.

The striking feature of Fig. 2.5b is that the populations in states  $m_F = -7/2$  ( $\downarrow$ ) and  $-5/2$  ( $\uparrow$ ) show pronounced oscillations, while the population in state  $m_F =$

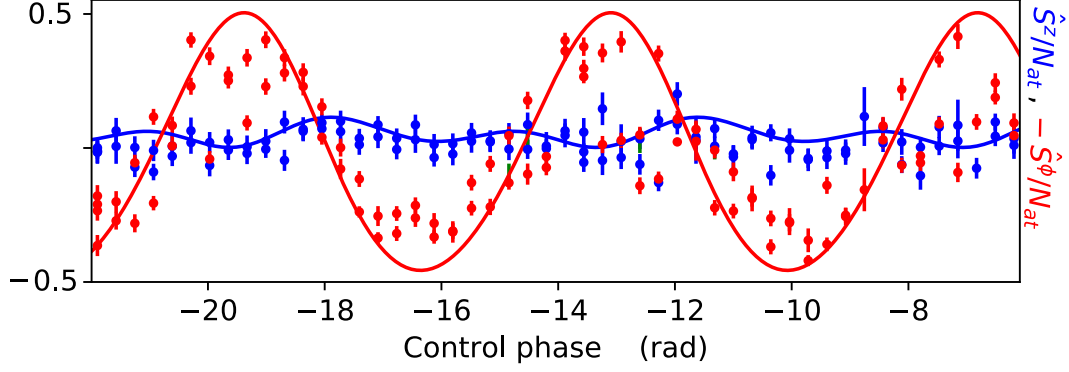


Figure 2.5: **Measuring two non-commuting observables in a single realization** a) Pulse scheme, highlighting one stage for preparing a well-defined state, and one measurement stage that includes unitary operations before the detection of populations. In frame (b), we monitor, as a function of the control phase, the fractional populations  $N_{(-7/2, -5/2, -3/2)}/N_{at}$ , in red, green, and blue, respectively. Error bars reflect only the population measurement uncertainty. Solid lines are the result of simulations of the master equation. We simultaneously acquire  $N_{-7/2}/N_{at}$  and  $N_{-3/2}/N_{at}$  during the same runs. From  $N_{-3/2}$ , we extract an estimate of the projection  $\langle \hat{s}_{\uparrow, \downarrow}^z \rangle$  of qubit pseudo-spin, while from  $N_{-7/2}$ , we extract an estimate of  $\langle \hat{s}_{\uparrow, \downarrow}^\phi \rangle$ , all during the same runs of the experiment. We acquire the population  $N_{-5/2}/N_{at}$  by independent runs. The solid lines result from a master equation simulation with a single adjustable parameter: an 18 Hz correction on the linear Zeeman splitting. (c) and (d) present the dependence of  $\langle \hat{O}_z \rangle$  on the energy scale separation  $2|q|/\hbar\Omega_R$  for Rabi pulses with a simple square temporal envelope, obtained from numerical simulations. We consider a coherent state with  $\langle \hat{s}_{\uparrow, \downarrow}^z \rangle = 0$ . We take the maximal, minimal, and mean values of  $\hat{O}_z$  over a  $2\pi$  variation of the control phase. We operate our experiment at  $2|q|/\hbar\Omega_R \simeq 9$ , providing the best balance between technically-limited decoherence and scheme fidelity.

$-3/2$  ( $a$ ) barely evolves. The oscillations reflect that we effectively change the spin measurement basis with the interferometric phase. The approximately flat behavior of  $N_{-3/2}$  demonstrates the capacity to rotate the spin in the sub-Bloch sphere set by the states  $|-7/2\rangle$  and  $|-5/2\rangle$  without significantly modifying the population  $N_{-3/2}$ . We still observe a weak dependence of  $N_{-3/2}$  on the control phase  $\phi$ . This signal is a signature of population transfers driven off-resonantly by the Raman couplings, which will be finite as long as  $|\hbar\Omega_R/2q| > 0$ . Interestingly, we did not see a signature of off-resonant transfers in the experiments restricted to a single pair of states. Indeed, in more complex pulse schemes, “leaked” atomic amplitudes have the opportunity to interfere with macroscopic amplitudes that are resonantly driven, which exacerbates their impact on populations.

The simple approach to tackle these parasitic population transfers is to increase the energy scale separation,  $|2q/\hbar\Omega_R|$ . We show in Fig. 2.5c,d how the stray signals fall with reduced Rabi couplings, using numerical simulations of the master equation. Here, the fundamental source of dissipation (*i.e.*, spontaneous emission due to a perfectly monochromatic laser) is included. The studied quantity is  $\langle\hat{O}_z\rangle/N_{at}$  for a coherent state with  $\langle\hat{s}_{\uparrow,\downarrow}^z\rangle = 0$ . Provided the phase control is achieved in a time shorter than the Raman pulses, this quantity depends on the ratio  $2|q|/\hbar\Omega_R$ , irrespective of the values of  $q$  and  $\Omega_R$ . We see that the  $\phi$ -dependence and mean value of  $\langle\hat{O}_z\rangle/N_{at}$  both slowly approach the quantum-projection-noise limit ( $\sqrt{1/2N_{at}} = 0.007$  for  $10^4$  atoms) when increasing  $2|q|/\hbar\Omega_R$ . However, at values  $2|q|/\hbar\Omega_R > 10^2$ , spontaneous emission introduces spin diffusion and degrades the scheme. Technical imperfections will bring the optimum to faster pulses, *i.e.*, lower values of  $2|q|/\hbar\Omega_R$ .

To push this limitation, a most promising avenue is the temporal shaping of the Rabi pulses. By deviating from the square amplitude envelopes used here, even with simple shapes [94], one can drastically reduce off-resonant population transfers for a given Raman coupling strength, and thus at constant overall scheme duration. More dramatically, Ref. [68] demonstrates numerically that optimal control methods would enable performing arbitrary unitary  $\mathfrak{su}(10)$  operations in a time  $\sim 30\hbar/q$ . This is about the same duration as the experiments that we present here, and relies on high inter-state couplings:  $2q/\hbar\Omega_R \lesssim 1$ . One could also use the ultra-narrow transition  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_2$  [95] to engineer the tensor light shift with dramatically reduced spontaneous emission.

Thus, expanding the internal Hilbert space in the measurement sequence enables the parallel estimates of several atomic observables. This follows the idea exposed in [96] for implementing positive-operator-valued measures (POVMs), and the literature on POVMs, *e.g.* to estimate measurement fluctuations [97], applies. Here, we have studied the case where two orthogonal pseudo-spin projections of an ensemble of qubits are measured by expanding the space to four states. This expansion comes at the cost of an increased impact from the quantum-projection noise, owing to smaller populations in each measured state and the stochastic nature of the “mapping” pulses. Given that there are ten possible spin states in strontium’s ground state, one could, in principle, simultaneously measure all three spin projections of an ensemble of pseudo-spins  $s = 1/2$  or even  $s = 1$ . Alternatively, one could simultaneously measure two projections of  $s = 1/2$ ,  $s = 1$ ,  $s = 3/2$ , or  $s = 2$  pseudo-spin ensembles.

### 2.1.6 Conclusion

In this work, we have demonstrated the implementation of operations effectively driven by generators of the  $\mathfrak{su}(10)$  group. We focused on selectively driving Rabi oscillations between adjacent ( $m_F \longleftrightarrow m_F + 1$ ) and next-to-adjacent ( $m_F \longleftrightarrow m_F + 2$ ) levels. We demonstrated these on four out of ten levels, with high fidelity  $> 0.99$ . We expect the generalization to the entire spin manifold to require moderate technical adjustments, such as a higher magnetic field bias. Being able to drive all  $\Delta m_F = (1, 2)$  transitions effectively amounts to driving “rotations” around  $2N - 3 = 17$  generators of the  $\mathfrak{su}(N)$  group. This number exceeds the  $N - 1$  number of generators that can be simultaneously diagonalized (which correspond to the  $N - 1$  quantization axes). Therefore concatenating  $\Delta m_F = (1, 2)$  transitions is in principle sufficient to implement all the  $N^2 - 1$  generators.

In practice, this set of rotations is sufficient to measure the relative amplitudes and coherences between all pairs of Zeeman levels, i.e. perform tomography and thus reconstruct the complete state. Combining these schemes with a spin-selective detection capable of giving access to all ten spin components, as in Refs. [82, 81], one would gain comprehensive control of the spin state, with applications to quantum simulation, computation, or sensing schemes requiring operations within the  $\mathfrak{su}(N)$  group [40, 68, 47, 48, 49]. Thanks to these tools, the spins of strontium 87 atoms are a fully exploitable qudit resource with  $\mathfrak{su}(10)$  character, which one can even complement by other coherently controllable degrees of freedom in electronically-excited states, e.g., as in Ref. [98, 99].

These assertions also apply to species with similar atomic structures - alkaline-earth-like atoms and group IIB transition metals fermionic isotopes - to which the scheme could be implemented. Indeed, they have in common: a large ratio between the hyperfine splitting and the linewidth of the state  $^3P_1$ , favorable for tensor-shift engineering with low spontaneous-emission levels; a vast spin Hilbert space in the  $^1S_0$  ground state;  $\mathfrak{su}(N)$  symmetric interactions; extensive coherence times afforded by the Landé factor of nuclear spins.

We have seen that large-spin atoms open up the possibility of parallelized interferometers, which can be used for measuring multiple fields or for common-mode noise-rejection schemes. Similar sequences could readily explore other avenues, such as multiple-path interferometers and quantum random walks. More generally, being able to tailor the spin state by tensor light shifts enables the production of “non-classical” spin states, i.e., single-atom spin states that cannot be modeled by an assembly of uncorrelated spin-1/2 particles [100]. These “non-classical” spin states present specific advantages for quantum sensing [44].

Finally, following the original idea of Ref. [74], we have seen that the vast Hilbert space is an opportunity for the parallel estimation of multiple non-commuting observables of an atomic ensemble. We studied this in the case of two observables of an ensemble of pseudo-spins 1/2. However, it would be most interesting to study the parallel estimation, e.g., of three non-commuting observables or pseudo-spins  $> 1/2$ . It would come at the cost of more Hilbert space resources and increased quantum-projection-noise effects. The full potential of such measurements deserve investigation. The scheme is analogous to randomly partitioning the system into several sub-ensembles and measuring each along a different quantization axis. One question

is whether this could be amenable to extracting signatures of specific many-body states (chiral states, cluster states [101, 102]), or to characterize general properties of the many-body states (entanglement, purity) in the spirit of, e.g., Refs. [103, 104].

## 2.2 Outlook to positive-operator-valued measures (POVMs)

In traditional quantum metrology, standard interferometers are bounded by Projective Valued Measurements (PVM), which restrict the device to sensing a single physical quantity per experimental run. Tracking multiple environmental parameters or reconstructing the full state usually requires sequential measurements across different configurations, heavily increasing the statistical overhead and cycle times. The high-dimensional ground state manifold of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  allows us to bypass these rigid constraints through parallelized architectures. Specifically, we demonstrated a parallel quantum sensor designed to simultaneously extract both the linear and the quadratic components of an external degeneracy-lifting field in a single shot.

To formally understand how a quantum system can extract such complementary pieces of information simultaneously, one look at the generalization of the measurement postulate via Positive-Operator-Valued Measures (POVM) [97, 105] of the reduced space of a two level object. Indeed, standard PVMs face a fundamental impossibility when trying to obtain complete information on a Hilbert space from a single outcome. Let us consider a system that produces either of these two non-orthogonal states of a two-level object, and try to extract from measurements which state is produced. For instance:

$$\left\{ |\psi_1\rangle = |0\rangle, \quad |\psi_2\rangle = \frac{1}{2}|0\rangle + \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}|1\rangle \right\}$$

because  $\langle\psi_1|\psi_2\rangle = 1/2 \neq 0$ , a projection-based measurement in the  $\{|\psi_1\rangle, |\psi_1^\perp\rangle\}$  basis—with  $|\psi_1^\perp\rangle = |1\rangle$ —yields a conditional probability of  $P(\psi_1|\psi_2) = |\langle\psi_1|\psi_2\rangle|^2 = 0.25$ . Unambiguous state discrimination (USD) addresses this limitation by guaranteeing error-free identification of non-orthogonal states at the expense of introducing a non-zero probability of obtaining an inconclusive result. Because of non-orthogonality, a single PVM outcome cannot deduce with certainty which state was prepared, and crucial information is completely lost.

A POVM overcomes this by defining an ensemble of positive hermitian operators  $\{\hat{E}_1, \hat{E}_2, \hat{E}_3\}$  ( $\hat{E}_i \geq 0$ , of positive eigenvalues) summing to the identity  $\sum_i \hat{E}_i = \mathbb{I}$ . This enforces orthogonality conditions in the same basis  $\{|\psi_1\rangle, |\psi_2\rangle, |\psi_1^\perp\rangle, |\psi_2^\perp\rangle\}$ :

$$\langle\psi_2|\hat{E}_1|\psi_2\rangle = 0 \tag{2.10}$$

$$\langle\psi_1|\hat{E}_2|\psi_1\rangle = 0 \tag{2.11}$$

with  $|\psi_2^\perp\rangle = \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}|0\rangle - \frac{1}{2}|1\rangle$ . Probability conservation requires an inconclusive operator  $\hat{E}_3$  such that  $\mathbb{I} = \hat{E}_1 + \hat{E}_2 + \hat{E}_3$ . Combined with the condition of semi-positivity of the eigenvalues, these constraints force the operators to be proportional to the dual

basis projectors:

$$\hat{E}_1 = \lambda |\psi_2^\perp\rangle \langle \psi_2^\perp| \quad (2.12)$$

$$\hat{E}_2 = \lambda |\psi_1^\perp\rangle \langle \psi_1^\perp| \quad (2.13)$$

where the normalization  $\lambda = 2/3$  validates the  $\hat{E}_3 \geq 0$  condition. This leads to a success probability of  $P(\hat{E}_1|\psi_1) = \lambda |\langle \psi_1 | \psi_2^\perp \rangle|^2 = 1/2$  (equivalent for  $P(\hat{E}_2|\psi_2)$ ), while the remaining 50% is routed to the inconclusive outcome  $\hat{E}_3$  since projecting  $\hat{E}_3$  onto  $\psi_1$  or  $\psi_2$  does not lead to a conclusive determination of the initial state.

Our second interferometric scheme, detailed in Section 2.1.5, constitutes a direct physical realization of this POVM framework. The protocol prepares a target qubit state  $|\psi\rangle = \alpha |-5/2\rangle + \beta |-7/2\rangle$ , and uses targeted coherent pulses to map a controlled fraction of these populations into two auxiliary ancillary states ( $|-9/2\rangle$  and  $|-3/2\rangle$ ).

## 2.2.1 Derivation of the experimental POVM framework

### 2.2.1.1 Four-level extended space dynamics

To model this sequence, we consider the four-level subspace  $\mathcal{H}_4$  spanned by the basis states:

$$\mathcal{H}_4 = \left\{ \left| -\frac{9}{2} \right\rangle, \left| -\frac{7}{2} \right\rangle, \left| -\frac{5}{2} \right\rangle, \left| -\frac{3}{2} \right\rangle \right\}. \quad (2.14)$$

In this basis, the fundamental projective measurements (PVM) associated with state selective fluorescence detection are described by the diagonal projectors:

$$\hat{E}_1 = \left| -\frac{9}{2} \right\rangle \left\langle -\frac{9}{2} \right|, \quad \hat{E}_2 = \left| -\frac{7}{2} \right\rangle \left\langle -\frac{7}{2} \right|, \quad \hat{E}_3 = \left| -\frac{5}{2} \right\rangle \left\langle -\frac{5}{2} \right|, \quad \hat{E}_4 = \left| -\frac{3}{2} \right\rangle \left\langle -\frac{3}{2} \right|. \quad (2.15)$$

Both operators below are single-qubit rotations generated by a Pauli matrix  $A$  (with  $A^2 = \mathbb{I}$ ), for which the exponential reduces to

$$\exp(-ixA) = \cos(x) \mathbb{I} - i \sin(x) A, \quad (2.16)$$

obtained by splitting the Taylor series of the exponential into its even and odd powers of  $A$ .

The pulse sequence consists of a differential phase accumulation  $\phi$  applied to state  $|-5/2\rangle$  (and other states but not our interest here). It is generated by  $\exp(-i\phi\sigma_z^{\uparrow\downarrow}/2)$  (Sec. 2.1.5.2), which by Eq. (2.16) (with  $A = \sigma_z$ ,  $x = \phi/2$ ) reads  $\text{diag}(e^{-i\phi/2}, e^{i\phi/2})$  in the  $\{|-5/2\rangle, |-7/2\rangle\}$  basis. Only the relative phase between the two levels affects any measurement outcome, so factoring out the (physically irrelevant) global phase  $e^{-i\phi/2}$  – and trivially extending to the two unaffected ancillary states – gives the phase operator:

$$\hat{\Phi}(\phi) = \text{diag}(1, 1, e^{-i\phi}, 1), \quad (2.17)$$

followed by resonant  $\pi/2$  pulse rotations acting simultaneously on the adjacent pairs  $\{|-9/2\rangle, |-7/2\rangle\}$  and  $\{|-5/2\rangle, |-3/2\rangle\}$ , duplicating the qubit amplitudes onto the ancillary states used for readout. On each addressed pair, this beam-splitter-like

operation is generated by a resonant Rabi pulse of area  $\pi/2$ ,  $\exp(-i\frac{\pi}{4}\sigma_x)$ , which by Eq. (2.16) (with  $A = \sigma_x$ ,  $x = \pi/4$ ) gives  $\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(\mathbb{I} - i\sigma_x) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\begin{pmatrix} 1 & -i \\ -i & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ . Applied simultaneously to both pairs, this takes the following block-diagonal form over  $\mathcal{H}_4$ :

$$\hat{X}_{\pi/2} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -i & 0 & 0 \\ -i & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & -i \\ 0 & 0 & -i & 1 \end{pmatrix}. \quad (2.18)$$

The measurement sequence is closed by a final resonant  $\pi/2$  pulse acting only on the original qubit pair  $\{|-7/2\rangle, |-5/2\rangle\}$ , leaving the ancillary states  $|-9/2\rangle$  and  $|-3/2\rangle$  untouched:

$$\hat{X}_{\pi/2}^{qubit} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} & \frac{-i}{\sqrt{2}} & 0 \\ 0 & \frac{-i}{\sqrt{2}} & \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}. \quad (2.19)$$

The full unitary transformation experienced by the system prior to detection is given by  $\hat{U} = \hat{X}_{\pi/2}^{qubit} \hat{\Phi}(\phi) \hat{X}_{\pi/2}$ : the duplicating pulse acts first, followed by the phase accumulation, followed by the closing pulse on the qubit pair. In the Heisenberg picture, the bare detection operators transform as  $\hat{E}'_i = \hat{U}^\dagger \hat{E}_i \hat{U}$ .

Carrying out the matrix multiplication for  $\hat{E}'_2 = \hat{X}_{\pi/2}^\dagger \hat{\Phi}^\dagger \hat{X}_{\pi/2}^{qubit\dagger} \hat{E}_2 \hat{X}_{\pi/2}^{qubit} \hat{\Phi} \hat{X}_{\pi/2}$  (and likewise for  $\hat{E}'_4$ ), explicitly, in the basis  $\{|-9/2\rangle, |-7/2\rangle, |-5/2\rangle, |-3/2\rangle\}$ , yields for the second and fourth detection channels:

$$\hat{E}'_2 = \frac{1}{4} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & i & e^{-i\phi} & -ie^{-i\phi} \\ -i & 1 & -ie^{-i\phi} & -e^{-i\phi} \\ e^{i\phi} & ie^{i\phi} & 1 & -i \\ ie^{i\phi} & -e^{i\phi} & i & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \hat{E}'_4 = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & \frac{1}{2} & \frac{i}{2} \\ 0 & 0 & -\frac{i}{2} & \frac{1}{2} \end{pmatrix}. \quad (2.20)$$

Compared to a sequence with only the duplicating pulse, the closing pulse  $\hat{X}_{\pi/2}^{qubit}$  mixes the phase accumulated on  $|-5/2\rangle$  back into the  $|-7/2\rangle$  channel, so that  $\hat{E}'_2$  now also carries  $\phi$ -dependent coherences – a direct signature of the qubit phase, and the key point of this measurement scheme.

$\hat{E}'_2$  and  $\hat{E}'_4$  could be measured in the same shot but it would be preferable to extend the space to more  $m_F$  states to reduce SQL noise.

### 2.2.1.2 Reduction to the target qubit subspace

While the set  $\{\hat{E}'_i\}$  forms a valid PVM over the full four-level space  $\mathcal{H}_4$ , the initial physical state  $|\psi\rangle = \alpha|-5/2\rangle + \beta|-7/2\rangle$  is strictly prepared inside the two-level target qubit subspace  $\mathcal{H}_{qubit} = \{|-\frac{7}{2}\rangle, |-\frac{5}{2}\rangle\}$ .

In Bergou [105] framework, measurement probabilities correspond to state overlaps  $P(i) = \langle\psi|\hat{E}'_i|\psi\rangle$ . Because the prepared state has zero initial population in the auxiliary states  $|-9/2\rangle$  and  $|-3/2\rangle$ , we have:

$$\left\langle -\frac{9}{2} \middle| \psi \right\rangle = 0, \quad \left\langle -\frac{3}{2} \middle| \psi \right\rangle = 0. \quad (2.21)$$

As a consequence, any matrix elements of  $\hat{E}'_i$  acting purely on  $|-9/2\rangle$  or  $|-3/2\rangle$  yield zero contribution when evaluated on  $|\psi\rangle$ . Restricting the transformed measurement operators to the active qubit manifold by projecting via  $\hat{P}_{\text{qubit}} = |-7/2\rangle\langle -7/2| + |-5/2\rangle\langle -5/2|$  defines the set of effective operators:

$$\hat{M}_i \equiv \hat{P}_{\text{qubit}} \hat{E}'_i \hat{P}_{\text{qubit}}. \quad (2.22)$$

Applying this projection to  $\hat{E}'_2$  isolates the populated block, which retains the  $\phi$ -dependent coherence between the two qubit states:

$$\hat{M}_2 = \frac{1}{4} \left[ \left| -\frac{7}{2} \right\rangle \left\langle -\frac{7}{2} \right| + \left| -\frac{5}{2} \right\rangle \left\langle -\frac{5}{2} \right| - ie^{-i\phi} \left| -\frac{7}{2} \right\rangle \left\langle -\frac{5}{2} \right| + ie^{i\phi} \left| -\frac{5}{2} \right\rangle \left\langle -\frac{7}{2} \right| \right]. \quad (2.23)$$

Likewise, projecting  $\hat{E}'_4$  eliminates the unpopulated auxiliary states  $|-9/2\rangle$  and  $|-3/2\rangle$ , leaving:

$$\hat{M}_4 = \frac{1}{2} \left| -\frac{5}{2} \right\rangle \left\langle -\frac{5}{2} \right|. \quad (2.24)$$

The set of restricted operators  $\{\hat{M}_i\}$  on  $\mathcal{H}_{\text{qubit}}$  are non-orthogonal ( $\hat{M}_i^2 \neq \hat{M}_i$ ) and positive semi-definite ( $\hat{M}_i \geq 0$ ), yet they fulfill the completeness relation  $\sum_i \hat{M}_i = \mathbb{I}_{\text{qubit}}$ . Restricting a global projective measurement on an extended Hilbert space to an active target subspace by eliminating unpopulated auxiliary channels provides a direct physical construction of a POVM.

Since  $\hat{P}_{\text{qubit}} |\psi\rangle = |\psi\rangle$  for the qubit-restricted state, the click probabilities coincide with those of the full-space operators,  $P(i) = \langle \psi | \hat{E}'_i | \psi \rangle = \langle \psi | \hat{M}_i | \psi \rangle$ , so that the measured populations obey  $\langle N_{-3/2} \rangle = N_{\text{at}} \langle \hat{M}_4 \rangle$  and  $\langle N_{-7/2} \rangle = N_{\text{at}} \langle \hat{M}_2 \rangle$ . Combined with the definitions of the collective pseudo-spin observables in terms of these same populations, this directly expresses the mean pseudo-spin projections in terms of the POVM outcome probabilities:

$$\langle \hat{s}_{\uparrow,\downarrow}^z \rangle = N_{\text{at}} \left( 2\langle \hat{M}_4 \rangle - \frac{1}{2} \right), \quad \langle \hat{s}_{\uparrow,\downarrow}^\phi \rangle = N_{\text{at}} \left( \frac{1}{2} - 2\langle \hat{M}_2 \rangle \right). \quad (2.25)$$

The  $\phi$ -independent term in  $\hat{M}_4$  (eq. (2.24)) reflects that  $\hat{s}^z$  does not depend on the interferometric phase, while the coherence carried by  $\hat{M}_2$  (eq. (2.23)) is precisely what makes  $\hat{s}^\phi$  sensitive to  $\phi$ .

ajouter ouverture sur mesure hétérodyne comme def d'un POVM [106] et l'application de l'article [96]

# Chapter 3

## Photoassociation : concept and spectroscopy of $^{87}\text{Sr}$ calibrated on $^{88}\text{Sr}$

While the previous chapter presented the individual evolution of atoms superposed in multiple states, this third chapter focuses on the loss processes through which two atoms are photoassociated to explore the molecular formation of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ . Photoassociation (PA) consists of illuminating colliding atoms at a specific frequency to form a bound molecular state. With the advent of cold and ultracold atoms, PA has become a high-resolution spectroscopic tool, as the extremely low initial kinetic energy significantly reduces thermal broadening and reveals subtle structures [107].

However, the formation of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  molecules remains an open question. In contrast, many groups have reported molecular lines and quantum degeneracy in bosonic isotopes ( $^{88}\text{Sr}$ ,  $^{86}\text{Sr}$ , and  $^{84}\text{Sr}$ ), notably leveraging Bose-Einstein condensates (BECs) and ultracold mixtures as demonstrated by Schreck and co-workers [108] alongside other experimental works [15, 4, 13, 14]. Regarding the fermionic species, theoretical predictions for molecular potentials were established in [109], while experimental PA on the broad  $^1\text{S}_0 - ^1\text{P}_1$  transition—which exhibits no hyperfine structure—was reported in [110]. Nevertheless, the intricate structure of the narrow intercombination line ( $^1\text{S}_0 - ^3\text{P}_1$ ) has so far hindered clear detection of molecular signatures, despite its unique promise as a controllable interface for state manipulation.

Beyond fundamental spectroscopy, resolving these narrow molecular transitions is directly motivated by applications in quantum metrology. In this context, a fundamental benchmark for phase estimation with  $N$  independent particles prepared in a coherent spin state is the Standard Quantum Limit (SQL), defined by the shot-noise scaling  $\Delta\phi_{\text{SQL}} = 1/\sqrt{N}$  [18]. For an ensemble of particles with effective spin  $s$  where interferometry is performed on extreme projection states, this limit scales as  $\Delta\phi_{\text{SQL}} = 1/\sqrt{2Ns}$ .

While standard protocols rely on coherent control, spin squeezing, or quantum gates to generate entangled states, the work of Foss-Feig et al. [22] inspired our team to pursue an alternative route. Rather than viewing dissipation as a decoherence mechanism to be avoided, we aim to harness the two-body reactive losses associated with these narrow molecular potentials as a dissipative engine. As a long-term

prospect, such a process can drive the system toward a stationary Dicke state in a zero-projection spin ( $m = J_z = 0$ ). In this configuration, the collective spin variance scales quadratically ( $\propto N^2$ ) rather than linearly as for uncorrelated states ( $\propto N$ ). Consequently, the resulting phase sensitivity bypasses the standard  $1/\sqrt{N}$  shot-noise scaling of the SQL and approaches the fundamental Heisenberg limit ( $\Delta\phi \propto 1/N$ ), offering the ultimate precision allowed by quantum mechanics [18].

To pave the way toward this goal, the work presented in this chapter focuses on an essential prerequisite: the spectroscopic identification of the molecular states involved in this spin-selective dissipative process. The main objective here is to benchmark the photoassociation mechanism itself, laying the necessary spectroscopic foundation for future state-purification protocols.

This chapter opens with the fundamental concepts of scattering theory required to describe photoassociation and atomic density dynamics via one- and two-body loss processes. Next, we present preliminary experimental results obtained with  $^{88}\text{Sr}$ , taking advantage of its well-documented molecular potentials to calibrate and benchmark our experimental setup. Building upon these foundations, we then investigate the fermionic isotope  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ . We present the experimental spectra and discuss the technical challenges and systematic effects that could account for the low contrast observed in the molecular lines. Finally, we conclude with an analysis of the surprisingly rich line spectrum and line shapes, which suggest yet unexplained physical mechanisms at play.

## 3.1 Introduction to photoassociation

### 3.1.1 Scattering theory

Understanding the PA process necessitates an introduction to scattering theory to define key quantities such as the scattering length and the optical length. These parameters emerge naturally from the asymptotic analysis of the radial Schrödinger equation describing the relative motion of two colliding atoms.

In the study of inter-atomic interactions, the Born-Oppenheimer approximation provides a natural simplification. Due to the large mass ratio between the nuclei and the electrons, the nuclei move on a much slower timescale. One can therefore solve the electronic problem for fixed nuclear positions. The resulting electronic energy curve as a function of the inter-nuclear distance  $r$  defines the adiabatic potential  $\hat{U}(r)$  experienced by the two atoms.

Assuming a spherically symmetric potential  $\hat{U}(r)$ , the treatment of the two-body collision in the center-of-mass frame allows the total relative wavefunction to be factorized into radial and angular parts:

$$\psi(r, \theta, \phi) = \frac{u_l(r)}{r} Y_l^m(\theta, \phi) \quad (3.1)$$

where the spherical harmonics  $Y_l^m(\theta, \phi)$  encode the angular dependence and  $l$  denotes the partial wave quantum number. By introducing the reduced mass of the two-atom system  $\mu_N = m_{\text{at}}/2$ , the Schrödinger equation reduces to a one-dimensional radial equation for each partial wave  $l$ :

$$\left(-\frac{\hbar^2}{2\mu_N}\frac{d^2}{dr^2} + \frac{\hbar^2 l(l+1)}{2\mu_N r^2} + \hat{U}(r)\right) u_l(r) = E u_l(r) \quad (3.2)$$

E the eigenvalue associated to the eigenfunction  $u(r)$ . This one-dimensional structure allows a direct analogy with the 1D quantum framework [111]. To extract the scattering properties of the system, one studies the asymptotic behavior of the solutions at large distances. Where the inter-atomic potential  $\hat{V}(r)$  vanishes, the general solution for  $u_l(r)$  takes the form [112]:

$$u_l(r) \xrightarrow{r \rightarrow \infty} a_l \sin\left(kr - \frac{l\pi}{2} + \delta_l\right) \quad (3.3)$$

where  $a_l$  is a normalization factor,  $k = \sqrt{2\mu_N E}/\hbar$  is the collision wavenumber, and  $\delta_l$  is the phase shift acquired by the  $l$ -th partial wave due to the short-range interaction potential.

For inter-atomic distances where  $1/r^2$  and  $V(r)$  are important [112]

$$u_l(r) \propto r^{l+1} + \frac{a}{r^l} \quad (3.4)$$

$a$  a constant. Then continuity of the wavefunction in the full space imposes a constraint on the phase shifts which at low momenta  $k$  that finds:

$$\delta_l \propto k^{2l+1} \quad (3.5)$$

For s-waves ( $l = 0$ ), this leads to the definition of the scattering length:

$$a = -\lim_{k \rightarrow 0} \delta_0/k \quad (3.6)$$

The full wavefunction is recovered by summing over all partial waves. At large distances, this superposition can be rewritten as an incoming plane wave and an outgoing scattered spherical wave:

$$\Psi \xrightarrow{r \rightarrow \infty} e^{i\mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{z}} + f(\theta) \frac{e^{ikr}}{r} \quad (3.7)$$

where  $f(\theta)$  is the scattering amplitude which can model both elastic and inelastic collisions and  $\theta$  is the angle between the incident and scattered wavevectors. This amplitude expresses for a specific partial wave  $l$  as

$$f_l = \frac{1}{2ik}(e^{2i\delta_l} - 1) \quad (3.8)$$

The asymptotical expression of  $\Psi$  and  $e^{ikz}$  is expressed in a spherical basis as a sum over all the partial waves. Then we can give as in 3.7 a decomposition of  $\Psi$ :

$$\Psi \simeq \frac{i}{2kr} \sum_{l=0}^{\infty} (2l+1) \left( (-1)^l e^{-ikr} - S_l e^{ikr} \right) \quad (3.9)$$

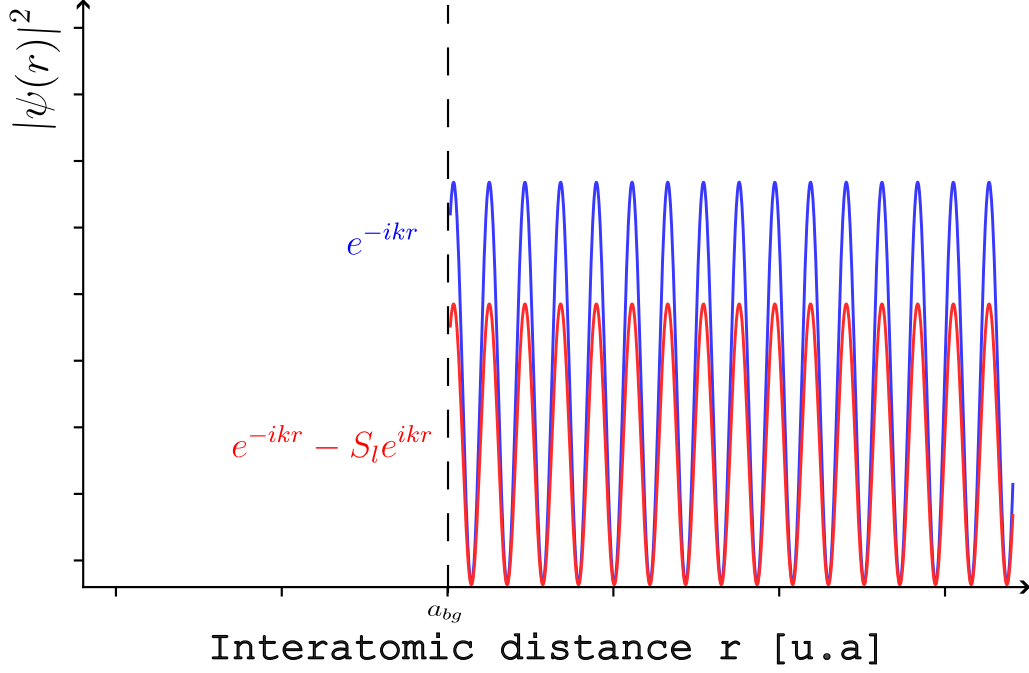


Figure 3.1: The wavefunction  $\Psi$  at large inter-atomic distances  $r$  behaves as a summation of an incoming plane wave and an outgoing spherical wave with attenuated amplitude  $f(\theta)$ . Here is a representation of this wavefunction for s-wave collisions at  $l = 0$ . The scattering occurs at background scattering length  $r = a_{bg}$  the distance where the elastic collisions properties start to be modified.

where we identify a spherical part and a scattering term with  $S_l = e^{2i\delta_l}$  a coefficient characterising the weight of the inelastic collisions.

In the presence of inelastic processes such as photoassociation, the colliding atom pair can be irreversibly lost from the scattering channel-either by forming a bound molecular state or by releasing kinetic energy. This loss of flux from the incoming channel cannot be captured by a purely real phase shift, as  $|S_l| = 1$  implies full conservation of the wavefunction amplitude. To account for this absorption of flux,  $\delta_l$  must be extended to the complex plane, allowing  $|S_l| < 1$  and introducing the possibility of inelastic scattering.

The associated elastic cross section representing the surface where the scope of the potential is effective writes as

$$\sigma_{el} = \frac{\pi}{k^2} \sum_{l=0}^{\infty} (2l+1) |1 - S_l|^2 \quad (3.10)$$

But we see in equation 3.9 that  $|S_l|$  needs to be  $< 1$  to allow dissipation of the wavefunction. Defining  $\delta_l$  as a complex number satisfies this condition and the inelastic cross section is

$$\sigma_{inel} = \frac{\pi}{k^2} \sum_{l=0}^{\infty} (2l+1) (1 - |S_l|^2) \quad (3.11)$$

Then from the condition  $\delta_0 \ll 1$  we deduce an approximated scattering amplitude  $S_0$

$$S_0 = e^{2i\delta_0} \simeq 1 + 2i\delta_0 \quad (3.12)$$

Added to the result of 3.6,

$$1 + 2i\delta_0 \simeq 1 - 2ika \quad (3.13)$$

Because  $\delta_0$  is complex, a direct result of these equations is that we can write a general scattering length as

$$a = a_{bg} + ia'' \quad (3.14)$$

At low temperatures we can re-express equations 3.10 and 3.11 as

$$\sigma_{el} = 4\pi|a|^2 \quad (3.15)$$

$$\sigma_{inel} = \frac{4\pi}{k}|a''| \quad (3.16)$$

As an illustration a usual case of the elastic collisions is atoms in the ground state. For inelasticity photoassociation is a good example of dissipative process where two atoms in the ground state are coupled to a molecular state by a laser.

### 3.1.2 PA and complex scattering length

Photoassociation (PA) is a process in which a pair of colliding free atoms absorbs a photon to form a bound molecule in an excited electronic state. Effectively, because the short-lived molecule quickly decays into deeply bound states or dissociates with high kinetic energy, it escapes the optical trap. Consequently, the bound molecule is typically seen as lost, and the process is perceived as a macroscopic two-body loss effect.

In the atomic pair frame, the electric dipole interaction drives the system from the ground electronic state  $\psi_g$  of potential  $U_g(r)$  to the excited molecular state  $\psi_e$  of potential  $U_e(r)$ . In the absence of a resonant laser, the internal evolution of the system is purely elastic and expresses as:

$$i\hbar \frac{d}{dt} \begin{pmatrix} \psi_g \\ \psi_e \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -\frac{\hbar^2}{2\mu} \nabla^2 + U_g & 0 \\ 0 & -\frac{\hbar^2}{2\mu} \nabla^2 + U_e - i\hbar \frac{\Gamma_{mol}}{2} \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} \psi_g \\ \psi_e \end{pmatrix}. \quad (3.17)$$

Both  $\psi_g$  and its field-free counterpart  $\psi_g^{(0)}$  introduced below are continuum states and cannot be normalized to unity. We adopt the standard energy normalization  $\langle \psi_g(E) | \psi_g(E') \rangle = \delta(E - E')$ , which fixes the s-wave asymptotic form to  $\psi_g^{(0)}(r, E) \rightarrow \sqrt{2\mu/(\pi\hbar^2 k)} \sin(kr + \eta_0)$ . This convention is not a mere bookkeeping choice: it is precisely what sets the density of final states entering Fermi's Golden Rule to unity, so that transition rates below can be written as  $2\pi |\langle f | H' | i \rangle|^2$  without an additional explicit density-of-states factor.

In the frame of [113] one treats the case when a laser is tuned near a specific vibrational level of the excited potential  $U_e(r)$ , coupling the free-atom continuum to the bound molecular state, as illustrated in Fig. 3.2.

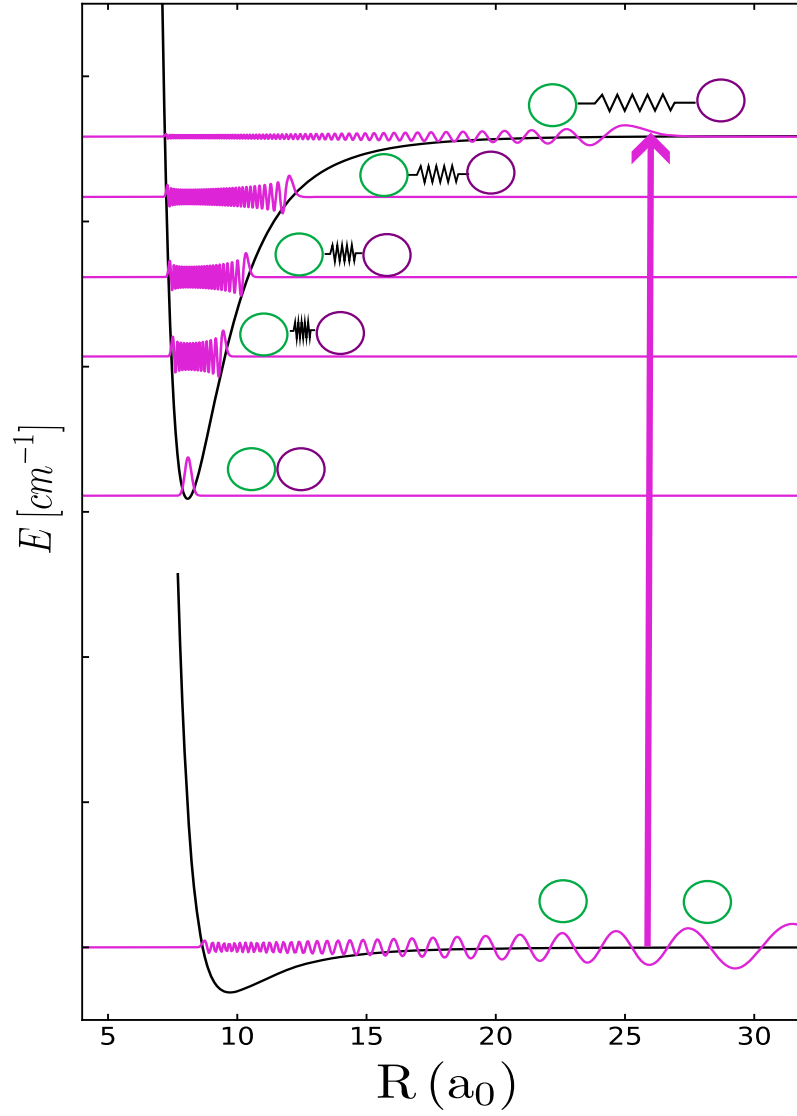


Figure 3.2: Adapted from [114]. General concept of photoassociation: a resonant laser couples a pair of colliding atoms from the free-atom continuum to a bound state of an excited molecular potential. Within this potential, the molecule occupies quantized vibrational states, described by the solutions of the 1D radial Schrödinger equation plotted for each level.

This coupling introduces inelastic channels into the system. The effective coupled-channel equation becomes:

$$i\hbar \frac{d}{dt} \begin{pmatrix} \psi_g \\ \psi_e \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -\frac{\hbar^2}{2\mu} \nabla^2 + U_g & \hbar\Omega/2 \\ \hbar\Omega/2 & -\frac{\hbar^2}{2\mu} \nabla^2 + U_e + \hbar\Delta - i\hbar\frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2} \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} \psi_g \\ \psi_e \end{pmatrix} \quad (3.18)$$

where  $\Gamma_{\text{mol}}$  is the natural molecular spontaneous emission linewidth,  $\Delta = \omega_e - \omega_L$  is the laser detuning from the excited bound state, and  $\hbar\Omega/2$  represents the coherent optical coupling.

This matrix equation shows that the laser creates a bridge between the two manifolds. During a collision, two atoms approaching each other on the ground potential  $U_g(r)$  have a non-zero probability to absorb a photon and transition to the excited molecular potential  $U_e(r)$ . Once populated, this state decays via spontaneous emission at a rate  $\Gamma_{\text{mol}}$ . To account for this particle loss within the quantum mechanical framework, the molecular decay appears as an imaginary term  $-i\hbar\frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2}$  in the Hamiltonian matrix. In quantum scattering theory, such an imaginary component acts as a sink that absorbs probability flux, directly translating the physical disappearance of the atoms from the elastic channel.

Since the laser is tuned far from any bare atomic resonance, the excited molecular state remains weakly populated, meaning the atoms spend most of their time interacting on the ground-state potential. To isolate the response of the excited molecular channel, we expand the closed-channel wavefunction  $\psi_e(r)$  onto the bound vibrational eigenstates  $|v_e\rangle$  of the excited Hamiltonian  $\hat{H}_e = -\frac{\hbar^2 \nabla^2}{2\mu} + U_e(r)$ , which satisfy  $\hat{H}_e |v_e\rangle = E_{v_e} |v_e\rangle$ .

As with Bohn and Julienne [115], who restrict their treatment to a single vibrational resonance well separated from its neighbours (and, in their case, from any hyperfine structure), we retain only the vibrational level  $v_e$  nearest to resonance in the expansion of  $\psi_e$  (isolated-resonance approximation), rather than truncating a perturbative expansion in laser intensity. For  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ , this restriction must additionally extend across the hyperfine manifold: since the  $^3P_1$  hyperfine splitting ( $\gtrsim 1$  GHz [30]) far exceeds both  $\Gamma_{\text{mol}}$  and the range of detuning explored here, different  $F'$  levels remain well-resolved, isolated resonances in their own right. The full expectation value  $\langle \hat{V} \rangle$  would, in principle, also contain contributions from every other ( $v'_e, F'$ ) manifold; these terms are not intrinsically negligible in magnitude, but each is suppressed by its own large, off-resonant energy denominator.

Projecting the second line of Eq. 3.18 onto a specific isolated vibrational state  $|v_e\rangle$  yields:

$$E\psi_e = \frac{\hbar\hat{\Omega}}{2}\psi_g + \left( \hat{H}_e + \hbar\Delta - i\hbar\frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2} \right) \psi_e \quad (3.19)$$

$$\langle v_e | (E - \hat{H}_e - \hbar\Delta + i\hbar\frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2}) | \psi_e \rangle = \langle v_e | \frac{\hbar\hat{\Omega}}{2} | \psi_g \rangle \quad (3.20)$$

$$\psi_e(r) \approx \frac{\left\langle v_e \left| \frac{\hbar\hat{\Omega}(r)}{2} \right| \psi_g \right\rangle}{E - E_{v_e} - \hbar\Delta + i\hbar\frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2}} v_e(r) \quad (3.21)$$

Substituting this spatial projection back into the ground-state channel (first line of

Eq. 3.18) yields:

$$i\hbar \frac{d}{dt} \psi_g = \left( -\frac{\hbar^2 \hat{\nabla}^2}{2\mu} + \hat{U}_g \right) \psi_g + \frac{\hbar \hat{\Omega}}{2} \psi_e \quad (3.22)$$

$$\left( E + \frac{\hbar^2 \hat{\nabla}^2}{2\mu} - \hat{U}_g \right) \psi_g = \frac{\hbar \hat{\Omega}}{2} \psi_e \quad (3.23)$$

$$\left( E + \frac{\hbar^2 \hat{\nabla}^2}{2\mu} - \hat{U}_g \right) \psi_g = \underbrace{\frac{\frac{\hbar \hat{\Omega}}{2} |v_e\rangle \langle v_e| \frac{\hbar \hat{\Omega}}{2} |\psi_g\rangle}{E - E_{v_e} - \hbar \Delta + i\hbar \frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2}}}_{\equiv \hat{V} \psi_g} \quad (3.24)$$

$$\left( -\frac{\hbar^2 \hat{\nabla}^2}{2\mu} + \hat{U}_g(r) + \hat{V} \right) \psi_g(r) = E \psi_g(r) \quad (3.25)$$

One wants to isolate the term that concerns the ground state to observe the modifications of it from the coupling to the molecular state. Then by projecting  $|\psi_g\rangle$  in 3.25 we define  $\langle \hat{V} \rangle$  as:

$$\langle \psi_g | \hat{V} | \psi_g \rangle = \frac{\left| \left\langle v_e \left| \frac{\hbar \hat{\Omega}(r)}{2} \right| \psi_g \right\rangle \right|^2}{E - E_{v_e} - \hbar \Delta + i\hbar \frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2}} \quad (3.26)$$

### From $\hat{V}$ to a shift of the scattering length.

The general relationship used here between a coupling potential and a resulting shift of the scattering length is the same Green's function argument that underlies the two-channel treatment of Feshbach resonances in [?] (see their Eqs. 13, 17, 19 and 22): there, the coupling matrix element  $\langle \phi_{\text{res}} | W | \phi_p^{(+)} \rangle$  plays exactly the role of our  $\langle v_e | \frac{\hbar \hat{\Omega}}{2} | \psi_g^{(0)} \rangle$ , and their scattering-length shift (their Eq. 22) has the same structure as the one derived below. We reproduce this result directly in position space, working at leading order in the laser coupling.

To relate  $\langle \hat{V} \rangle$  to  $a(\Delta)$ , compare the full solution  $\psi_g$  of Eq. 3.25 to the background solution  $\psi_g^{(0)}$  of the same equation with  $\hat{V} \rightarrow 0$ , both evaluated at the same threshold energy  $E \rightarrow 0$ :

$$-\frac{\hbar^2 \hat{\nabla}^2}{2\mu} \psi_g^{(0)} + \hat{U}_g \psi_g^{(0)} = E \psi_g^{(0)}, \quad (3.27)$$

which is simply Eq. 3.25 with the coupling to the molecular channel switched off, consistent with  $\psi_g^{(0)}$  describing purely elastic collisions on  $U_g$  alone as in Eq. 3.17. Subtracting Eq. 3.27 from Eq. 3.25 (both at the same  $E$ ), multiplying the former by  $\psi_g$  and the latter by  $\psi_g^{(0)}$ , and subtracting, gives

$$\frac{d}{dr} \left[ \psi_g^{(0)'} \psi_g - \psi_g' \psi_g^{(0)} \right] = \frac{2\mu}{\hbar^2} \hat{V} \psi_g \psi_g^{(0)}.$$

Integrating from  $r = 0$ , where both wavefunctions vanish, to  $r \rightarrow \infty$ , where  $\psi_g^{(0)} \rightarrow r - a_{\text{bg}}$  and  $\psi_g \rightarrow r - a$  by definition of the scattering length, yields

$$\delta a \equiv a - a_{\text{bg}} = -\frac{2\mu}{\hbar^2} \int_0^\infty \hat{V}(r) \psi_g(r) \psi_g^{(0)}(r) dr.$$

This integral still contains the full, unknown  $\psi_g$ , so nothing has been solved yet. To make progress, write  $\psi_g = \psi_g^{(0)} + \delta\psi$ , where  $\delta\psi$  is the correction to the wavefunction caused by switching on  $\hat{V}$ . Since  $\hat{V}$  already involves the coupling  $\frac{\hbar\Omega}{2}$  twice – once to excite to  $v_e$ , once to decay back – it is proportional to  $\Omega^2$ ; the correction  $\delta\psi$  it induces is therefore also of order  $\Omega^2$ . Splitting the integral according to  $\psi_g = \psi_g^{(0)} + \delta\psi$  gives one term with  $\psi_g^{(0)}$  in place of  $\psi_g$ , plus an extra term proportional to  $\hat{V} \delta\psi$ ; since both factors are of order  $\Omega^2$ , this extra term is of order  $\Omega^4$  – a much smaller correction, which can be dropped consistently with the weak-population assumption already stated above. Keeping only the leading term thus amounts to replacing  $\psi_g$  by  $\psi_g^{(0)}$  inside the integral:

$$\delta a \approx -\frac{2\mu}{\hbar^2} \int_0^\infty \hat{V}(r) [\psi_g^{(0)}(r)]^2 dr = -\frac{2\mu}{\hbar^2} \langle \hat{V} \rangle,$$

i.e. Eq. 3.26 evaluated on the background threshold state. This identifies

$$a(\Delta) = a_{\text{bg}} - \frac{2\mu}{\hbar^2} \langle \hat{V} \rangle = a_{\text{bg}} - \frac{2\mu}{\hbar^2} \frac{\left| \left\langle v_e \left| \frac{\hbar\hat{\Omega}(r)}{2} \right| \psi_g^{(0)} \right\rangle \right|^2}{E - E_{v_e} - \hbar\Delta + i\hbar\frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2}} \quad (3.28)$$

### Explicit form of $l_{\text{opt}}$ via the Wigner threshold law.

Following Bohn and Julienne [115], one can define the stimulated rate  $\Gamma_{\text{stim}}$  from  $|v_e\rangle$  to  $|\psi_g^{(0)}\rangle$  by the Fermi Golden Rule as

$$\Gamma_{\text{stim}}(k) = 2\pi \left( \frac{2\pi I}{c} \right) d^2 |\langle v_e | \psi_g^{(0)} \rangle|^2 \quad (3.29)$$

with  $I$  the laser intensity,  $c$  the speed of light, and  $d$  the transition dipole moment;  $\frac{\hbar\hat{\Omega}(r)}{2} = \vec{d} \cdot \vec{E}$  is the dipolar coupling to the laser field  $\vec{E}$ , so the numerator of Eq. 3.28 is identified with  $\hbar\Gamma_{\text{stim}}(k)$ , which depends on the **Franck-Condon factor**  $\langle v_e | \psi_g^{(0)} \rangle$ , the overlap between the (energy-normalized) ground-state scattering wavefunction and the excited molecular state.

Because  $\psi_g^{(0)}$  is energy-normalized, its amplitude at the moderate separations relevant to this overlap follows the s-wave Wigner threshold law and scales as  $\sqrt{k}$  as  $E \rightarrow 0$  [107]: writing  $\psi_g^{(0)}(r, E \rightarrow 0) \approx \sqrt{k} f_0(r)$  for a  $k$ -independent reference function  $f_0$ , one obtains  $|\langle v_e | \psi_g^{(0)} \rangle|^2 = k |\langle v_e | f_0 \rangle|^2$ , so that  $\Gamma_{\text{stim}}(k) \propto k$ , consistent with the general threshold law  $\Gamma_b(E, \ell) \propto E^{\ell+1/2}$  for  $\ell = 0$  [107]. Writing this proportionality as [116]

$$\Gamma_{\text{stim}}(k) = 2k l_{\text{opt}} \Gamma_{\text{mol}} \quad (3.30)$$

defines the  $k$ -independent **optical length**

$$l_{\text{opt}} \equiv \frac{\pi}{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}} \left( \frac{2\pi I}{c} \right) d^2 |\langle v_e | f_0 \rangle|^2, \quad (3.31)$$

which is independent of collision energy and scales linearly with the laser intensity  $I$ , as required.

### Compact resonant form.

Absorbing  $E_{ve}$  into a redefinition of the detuning origin and using Eqs. 3.29-3.31, Eq. 3.28 reduces to

$$a(\Delta) = a_{\text{bg}} + \frac{l_{\text{opt}}\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{\Delta + i\frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2}} \quad (3.32)$$

where  $a_{\text{bg}}$  is the real background scattering length representing native elastic collisions [116].

To distinguish how the laser independently alters the elastic interactions and the loss mechanisms, we multiply the resonant fraction in Eq. 3.32 by the complex conjugate of its denominator. This algebraic separation successfully decouples the scattering length into its real (dispersive) and imaginary (absorptive) components,  $a(\Delta) = a_{\text{bg}} + \delta a(\Delta) - ia''(\Delta)$ :

$$a(\Delta) = a_{\text{bg}} + \frac{l_{\text{opt}}\Gamma_{\text{mol}}\Delta}{\Delta^2 + \left(\frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2}\right)^2} - i\frac{l_{\text{opt}}\Gamma_{\text{mol}}\frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2}}{\Delta^2 + \left(\frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2}\right)^2} \quad (3.33)$$

The real light-induced shift  $\delta a(\Delta)$  governs the modification of the elastic properties of the gas, whereas the imaginary part  $a''(\Delta)$  directly quantifies the rate of inelastic two-body losses.

### 3.1.3 General scaling laws for PA

To connect this microscopic scattering amplitude to observable experimental quantities, one must translate these individual collision events into a population decay that writes as [20]:

$$\frac{dN}{dt} = -\beta(T)N^2 - \Gamma N \quad (3.34)$$

where  $\beta(T)$  is related to the two-body loss rate  $K_2$  and  $\Gamma$  is the one-body loss rate that depends experimentally mostly on the vacuum quality.

In quantum scattering theory, the fundamental two-body loss rate coefficient  $K_2(k)$  is directly driven by the absorptive (imaginary) part of the scattering length  $a''$  derived from Eq. 3.26:

$$K_2(k) = \frac{16\pi\hbar}{m_{\text{at}}}a''(k, \Delta) \quad (3.35)$$

Grounded on the systematic study of optical Feshbach resonances by Blatt et al. [117], substituting the expression of  $a''$  into Eq. 3.35 yields the complete expression for the loss coefficient as a function of the collision wavevector  $k$ :

$$K_2(k) = \frac{4\pi\hbar}{m_{\text{at}}k} \times \frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}\Gamma_{\text{stim}}(k)}{\Delta^2 + \frac{1}{4}(\Gamma_{\text{mol}} + \Gamma_{\text{stim}}(k))^2} \quad (3.36)$$

where  $m_{\text{at}}$  is the atomic mass,  $\Delta = \omega_{\text{L}} - \omega_{\text{mol}}$  is the laser detuning from the molecular resonance, and  $\Gamma_{\text{mol}}$  is the natural molecular linewidth.

While  $K_2$  characterizes the fundamental two-body collision process, the experimentally observed decay coefficient  $\beta$  depends on the spatial density distribution of

the atomic cloud of width  $\sigma_x, \sigma_y, \sigma_z$ . The relation between  $K_2$  and  $\beta$  is derived by integrating the local loss over a Gaussian density profile:

$$\frac{dN(t, T)}{dt} = -K_2 \iiint n^2(x, y, z, t, T) d^3r \quad (3.37)$$

$$\text{with } n(x, y, z, t, T) = n_0 \exp\left(-\frac{x^2}{2\sigma_x(T)^2} - \frac{y^2}{2\sigma_y(T)^2} - \frac{z^2}{2\sigma_z(T)^2}\right) \quad (3.38)$$

$$\text{and } n_0 = \frac{N(t, T)}{(2\pi)^{3/2}\sigma_x(T)\sigma_y(T)\sigma_z(T)} \quad (3.39)$$

$$\frac{dN(t, T)}{dt} = -K_2 \frac{N(t, T)^2}{2\sqrt{2}V_e(T)} \equiv -\beta(T)N(t, T)^2 \quad (3.40)$$

$$\text{where } V_e(T) = (2\pi)^{3/2}\sigma_x(T)\sigma_y(T)\sigma_z(T) \quad (3.41)$$

$$\text{Then } \beta(T) = \frac{K_2}{2\sqrt{2}V_e(T)} \quad (3.42)$$

consistent with the definitions found in [118].

For low temperatures, we neglect the contribution of the wavevector since  $k \rightarrow 0$ . In this threshold regime, the light-induced linewidth becomes negligible compared to the natural molecular width ( $\Gamma_{\text{stim}}(k) \ll \Gamma_{\text{mol}}$ ). On resonance ( $\Delta = 0$ ), substituting Eq. 3.30 into Eq. 3.36 allows the wavevector  $k$  to cancel out from the prefactor, and the microscopic PA rate coefficient simplifies to:

$$K_2 = \frac{16h}{m_{\text{at}}} l_{\text{opt}} \quad (3.43)$$

This fundamental result demonstrates that at low temperatures, the maximum photoassociation rate becomes independent of the temperature and scales purely linearly with the laser intensity  $I$  through its dependence on  $l_{\text{opt}}$ . Structurally,  $K_2$  is maximized when the ground- and excited-state wavefunctions exhibit maximum overlap at the Condon radius. In a classical picture, this distance corresponds to the turning point where the colliding atoms spend the most time, maximizing the transition probability.

Finally, by combining Eq. 3.42 and the low-temperature limit of  $K_2$ , we obtain the total macroscopic evolution equation of the trapped population:

$$\frac{dN}{dt} = -\frac{4\sqrt{2}h}{V_e m_{\text{at}}} l_{\text{opt}} N^2 - \Gamma N \quad (3.44)$$

which highlights that the global loss process is driven by the tunable optical length  $l_{\text{opt}}$  and enhanced by the peak atomic density  $n_0 \propto 1/V_e$ .

### 3.1.4 Handling multiple molecular potentials

So far, the photoassociation (PA) process has been presented assuming a simplified picture with a single excited-state molecular potential  $U_e$ . However, the molecules

created via PA exhibit a rich internal structure, making the identification of accessible excited states essential for predicting and optimizing the loss rate coefficient  $\beta(T)$ .

Unlike atomic spectroscopy, where selecting target states is straightforward, identifying specific molecular target states is significantly more involved due to the dense coexistence of multiple potential energy curves. Following the Born-Oppenheimer approximation, the fast electronic motion decouples from the slower nuclear motion. Each distinct molecular electronic configuration—labeled by its set of molecular quantum numbers—gives rise to an adiabatic potential energy curve  $U_e(r)$ . Determining these curves  $U_e(r)$  is crucial, as they dictate the bound-state wavefunctions  $\psi_e(r)$  and govern the overall PA dynamics.

#### 3.1.4.1 Symmetry constraints and Pauli exclusion principle

In ultracold gases, ground-state collisions occur predominantly in the  $s$ -wave regime ( $R_i = 0$ ), as higher partial waves ( $l > 0$ ) are reflected by the centrifugal barrier before reaching the short-range interaction region. For fermionic  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  atoms, Fermi-Dirac statistics impose a overall antisymmetric wavefunction  $|\Psi\rangle$  under nuclear permutation.

For two identical atoms A and B with spatial states  $|\beta_1\rangle$  and  $|\beta_2\rangle$ , the total molecular wavefunction is expressed as:

$$|\Psi\rangle = (|\beta_1\rangle_A |\beta_2\rangle_B - \rho \times p |\beta_1\rangle_B |\beta_2\rangle_A) \otimes |\phi\rangle \quad (3.45)$$

where  $|\phi\rangle$  represents the total nuclear spin wavefunction. Since  $s$ -wave collisions ( $R_i = 0$ ) feature a symmetric spatial wavefunction, Pauli’s principle mandates that the ground-state nuclear spin wavefunction  $|\phi\rangle$  must be antisymmetric. Because electric dipole ( $E1$ ) transitions act purely on electronic and spatial degrees of freedom, the nuclear spin acts as a spectator; hence,  $|\phi\rangle$  **remains antisymmetric throughout the PA process**.

Following [119],  $\rho = p_1 p_2$  denotes the product of the intrinsic electronic parities of the two isolated atoms, while  $p = (-1)^R$  reflects the rotational parity associated with the **molecular rotational quantum number  $R$** .

#### 3.1.4.2 Angular momentum coupling and state enumeration

Spin-orbit coupling plays a dominant role in shaping the excited molecular structure near the  $^1\text{S}_0 - ^3\text{P}_1$  intercombination asymptote. The total angular momentum of the molecule is defined by  $T = R + F = R + I + J$ , where  $F = f_1 + f_2$  is the coupled atomic angular momentum,  $J = j_1 + j_2$  is the total electronic angular momentum, and  $R$  is the rotational angular momentum.

Along the internuclear axis, the projection of the electronic angular momentum is quantified by:

$$\Omega = \Lambda + \Sigma \quad (3.46)$$

where  $\Lambda$  and  $\Sigma$  represent the internuclear projections of the orbital and spin angular momenta, respectively. Because spin-orbit interaction is strong relative to rotational coupling at short to intermediate ranges, the molecule is appropriately described

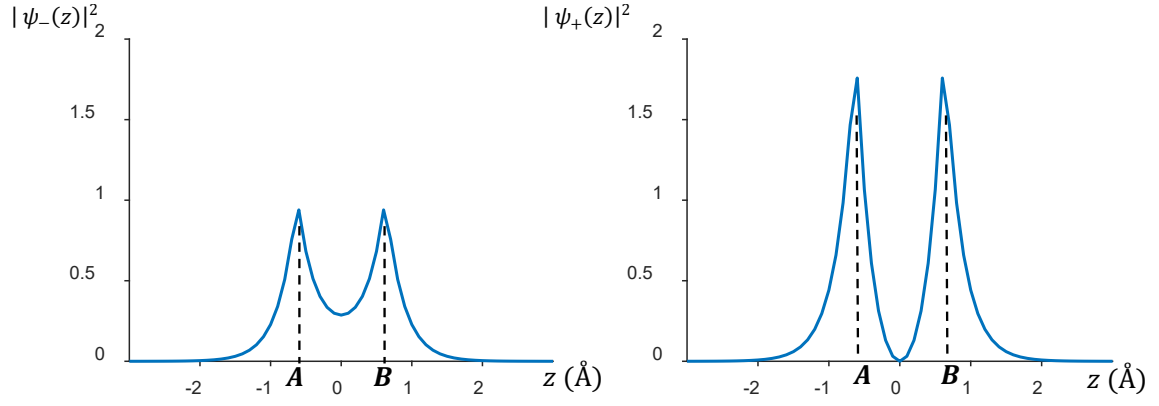


Figure 3.3: Gerade ( $g$ ) and ungerade ( $u$ ) spatial electronic wavefunctions for electrons orbiting nuclei A and B. Left: Square modulus  $|\psi_{-}(z)|^2$  for an ungerade state, showing a non-zero probability density between the two nuclei. Right: For a gerade state, the electronic probability density vanishes at the midpoint between the nuclei.

within Hund's case (c) framework (see Fig. 3.4), where  $\Omega$  remains a good quantum number.

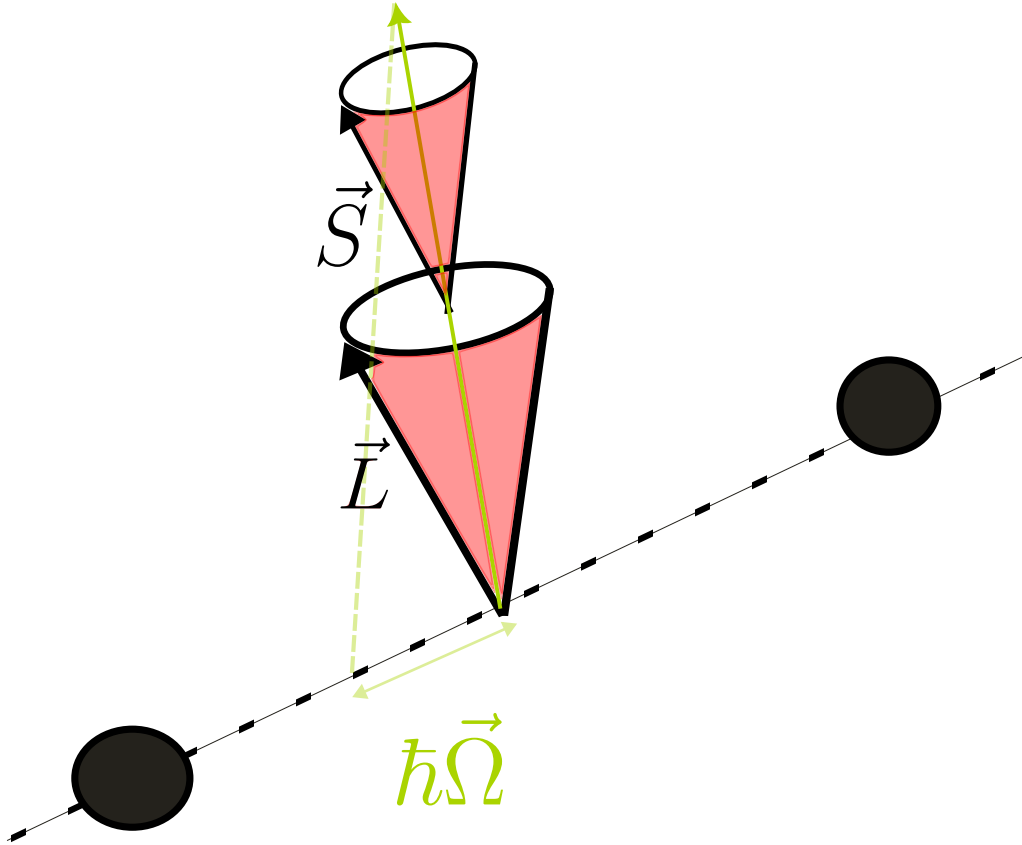


Figure 3.4: Hund's case (c) coupling scheme, where strong spin-orbit interaction couples the total electronic angular momentum to the internuclear axis with projection  $\hbar\Omega$ . In most ultracold photoassociation scenarios, the rotational quantum number is low ( $R = 0, 1$ ).

To determine the accessible target molecular states, we analyze the parity requirements in both initial and final asymptotes:

- **Ground collisional state ( $^1\text{S}_0 + ^1\text{S}_0$ ):**

Both atoms share identical, even electronic parity ( $p_1 = p_2 = +1$ ), giving  $\rho = +1$ . To maintain an overall antisymmetric wavefunction with an antisymmetric spin state  $|\phi\rangle$ , we require  $\rho \times p = +1$ . This implies  $p = +1$ , which restricts ground  $s$ -wave collisions to even rotational numbers ( $R_i = 0, 2, \dots$ ).

- **Excited molecular state ( $^1\text{S}_0 + ^3\text{P}_1$ ):**

The asymptotic electronic parities are opposite ( $p_1 = +1, p_2 = -1$ ), leading to a constant electronic parity product  $\rho = -1$ . Because the nuclear spin state remains antisymmetric, the Pauli constraint  $\rho \times p = +1$  requires  $p = -1$ . Consequently, the excited molecular states accessible from  $s$ -wave collisions must feature odd rotational quantum numbers ( $R_f = 1, 3, 5, \dots$ ).

Applying these selection rules to  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  atoms photoassociated in the  $F = 11/2$  manifold (with  $f_1 = 9/2$  for  $^1\text{S}_0$  and  $f_2 = 11/2$  for  $^3\text{P}_1$ ), the electronic angular momentum  $J = 1$  couples with nuclear spin to yield total atomic angular momenta  $F \in \{1, 2, \dots, 10\}$ . Combining  $F$  with the allowed odd rotational modes ( $R_f = 1, 3, 5, \dots$ ) and taking into account electric dipole selection rules ( $|\Delta T| \leq 1$  with  $T = 0 \not\rightarrow T = 0$ ), the accessible final states  $T^f$  satisfy:

$$\text{For } R_f = 1, \quad T^f \in \{1, 2, \dots, 10\} \quad (3.47)$$

$$\text{For } R_f = 3, \quad T^f \in \{1, 2, \dots, 10\} \quad (3.48)$$

$$\text{For } R_f = 5, \quad T^f \in \{1, 2, \dots, 10\} \quad (3.49)$$

### 3.1.4.3 Effective hamiltonian and potential modeling

Taking into account the hyperfine-induced mixing between  $g$  and  $u$  electronic manifolds ( $0_u, 1_u, 0_g, 1_g$ ) at long range—analogueous to observations in  $^{173}\text{Yb}$  [118]—we estimate a total of approximately 981 accessible  $(R_f, T^f)$  molecular configurations. This massive density of states illustrates the extreme complexity of the excited molecular spectrum to be mapped experimentally.

The high density of states expected for  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  makes spectral assignment particularly challenging. To move beyond a statistical estimation and accurately predict the energy levels of these 981 configurations, precise modeling of the molecular interaction is required. This involves describing the coupling between the rotation of the nuclear frame, the electronic degrees of freedom, and the hyperfine structure.

Following the molecular picture introduced in Section 3.1.1, the energy of these states is governed by the total hamiltonian  $\hat{H}$ , which for a Sr-Sr system of reduced mass  $\mu_N$  can be expressed as:

$$\hat{H} = \frac{p_r^2}{2\mu_N} + \frac{\hbar^2}{2\mu_N r^2} R(R+1) + U_{BO} + \hat{H}_{\text{hf}} \quad (3.50)$$

the first and second terms representing the kinetic energy and radial energy of the molecule. Higher-order electronic interactions have been neglected depending on the relevant Hund's case. For  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ , the Born-Oppenheimer potential  $\hat{U}_{\text{BO}}$  is approximated using a long-range expansion similar to  $^{173}\text{Yb}$ :

$$U_{\text{BO}}(r) = -\frac{C_6}{r^6} \left(1 - \frac{\sigma^6}{r^6}\right) - s \frac{C_3^\Omega}{r^3} \quad (3.51)$$

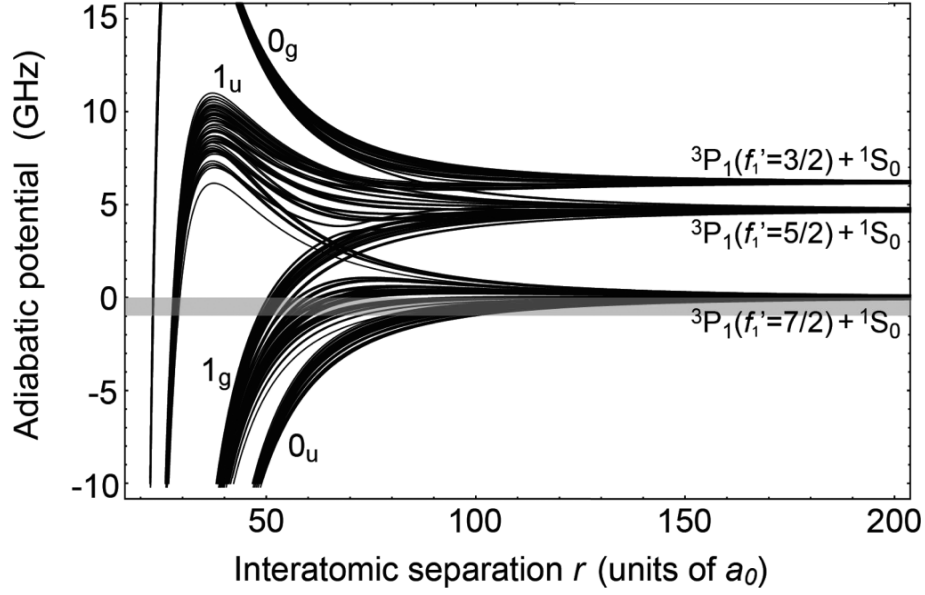


Figure 3.5: Density of molecular potentials for  $^{173}\text{Yb}$  with three hyperfine states, giving rise to numerous triplets of quantum numbers ( $T, F, R$ ). The spectral lines are identified as  $\Omega_{u/g}$ , where  $\Omega$  is the total orbital momentum projection of the molecule and  $u/g$  denotes the electronic parity (see Fig. 3.3).

where  $s = +1$  and  $s = -1$  correspond to  $g$  and  $u$  potentials, respectively.  $C_6$  and  $C_3^\Omega$  are Van der Waals and dipole-dipole coefficients [120],  $\Omega$  still standing for projection of angular momentum, and  $\sigma$  is a free parameter to adjust with the experimental results.

The atomic hyperfine Hamiltonian  $\hat{H}_{\text{hf}}$  acts solely on the  $^3\text{P}_1$  atom (with nuclear spin  $i_1 = 9/2$  and electronic angular momentum  $j_1 = 1$ ), as the ground-state  $^1\text{S}_0$  atom has  $j_2 = 0$  and thus no hyperfine interaction:

$$\hat{H}_{\text{hf}} = A(\mathbf{i}_1 \cdot \mathbf{j}_1) + B \frac{3(\mathbf{i}_1 \cdot \mathbf{j}_1)^2 + \frac{3}{2}(\mathbf{i}_1 \cdot \mathbf{j}_1) - i_1(i_1 + 1)j_1(j_1 + 1)}{2i_1(2i_1 - 1)2j_1(2j_1 - 1)} \quad (3.52)$$

where  $A$  and  $B$  are the magnetic dipole and electric quadrupole hyperfine constants, respectively.

Among these potential curves, approximately 80 bound internal states were experimentally identified for  $^{173}\text{Yb}$  [118]. Atom-loss spectra, recorded as a function of PA laser detuning, reveal the position of bound states relative to the atomic resonance  $|^1\text{S}_0, F = 5/2\rangle \rightarrow |^3\text{P}_1, F = 7/2\rangle$ . Near this threshold, atoms are illuminated for 30 ms at low intensity ( $I = 37 \text{ mW/cm}^2$ ) to avoid power broadening, resolving bound states closest to the dissociation limit. At larger red detunings, higher laser power and optimized exposure times are used to maximize signal depth.

Theoretically, these experimental loss lines are assigned by computing the eigenvalues of the effective Hamiltonian and adjusting parameters such as  $C_n$  coefficients to match observed vibrational levels [120]. Several semi-classical tools aid this assignment: the WKB approximation describes the near-threshold bound states, while

LeRoy-Bernstein scaling predicts the spacing of consecutive vibrational lines near the dissociation limit without requiring detailed short-range potential data. Finally, mass scaling across strontium isotopes [14] serves as a robust benchmark to cross-check these energy assignments.

### 3.1.5 Internal energy states

#### 3.1.5.1 WKB approximation

The Wentzel-Kramers-Brillouin (WKB) approximation is a semi-classical method used to estimate the vibrational eigenvalues of a diatomic system. By modeling the interatomic potential, the position of a first bound state can be determined, which subsequently enables the deduction of the following vibrational levels.

In this approach, the wavefunction is assumed to take the form of a modified plane wave of wavevector  $k(x)$ ,  $\psi(x) = \frac{C}{\sqrt{k(x)}} e^{i \int_{x_0}^x k(x') dx'}$  [121]. These waves are solutions to the one-dimensional Schrödinger equation for two particles with reduced mass  $\mu$  and eigenenergy  $E$ :

$$-\frac{\hbar^2}{2\mu} \frac{d^2\psi}{dx^2} + U(x)\psi = E\psi \quad (3.53)$$

This leads to the expression of the local wavevector  $k(x)$ :

$$k(x) = \frac{p(x)}{\hbar} = \frac{\sqrt{2\mu(E - U(x))}}{\hbar} \quad (3.54)$$

The validity of this approximation is governed by the condition  $\frac{1}{2\pi} \frac{d\lambda}{dx} \ll 1$ , implying that the local de Broglie wavelength  $\lambda$  must vary slowly compared to the scale of the atoms' motion. This can be explicitly rewritten in terms of the potential gradient:

$$\left| \frac{\mu \hbar \frac{dU}{dx}}{[2\mu(E - U(x))]^{3/2}} \right| \ll 1 \quad (3.55)$$

This expression highlights two critical regimes where the semi-classical approach fails. First, near the classical turning points where  $E \approx U(x)$ , the kinetic energy vanishes and the wavelength diverges. Second, at short internuclear distances (Region I in Fig. 3.6), the steepness of the repulsive wall  $|dU/dx|$  becomes too large for the atoms to follow the potential variations adiabatically. In these regions, connection formulas, typically using Airy functions, are required to match the solutions across the turning points.

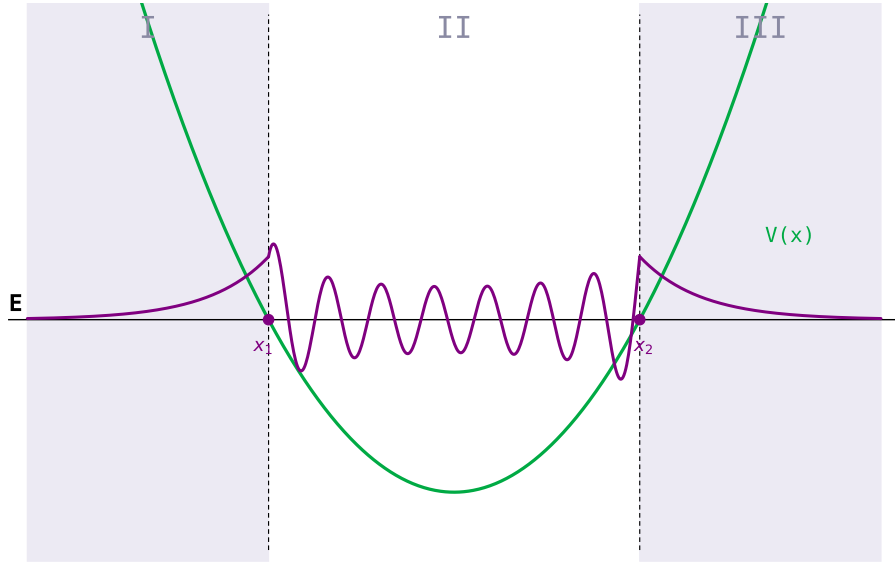


Figure 3.6: Semi-classical approximation at short range in an interatomic potential  $U(x)$ . The energy level  $E$  intersects the potential at the turning points  $x_1$  and  $x_2$ . In the classically allowed Region II, the wavefunction oscillates with an amplitude proportional to  $1/\sqrt{k(x)}$  where in the forbidden Regions I and III, the wavefunction is evanescent.

At positions  $x = x_1$  and  $x_2$ , the momentum reaches zero and becomes imaginary as the energy level  $E$  crosses the potential  $U(x)$ . In the classically forbidden regions I and III, the wavefunction is evanescent and characterized by the decay constant  $\kappa(x) = \sqrt{2\mu(U(x) - E)}/\hbar$ . Around the turning points, it is standard to linearize the potential to connect the oscillatory and evanescent solutions. Region I is generally not studied in detail for photoassociation since the repulsive wall of the potential is extremely steep and diverges at very short distances.

To ensure a physical stationary state, the phase accumulated by the wave as it reflects between the barriers at  $x_1$  and  $x_2$  must satisfy a quantization condition. By ensuring the continuity of the solutions over  $[0, +\infty[$ , the phase integral must follow:

$$\int_{x_1}^{x_2} k(x)dx = \left(n + \frac{1}{2}\right) \pi \quad (3.56)$$

This formula, known as the Bohr-Sommerfeld quantization condition, enables the identification of the discrete energy eigenvalues  $E_n$  that satisfy the integral. these values correspond to the vibrational states of the molecular potential.

### 3.1.5.2 Leroy-Bernstein scaling

The LeRoy-Bernstein scaling law [122] builds upon the WKB approximation to identify the position of the high-lying vibrational states near the dissociation limit. This model is particularly powerful as it relies solely on the long-range behavior of the potential, bypassing the need for a detailed description of the complex short-range interactions.

Near the dissociation limit  $D_e$ , occurring at large internuclear distances  $r$ , the potential can be approximated by its leading long-range term:

$$U(r) \approx D_e - \frac{C_n}{r^n} \quad (3.57)$$

where  $C_n$  is the long-range coefficient (typically  $n = 6$  for Van der Waals or  $n = 3$  for resonant dipole-dipole interactions). For a vibrational state  $\nu$  with energy  $E_\nu$ , we define the binding energy as  $\epsilon_\nu = D_e - E_\nu$ . Substituting this into the Bohr-Sommerfeld quantization condition (Eq. 3.56), we seek solutions for:

$$\int_{r_{min}}^{r_{max}} \frac{\sqrt{2\mu}}{\hbar} \sqrt{\frac{C_n}{r^n} - \epsilon_\nu} dr = (\nu_D - \nu)\pi \quad (3.58)$$

where  $\nu_D$  is a non-integer parameter representing the effective vibrational index at the dissociation limit. After integration, the relationship between the binding energy and the vibrational quantum number is given by:

$$\epsilon_\nu = \left[ (\nu_D - \nu) \frac{\hbar n}{2\mu^{1/2} C_n^{1/n}} \frac{\sqrt{\pi} \Gamma(1/n + 1/2)}{\Gamma(1/n)} \right]^{\frac{2n}{n-2}} \quad (3.59)$$

Here,  $\Gamma$  denotes the Euler Gamma function. This expression is often rearranged to show the scaling of the vibrational spacing:

$$E_\nu = D_e - [(\nu_D - \nu) H_n]^{\frac{2n}{n-2}} \quad (3.60)$$

where  $H_n$  is defined as:

$$H_n = \frac{\hbar n \sqrt{\pi}}{2\mu^{1/2} C_n^{1/n}} \frac{\Gamma(1/n + 1/2)}{\Gamma(1/n)} \quad (3.61)$$

This notation highlights that the binding energy follows a power law relative to the "distance"  $\nu_D - \nu$  from the dissociation limit, where the exponent is purely determined by the nature of the long-range interaction.

### 3.1.5.3 Mass scaling and isotopic shifts

Mass scaling is a powerful method used to predict the vibrational energy levels of different isotopes from a single known potential. By adjusting the reduced mass  $\mu$  corresponding to the isotope considered, one can determine the phase constraint on the vibrational states. While this approach neglects the hyperfine structure, it provides a reliable estimation of the spectral range where vibrational resonances are expected.

In particular,  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  is a bosonic isotope with a nuclear spin  $I = 0$ , meaning it possesses no hyperfine structure. Its photoassociation spectrum is significantly simpler than that of fermionic  $^{173}\text{Yb}$  (see Fig. 3.5), involving only two accessible potentials

in the first excited molecular state:  $0_u$  and  $1_u$ . Based on the results presented in [4], the potential can be modeled as:

$$U(r) \approx -\frac{C_6}{r^6} - \frac{C_3, \Lambda}{r^3} + \frac{\hbar^2 R(R+1)}{2\mu r^2} \quad (3.62)$$

for the two molecular symmetries  $\Lambda = 0, 1$ . Since the Born-Oppenheimer approximation remains valid across the strontium isotopes ( $^{84}\text{Sr}$ ,  $^{86}\text{Sr}$ ,  $^{88}\text{Sr}$ ), the electronic potential  $V_{BO}(r)$  is assumed to be identical for all species. Consequently, only the reduced mass  $\mu$  in the WKB phase integral varies:

$$\int_{x_1}^{x_2} \frac{\sqrt{2\mu(E - U(x))}}{\hbar} dx = \left(n + \frac{1}{2}\right) \pi \quad (3.63)$$

The experimental positions of the first vibrational states for the  $0_u^+$  potential in  $^{84}\text{Sr}$ ,  $^{86}\text{Sr}$ , and  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  are shown as red crosses in Fig. 3.7. These data points allow for the refinement of the potential shape  $U(r)$ . The fitted functions (blue lines) then enable the prediction of the frequency ranges where  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  resonances should occur. Nevertheless article [20] demonstrates the impossibility to determine scattering length on  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  from mass scaling due to the hyperfine interaction of the species. Notably, discontinuities observed for the  $^{84}\text{Sr}$  isotope correspond to avoided crossings resulting from couplings with the ground-state potential.

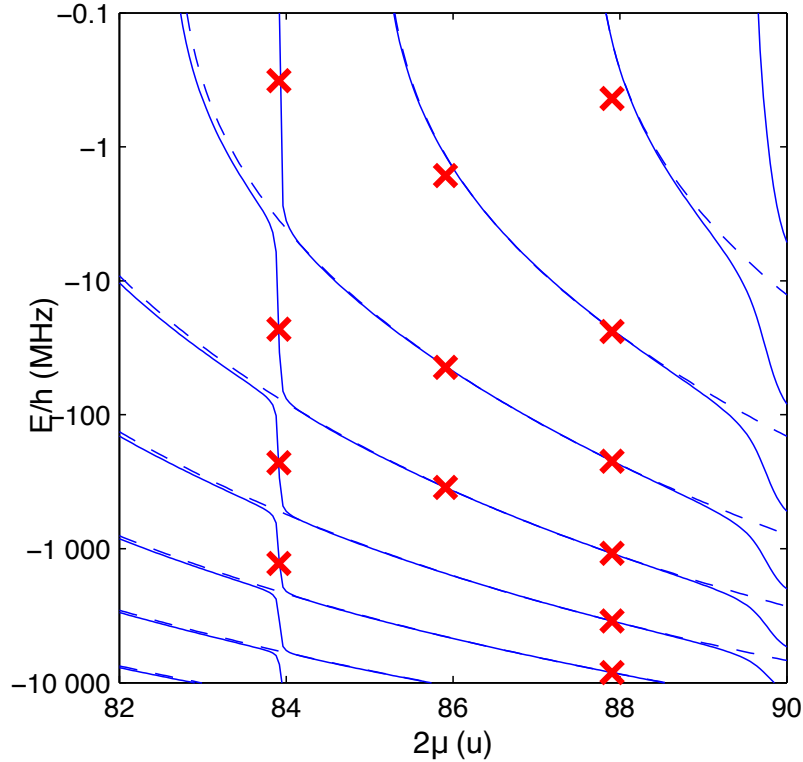


Figure 3.7: This graph - extracted from [14]- confronts the experimental internal states in red crosses to their theoretical predictions for different reduced mass of strontium isotopes. The theoretical model guarantees approximated scales for molecular lines of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  but not precisely because this model neglects the hyperfine interaction of the species.

In conclusion, combining semi-classical WKB theory with LeRoy-Bernstein scaling offers a practical framework to estimate vibrational spacings near the intercombination threshold. This approach serves as a reliable guide for bosonic isotopes like  $^{88}\text{Sr}$ , presented in the next section. However, it cannot account for the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  photoassociation spectra, where instead of the dense manifold of lines, only a few narrow resonances are experimentally observed.

In this first part of the chapter, I have presented the theoretical picture of the photoassociation process where the following introduced material will help to understand the experimental results presented in the next section:

- I demonstrated the relation of the two-body collision rate coefficient  $K_2$  with the scattering length, which includes the parameter  $l_{opt}$  characterizing the strength of the inelastic loss process.
- I presented the different molecular potentials and their symmetries, which should help for future understanding of the results to identify the molecular lines of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ .
- I presented two ways of estimating the position of the molecular states: the WKB approximation to determine the position of the vibrational states that could be complemented by the LeRoy-Bernstein scaling. The second one is the mass scaling that predicts – without considering the hyperfine structure that changes the position of these lines – an estimation of the energy range where the molecular lines of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  should be found.

In the following section I present the experimental protocol used on the  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  species that enables to calibrate the procedure for fermionic molecular lines research.

## 3.2 Spectroscopy protocol and calibration of the photoassociation laser

### 3.2.1 Gas preparation and isotope specificities

I will now present our experiments consisting in identifying photoassociation lines of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ , starting from a characterization of  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  molecular lines abundantly published. The  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  has not been explored yet as explained in the introduction: this is surprising since many results of molecular spectroscopy have been published for strontium isotopes.

The photoassociation (PA) rate is strongly density-dependent, as detailed in Section 3.1.3. The experimental approach differs according to the quantum statistics of the isotope:

- **Fermions ( $^{87}\text{Sr}$ ):** High densities are achieved by optimizing evaporative cooling ramps once the atoms are loaded into the crossed Optical Dipole Trap (ODT).
- **Bosons ( $^{88}\text{Sr}$ ):** The near-zero scattering length of  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  is detrimental to evaporative cooling, as it suppresses the elastic collisions necessary for thermalization. In this case, the final density relies almost exclusively on the efficiency

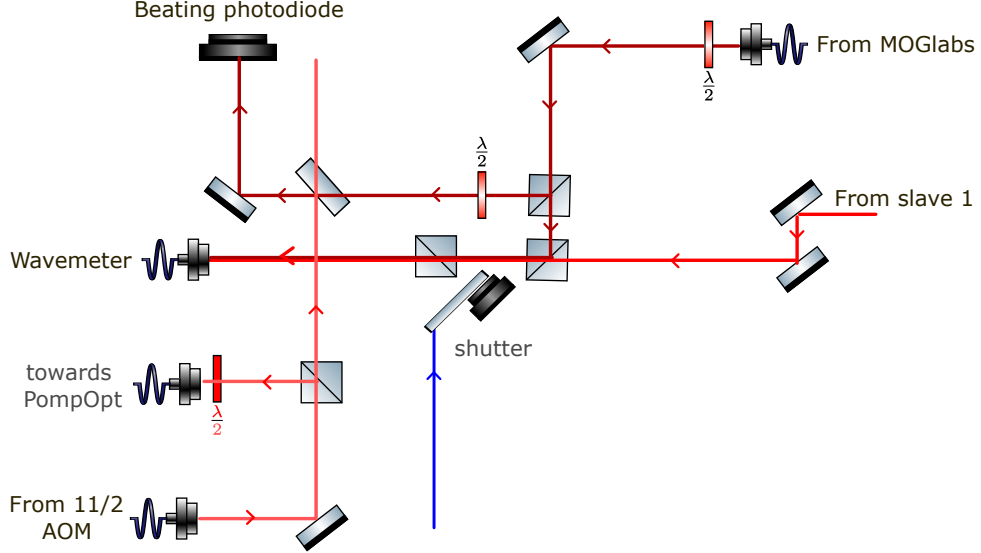


Figure 3.8: Beating scheme for PA process between the light from "AOM 11/2" that is settled on the resonance  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_1, F = 11/2$ , and MOGLabs. The light is coming from 3.19 to split in two arms: optical pumping and PA. This last one serves for MOGLabs locking in a beating procedure where the beam is recombined by the 50/50 waveplate superposing with slave 1 beam.

of the preceding cooling and trapping stages (e.g., the MOT).

Once a dense cloud is obtained, the PA process is initiated in a magnetic field of  $B = 1.6$  mT optimized for  $\pi$  optical transitions, by illuminating the atoms with a dedicated laser beam that is presented in details in the following.

### 3.2.2 Photoassociation lasers and their spectral characteristics

#### 3.2.2.1 ECDL locking and frequency referencing

The PA beam is generated by a phase lock system of the MOGLabs ECDL (see 1.3.1) onto the Radiant Dyes ECDL with a Thorlabs red diode **HL6750MG**: this latter is referenced to an ultrastable cavity. The beating procedure aims to lock this laser: as detailed in figure 3.9 the MOGLabs and "11/2 AOM" beams interfere on the same optical path intercepted by the "beating photodiode". The measured signal is then converted by the photodiode and mixed with an RF source to generate an error signal that is fed back to the MOGLabs laser current and piezo to stabilize the frequency.

The optical path of the figure 3.8 shows a design of the "11/2" beam that is shared in a first arm for the optical pumping of the atoms and in a second one for the beating procedure. In the same place the beams from repumper, MOGLabs and slave 1 are sent nearby to a wavemeter that is measuring one by one thanks to mechanical shutters.

The final frequency of the PA beam depends on multiple RF and optical frequencies:

- $f_{Red\ master}$  is the optical frequency of the head master ECDL laser

- $f_{beating}^{RF}$  the frequency used for demodulating the beating between 11/2 beam and MOGlabs. This RF source gives the error signal necessary for the wavelength setting and stabilization of the MOGlabs laser.
- $f_{Raman}^{RF}$  the frequency of the "Raman AOM" used to shift the frequency beam of the PA beam in very last position of the scheme, also used for the Raman transitions used in the Ramsey interferometry schemes of Chapter 2
- $f_{slave1}^{RF}$  is the frequency of the "Slave 1" AOM that is ahead of the lines for the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  MOT and the "11/2 AOM" responsible for the optical pumping and the beating. The shift of the diffracted order enables to go from the isotope 88 to the 87 (see 3.3.1)
- $f_{11/2}^{RF}$  is the frequency of the "11/2 AOM" used for optical pumping and beating.

The frequency of the beam sent to the atoms is then given by the following formula:

$$f_{PA} = f_{MOGlabs} + f_{beating}^{RF} - f_{Raman}^{RF} \pm 2 \times f_{slave1}^{RF} - 2 \times f_{11/2}^{RF} \quad (3.64)$$

The locking upper limit of the MOGlabs laser does not allow to reach frequencies above  $f_{beating}^{RF} = 500$  MHz. A possibility to address deeper bound vibrational states is to modify the different accessible frequencies -considering their RF frequency limits- and/or invert the diffracted order of the "Raman AOM" that allows to shift the PA beam to about  $\pm 260$  MHz.

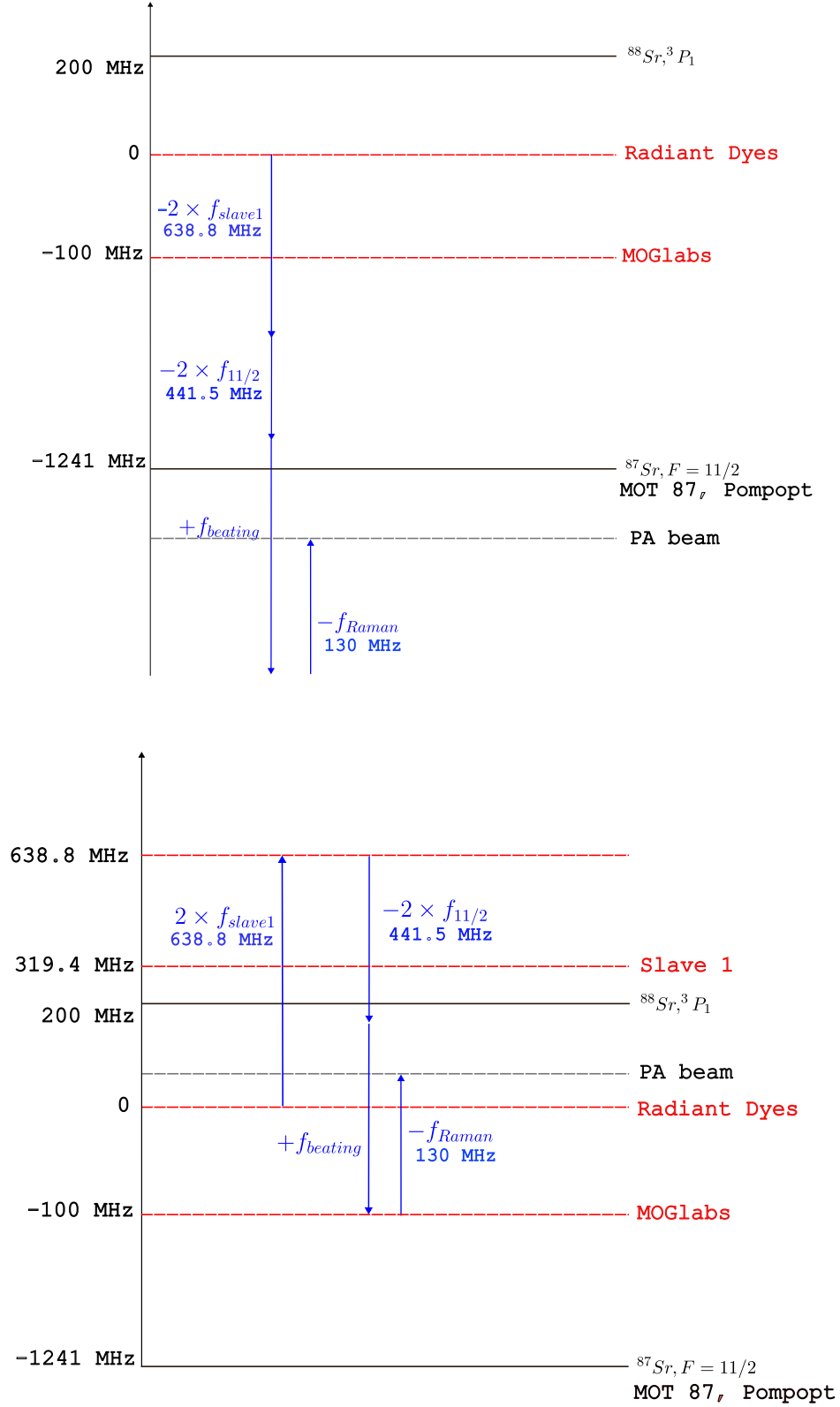


Figure 3.9: Frequency schemes for photoassociation (PA) depending on the targeted isotope: (top) scheme for  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  and (bottom) scheme for  $^{88}\text{Sr}$ . Switching the diffracted order of 'AOM Slave 1' allows for a seamless transition between isotopes, requiring only a minor realignment of the beam injection downstream of the AOM.

### 3.2.2.2 Spectral imperfections from the locking scheme

The beating spectrum of the PA laser locking is presented in Fig. 3.10 at a resolution bandwidth  $\text{RBW} = 10 \text{ kHz}$ , with a video bandwidth  $\text{VBW} = 300 \text{ Hz}$ . Expecting the molecular lifetime of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  to be  $\Gamma_{\text{mol}} \simeq 15 \text{ kHz}$ , this signal simulates the spectrum seen by the molecules. Fitting the beat note with three Lorentzians – a central peak and two symmetric sidebands – yields a central peak of  $\text{FWHM} \simeq 13 \text{ kHz}$ , close to the RBW of the measurement, and sidebands at  $\pm 70 \text{ kHz}$  with a considerably larger FWHM of  $\simeq 80 \text{ kHz}$ . Because the sidebands are so much broader than the central peak, they carry the majority of the total power: integrating the fitted lineshapes, only  $\simeq 31\%$  of the optical power addresses the molecules at the beating center frequency, while  $\simeq 69\%$  is spread across the sidebands. This observation limits the power at which one can photoassociate the atoms efficiently on resonance. Since the central peak’s measured width is comparable to the RBW itself, this measurement cannot resolve the true intrinsic linewidth of the laser – only an upper bound. Regardless, the presence of these broad sidebands means that the effective linewidth of the transition addressed by the PA beam, whether atomic or molecular depending on the laser frequency, is broadened well beyond  $\Gamma_{\text{mol}}$  by this spectral structure.

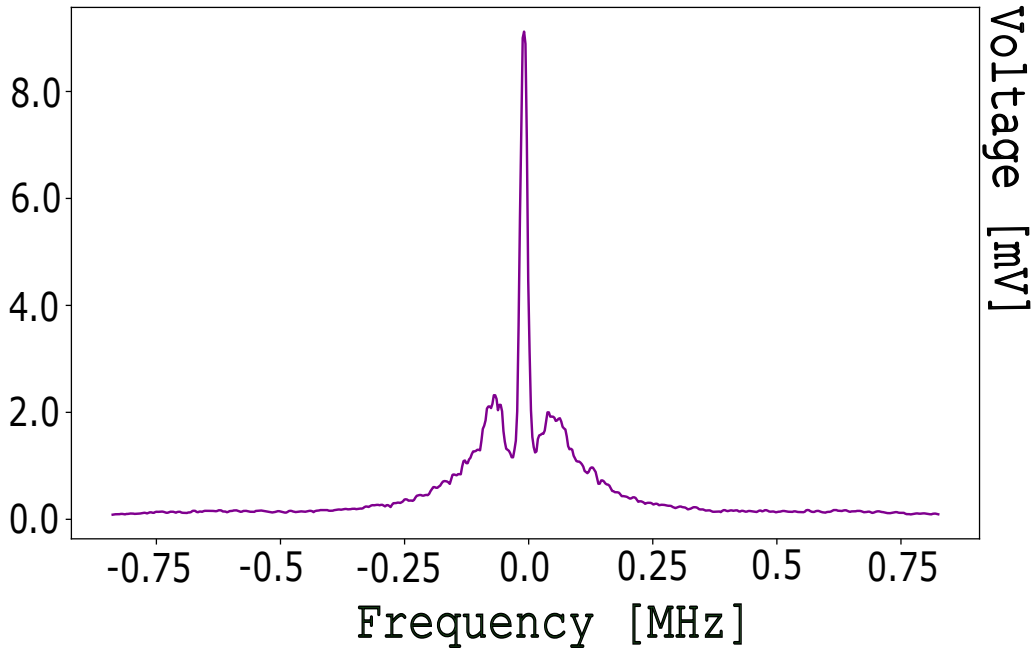


Figure 3.10: Beating spectrum between the MOGlabs laser and the "AOM 11/2" measured at the spectrum analyzer at  $\text{RBW} = 10 \text{ kHz}$  and  $\text{VBW} = 300 \text{ Hz}$ , with a three-Lorentzian fit (central peak + two sidebands at  $\pm 70 \text{ kHz}$ ). The sidebands, of larger FWHM than the central peak, carry the majority ( $\simeq 69\%$ ) of the total optical power.

### 3.2.2.3 Spectral imperfections from the filter cavity system

The MOGlabs laser passes through a Fabry-Perot cavity (see section 1.3.3) stabilized by a Pound-Drever-Hall (PDH) locking system. This involves an EOM that modulates the incident electric field of frequency  $f_0$  fixed at  $f_M = 40.48 \text{ MHz}$  (see [32]). The phase modulation gives rise to interferences between the carrier at central

frequency  $f_0$  and the modulating signal at  $f_M$ :

$$E_{inc}^{mod} = E_0 (J_0(\beta)e^{if_0t} + J_1(\beta)e^{i(f_0+f_M)t} - J_1(\beta)e^{i(f_0-f_M)t}) \quad (3.65)$$

The first term at amplitude  $J_0(\beta)$  - the  $0^{th}$  order Bessel function - is the incident electric field at frequency  $f_0$  with effective amplitude  $E_0 J_0(\beta)$ . The second and third terms come from the interference of the carrier with the RF signal giving rise to two sidebands at  $f_0 \pm f_M$  with amplitude  $J_1(\beta)$  the first order Bessel function. Figure 3.11 shows the ratio between the carrier and sidebands depending on the settled  $\beta$ . Experimentally the modulation depth  $\beta = 1$  gives around three times more intensity in the carrier relative to each sideband ( $J_0^2(\beta)/J_1^2(\beta) \simeq 3.0$ ), which is convenient to these constraints and directly tunable by the amplitude of the RF signal.

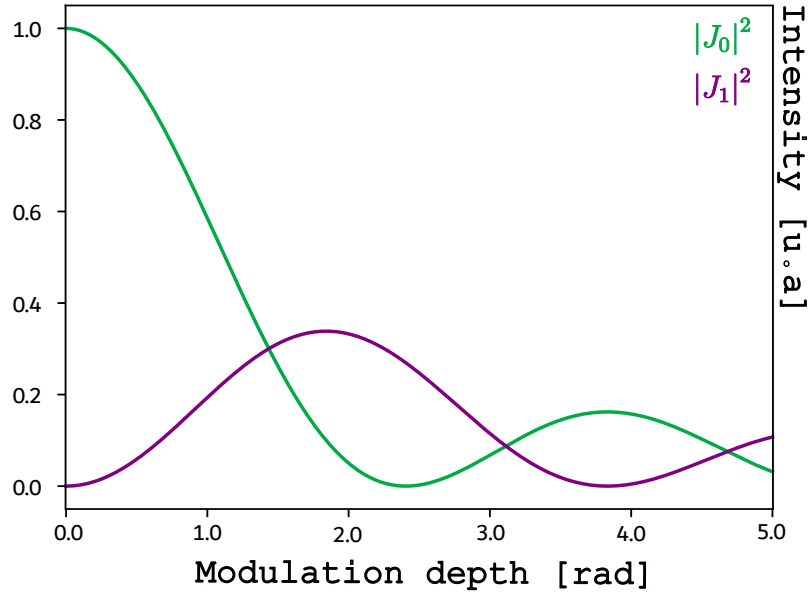


Figure 3.11: Modulus square of the  $0^{th}$  and  $1^{st}$  Bessel functions  $J_n$  governing the power distribution between the carrier and PDH sidebands.

The sidebands are indispensable to the PDH scheme itself: it is their reflection off the cavity, interfering with the reflected carrier, that generates the dispersive error signal used for locking (see section 1.3.3). Being detuned by  $f_M$  from the carrier resonance, they are in principle mostly rejected by the cavity rather than transmitted to the atoms. However, this rejection is not perfect, since the cavity linewidth is finite: the sidebands still experience a small residual transmission set by the cavity's Lorentzian lineshape,

$$\frac{T(f_M)}{T(0)} = \frac{1}{1 + \left(\frac{2f_M}{\delta\nu}\right)^2}. \quad (3.66)$$

Using the cavity's measured finesse ( $\mathcal{F} = 310 \pm 15$ ) and FSR (3 GHz), i.e. a linewidth  $\delta\nu = \text{FSR}/\mathcal{F} \simeq 10$  MHz, and the PDH modulation frequency  $f_M = 40.48$  MHz, this residual transmission amounts to  $T(f_M)/T(0) \simeq 1.4\%$ . Combined with the sideband-to-carrier power ratio set by the modulation depth ( $J_1^2(\beta)/J_0^2(\beta) \simeq 0.33$

at  $\beta = 1$ ), the power reaching the atoms in each sideband is expected to be  $\simeq 0.5\%$  of the power reaching them in the carrier. Although small, this residual power is enough to drive a detectable one-body loss signal, displaced from the main photoassociation resonance by  $\pm f_M$ , as we now demonstrate experimentally.

We measured the effect of these sidebands on 500 000 atoms gas evaporated and recompressed to a temperature  $T = 4.1\mu K$ . It is tested on the two spin components  $m_f = -9/2, +9/2$  optically pumped during 2 sec at optical power  $I = 385\text{mW}/\text{cm}^2$  with the ECDL laser. Plot 3.13 shows the number of atoms addressed by the positive sideband: as schematized in 3.12 the presence of the sidebands triggers "ghost" resonances when the carrier is detuned by  $f'_0 = f_0 \pm f_M = f_0 \pm 40.48\text{ MHz}$  from the atomic transition, leading to spurious one-body losses. The interfering components are also displaced by the same frequency. Then the sideband at  $f'_0 - f_M$  visible in the purple signal is addressing the atomic transition at  $f_0$  with a reduced amplitude comparing to the dark signal previously centered in  $f_0$ .

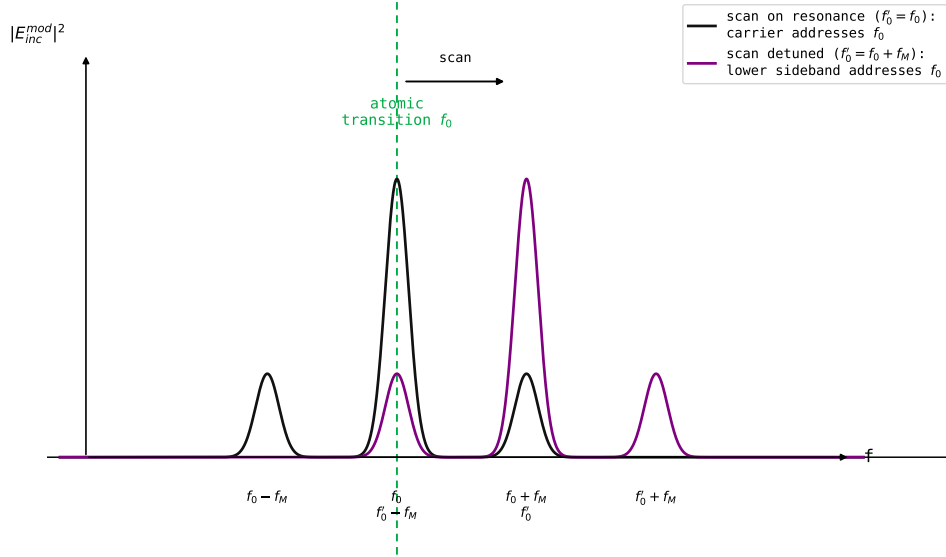


Figure 3.12: Scheme of the PDH sidebands addressing the atomic resonance, shown at two snapshots of the laser frequency scan. The atomic transition sits at the fixed frequency  $f_0$  (green dashed line). In black: the carrier is scanned onto resonance ( $f'_0 = f_0$ ), producing the true photoassociation signal. In purple: the carrier is instead detuned to  $f'_0 = f_0 + f_M$ , so that it is itself off-resonance, but its lower sideband coincides with  $f_0$  and drives a spurious ("ghost") loss resonance. As the scan sweeps  $f'_0$ , this coincidence recurs whenever  $f'_0 = f_0 \pm f_M$ , producing satellite peaks such as the one reported in Fig. 3.13.

Figure 3.13 shows the resulting ghost resonance measured on a gas of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ ,  $F = 9/2$ , of density  $n = 13 \times 10^{12}\text{ atoms}/\text{cm}^3$ , addressed here by the resonant lower sideband, as schematized in Fig. 3.12. The carrier and the upper sideband are not visible in this scan range, as they remain far detuned from resonance over these frequencies. The green dashed line marks the expected position of the ghost resonance,  $|\Delta| = f_M$ , which coincides with the observed loss feature.

This resonance is not a single, clean feature but shows several overlapping peaks, which we attribute to two possible causes. First, the PA laser polarization may not

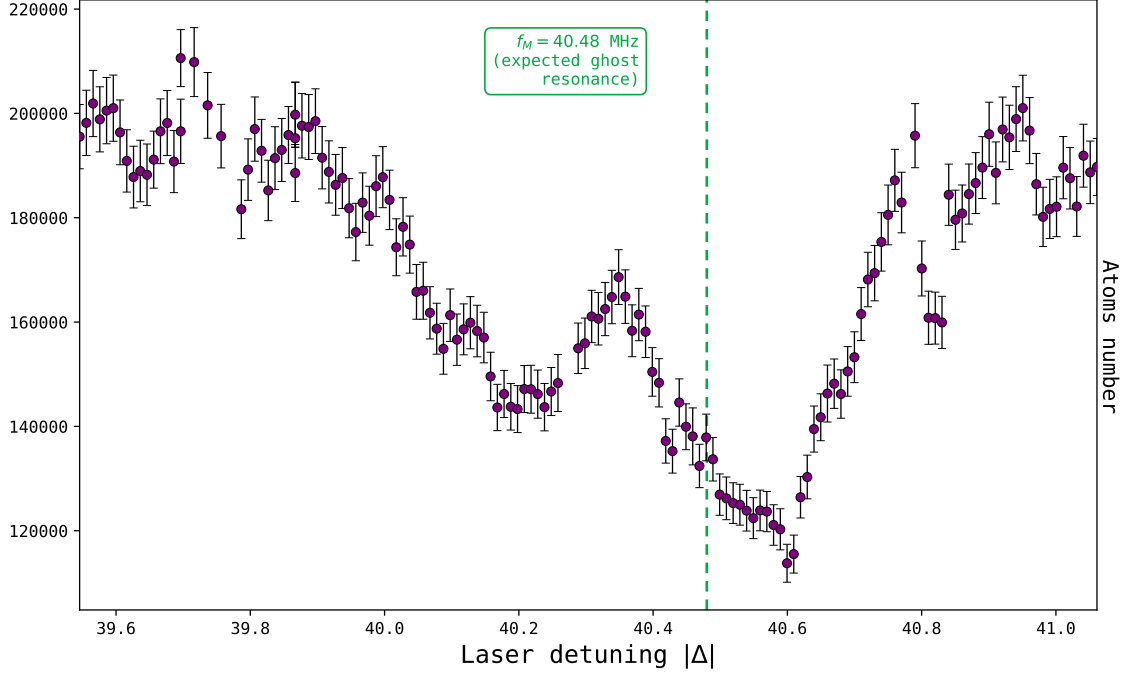


Figure 3.13: Atomic loss due to the FP cavity’s PDH sideband addressing the  $^1S_0 \rightarrow ^3P_1$  line at  $\Delta = f_0 - f_M$ , with  $f_M$  the modulation frequency of the PDH EOM. The dashed line marks the expected detuning of the ghost resonance,  $|\Delta| = f_M = 40.48$  MHz.

be perfectly  $\sigma$ : a small admixture of the orthogonal polarization would drive transitions to neighbouring  $m_F$  states, each addressed at a slightly different frequency and all overlapping within the scan range. Second, several lines displaced by the Zeeman shift and by the tensor light shift (TLS) may be contributing simultaneously; this scenario is supported by repeating the same measurement at different magnetic fields, which showed the splitting between peaks evolving with  $B$ . These two explanations are not mutually exclusive, and disentangling their relative contributions would require further measurements dedicated to this question.

Lowering the modulation depth  $\beta$  reduced the absolute amplitude of this curve, but did not allow us to fully cancel the effect: a molecular line of small amplitude could still be hidden within this signal. One could use the other laser from ‘AOM 11/2’ to explore this frequency range.

## Conclusion on the characterization of the PA spectroscopic protocol

The purpose of this section was to establish and validate the operational procedure to tune the PA laser frequency. Characterization of the laser system highlighted two critical experimental insights:

- **Power calibration and spectral distribution:** Analyzing the beat-note signal revealed that more than half of the total laser power is distributed into unwanted frequency components. This spectral dilution directly contributes to the observed broadening of both atomic and molecular spectroscopic lines.

- **Modulation-induced parasitic resonances:** Laser modulation can generate sidebands that induce unexpected atomic or molecular transitions. Specifically, sidebands at  $f_M = \pm 40.48$  MHz from the main line can lead to a misinterpretation of atom loss signals. In our setup, this modulation originates from the electro-optic modulator (EOM) used for the Pound-Drever-Hall (PDH) lock, although similar effects can arise in the presence of an optical device that can be modulated by an close RF source frequency such as acousto-optic modulators (AOMs).

### 3.2.3 Atomic and molecular lines calibration

#### 3.2.3.1 General experimental framework and baseline parameters

Before scanning for molecular resonances, the atomic transition itself is calibrated by recording the atom loss induced by the PA beam as a function of its detuning around the expected atomic frequency. This loss follows a two-body decay: isolating the two-body term of Eq. 3.44,

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{dn(t)}{dt} &= -K_2 n(t)^2 \\
\int_{n_0}^{n(t)} \frac{dn}{n^2} &= -K_2 \int_0^t dt \\
\left[ -\frac{1}{n} \right]_{n_0}^{n(t)} &= -K_2 t \\
\frac{1}{n(t)} - \frac{1}{n_0} &= K_2 t \\
t &= \frac{1}{K_2} \frac{n_0 - n(t)}{n(t)n_0}
\end{aligned}$$

so that the characteristic loss time at half the initial density is

$$\tau = \frac{1}{K_2 n_0}. \quad (3.67)$$

The PA experiments on  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  presented in this section begin with an initial density of  $n_0 = 5 \times 10^{13}$  atoms/cm<sup>3</sup> and a temperature of  $T \simeq 1.7$   $\mu\text{K}$ . The atomic transition is addressed at  $f_{\text{beating}}^{\text{RF}} = f_{\text{Raman}}$  using a laser beam with an intensity of  $I = 100 I_{\text{sat}}$  and a waist of  $w_0 = 340$   $\mu\text{m}$ . For the typical two-body loss rate coefficients expected on this transition ( $10^{-12} < K_2 < 10^{-8}$  cm<sup>3</sup> · s<sup>-1</sup>), these parameters predict a characteristic loss time  $\tau$  of a few milliseconds or less.

Contrary to this prediction, the observed loss was much weaker than expected for the predicted  $\tau$ : the measured  $l_{\text{opt}}$  values were far from those reported in the literature (see [15], [116]), despite using an intensity comparable to, or higher than, typical values used in similar experiments – a discrepancy that would not be expected if it were simply due to insufficient laser power. Investigating this discrepancy revealed a spatial misalignment between the PA beam and the atomic cloud for this particular dataset: the shape of the out beam from the vacuum cell was different than the input one, we interpret as only a fraction of the atoms actually contributed to

the measured two-body loss, diluting the apparent loss rate. This misalignment is specific to the  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  measurements shown in this section and does not affect the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  data presented elsewhere in this thesis. To recover a measurable loss signal despite this reduced effective overlap, all  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  data shown here were acquired with a correspondingly extended illumination time of approximately 800 ms. This comes at a cost: at resonance, the resulting  $N = \Gamma_{at}/2 \times t \simeq 10^4$  scattered photons per atom induce severe heating of the atomic cloud, causing significant thermal broadening of the molecular resonances discussed below.

Once the MOGlabs laser is robustly locked to this reference,  $f_{\text{beating}}^{RF}$  is scanned to search for the three lowest vibrational states, shown in Fig. 3.14.

### 3.2.3.2 Fitting model for molecular resonances

Each data point of the presented atomic and molecular lines is extracted by fitting the absorption images of the atomic cloud with a 2D Gaussian function. The atom number  $N$  is obtained from the integral of the fit,  $N \propto A \sigma_x \sigma_y$ . The relative statistical uncertainty on  $N$  was estimated from the diagonal elements of the fit covariance matrix,

$$\frac{\delta N}{N} \simeq \sqrt{\left(\frac{\delta A}{A}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{\delta \sigma_x}{\sigma_x}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{\delta \sigma_y}{\sigma_y}\right)^2}, \quad (3.68)$$

where  $\delta A$ ,  $\delta \sigma_x$ , and  $\delta \sigma_y$  are the standard errors on the amplitude and on the spatial widths along  $x$  and  $y$ . This expression neglects the off-diagonal covariance terms between the fit parameters (e.g.  $\text{Cov}(A, \sigma_x)$ ), which were not retained from the original fitting routine. As amplitude and width are generally correlated in a 2D Gaussian fit, this estimate should be considered a lower bound on the true statistical uncertainty rather than an exact value.

To account for shot-to-shot experimental fluctuations, the RMS atom number variation over ten consecutive realizations was also included. The total uncertainty associated with each atom number measurement is given by:

$$\sigma_N^{\text{tot}} = N \sqrt{\sigma_{\text{gaussian}}^2 + \sigma_{\text{systematic}}^2} \quad (3.69)$$

We now aggregate the results from different realizations into a spectrum, and fit the latter. Each atomic and molecular resonance is fitted with a Lorentzian lineshape,

$$f(x) = y_0 + \frac{A}{(x - x_0)^2 + \left(\frac{\Gamma}{2}\right)^2} \quad (3.70)$$

characterized by a width  $\Gamma$  at  $1/\sqrt{e}$  of the amplitude, centered at  $x_0$ , with a peak amplitude  $A/(\Gamma/2)^2$  and an offset  $y_0$ .

The resonances exhibit an effective linewidth  $\Gamma_{\text{tot}}$  resulting from physical and technical broadening mechanisms:

$$\Gamma_{\text{tot}} = \sqrt{\Gamma_0^2 + \Gamma_{\text{thermal}}^2 + \Gamma_{\text{laser}}^2 + \Gamma_{\text{remainder}}^2} \quad (3.71)$$

The first contribution,  $\Gamma_0$ , is associated with the radiative lifetime of the excited state. For a photoassociated molecule – formed through a one-photon process –

this natural radiative linewidth is, in principle, twice that of an excited atom ( $\Gamma_0 = 2\pi \times 7.5$  kHz for the  $^1S_0 - ^3P_1$  atomic line of  $^{88}\text{Sr}$ , and  $\Gamma_0 \approx 15$  kHz on average for the molecular states). Due to small Franck-Condon factors, the effective saturation intensity  $I_{\text{sat}}^{\text{eff}}$  for molecular transitions is significantly larger than for atomic ones, making power broadening completely negligible for molecular lines [4].

For molecular resonances specifically, the photoassociation rate depends on the relative velocity of the colliding atom pair, so that the thermal spread of this relative motion introduces an additional, molecule-specific broadening – distinct from ordinary single-atom Doppler broadening – given by:

$$\Gamma_{\text{thermal}} = \frac{1}{\lambda} \sqrt{\frac{k_B T}{\mu}} \quad (3.72)$$

with  $\mu = m_{\text{at}}/2$  the reduced mass of the colliding pair,  $\lambda$  the laser wavelength,  $T$  the gas temperature, and  $k_B$  the Boltzmann constant.

Finally,  $\Gamma_{\text{laser}}$  accounts for the intrinsic spectral width of the laser source, while  $\Gamma_{\text{remainder}}$  gathers any additional technical broadening. By subtracting the known physical contributions ( $\Gamma_0, \Gamma_{\text{thermal}}$ ) in quadrature from the measured total linewidth  $\Gamma_{\text{tot}}$ , one can isolate the combined technical contribution:

$$\Gamma_{\text{laser+rem}} = \sqrt{\Gamma_{\text{tot}}^2 - (\Gamma_0^2 + \Gamma_{\text{thermal}}^2)} \quad (3.73)$$

Other phenomena can affect the measured linewidth beyond these three ingredients (radiative lifetime, thermal broadening, power broadening), and it is common for photoassociation lines to appear broader than expected from these alone.

### 3.2.4 Experimental results on $^{88}\text{Sr}$

We now present photoassociation data on the isotope  $^{88}\text{Sr}$ . We identified two vibrational lines and compared our experimental findings (line center, linewidth) to the literature, before discussing their broadening in more detail. The measured and literature values are summarized in Table 3.1.

|                                              | $\nu = -1$             | $\nu = -2$             |
|----------------------------------------------|------------------------|------------------------|
| Exposure time $t$                            | 1000 ms                | 50 ms                  |
| Intensity $I$                                | 826 mW/cm <sup>2</sup> | 303 mW/cm <sup>2</sup> |
| Measured detuning $f$                        | −23.99(1) MHz          | −222.70(1) MHz         |
| Literature $f$ [4]                           | −23.932(33) MHz        | −222.161(35) MHz       |
| $\Gamma_{\text{tot}}$ (measured)             | $192 \pm 9$ kHz        | $330 \pm 13$ kHz       |
| $\Gamma_0$ (first principles)                | 15 kHz                 | 15 kHz                 |
| $\Gamma_{\text{thermal}}$ (first principles) | 19 kHz                 | 21 kHz                 |
| $\Gamma_{\text{laser+rem}}$ (residual)       | $190.47 \pm 9$ kHz     | $328.99 \pm 13$ kHz    |

Table 3.1: Summary of the two vibrational states identified for  $^{88}\text{Sr}$ , comparing measured line centers and linewidths to the literature values from Zelevinsky et al. [4].  $\Gamma_0$  and  $\Gamma_{\text{thermal}}$  are estimated from first principles (not extracted from the data);  $\Gamma_{\text{laser+rem}}$  is obtained by subtracting these two contributions in quadrature from  $\Gamma_{\text{tot}}$ .

Both states were detected using the MOGlabs laser system. The natural width  $\Gamma_0$  and the thermal broadening  $\Gamma_{\text{thermal}}$  are both estimated from first principles rather than extracted from the data – the expected linewidth should in principle also include a power broadening contribution, which we take to be negligible here given the small Franck-Condon factors discussed above. The residual  $\Gamma_{\text{laser+rem}}$ , obtained by subtracting  $\Gamma_0$  and  $\Gamma_{\text{thermal}}$  in quadrature from  $\Gamma_{\text{tot}}$ , therefore captures both technical laser broadening and any deviation of these first-principles estimates from their true values.

Our measured line centers agree well with the results reported by Zelevinsky et al. [4], who identified vibrational states associated with the  $0_u$  photoassociation potential. The tensorial light shift induced by the photoassociation (PA) beam causes a frequency shift in these molecular states, as investigated by Blatt et al. [13], where the  $\nu = -2$  state exhibited a red-shift of 200 kHz for a laser intensity increase of approximately 800 mW/cm<sup>2</sup>.

The measured linewidths ( $\Gamma_{\text{tot}} \sim 192\text{--}330$  kHz) remain significantly larger than the expected intrinsic molecular linewidth of  $\Gamma_0 \approx 15$  kHz. This substantial broadening is consistent with the spectral impurities of the MOGlabs laser: convolving the measured beat-note spectrum – a narrow central peak (FWHM  $\simeq 13$  kHz) flanked by sidebands at  $\pm 70$  kHz with FWHM  $\simeq 80$  kHz – with the expected clean molecular lineshape ( $\Gamma_0 \oplus \Gamma_{\text{thermal}} \simeq 26$  kHz) yields an apparent linewidth of  $\simeq 135$  kHz. This accounts for a substantial fraction of the observed broadening, though not all of it, indicating that additional technical noise sources – not fully captured by this single beat-note measurement – are likely also contributing. To confirm the technical origin of this broadening, we measured the same molecular line with an alternative, higher-stability laser source.

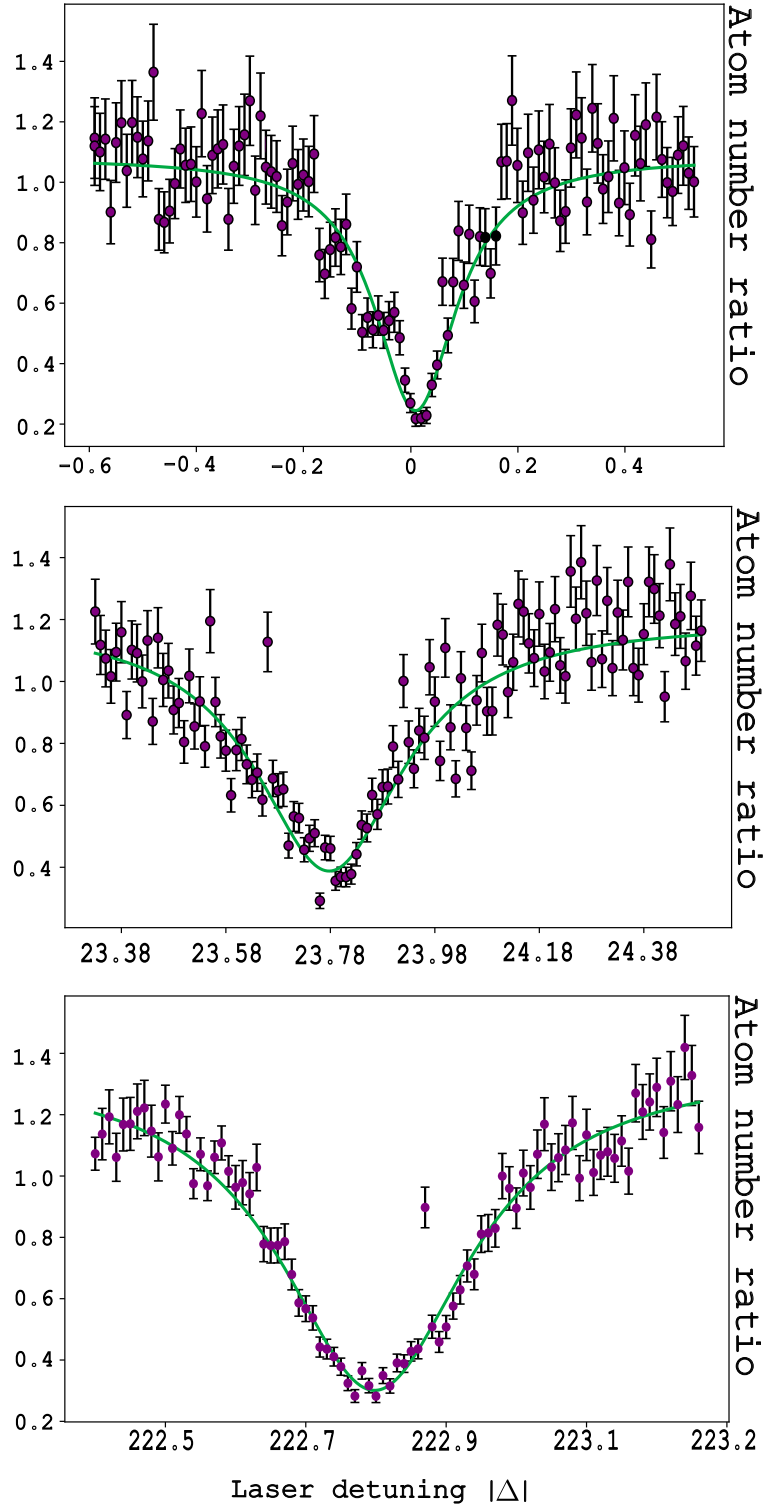


Figure 3.14: Normalized  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  atom number across the intercombination line. (Top) Atomic resonance used as the PA frequency reference. Data points are extracted from 2D Gaussian fits of absorption images; error bars include fit covariance and unperturbed cloud RMS fluctuations. (Middle)  $\nu = -1$  vibrational state ( $I = 826 \text{ mW/cm}^2$ , 1000 ms). (Bottom)  $\nu = -2$  vibrational state ( $I = 303 \text{ mW/cm}^2$ , 50 ms). Solid lines are Lorentzian fits with errors accounting for diagonal terms of covariance matrix and systematic fluctuations.

### 3.2.4.1 PA experiments with an alternative laser source

Spectroscopy measurements confirmed the significant broadening induced by the MOGLabs ECDL laser. To demonstrate its technical origin, we compared the MOGLabs results with a more stable laser source: a diode laser injection-locked onto the Radiant Dyes master ECDL. The measured parameters for the  $\nu = -2$  molecular state are summarized in Table 3.2 and illustrated in Figure 3.15.

Table 3.2: Experimental comparison of the photoassociation line to the bound state  $\nu = -2$  measured with two different laser sources.

| Parameters                                                                  | Injection locked laser | MOGLabs ECDL       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|--------------------|
| Detuning $f$ [MHz]                                                          | $-222.70 \pm 0.01$     | $-222.70 \pm 0.01$ |
| Intensity $I$ [mW/cm <sup>2</sup> ]                                         | 795                    | 231                |
| Natural width $\Gamma_0$ [kHz]                                              | 15                     | 15                 |
| $\Gamma_{\text{thermal}}$ (calc.) [kHz]                                     | 21                     | 21                 |
| <b>Total measured width <math>\Gamma_{\text{tot}}</math> [kHz]</b>          | $115.5 \pm 8.8$        | $344.5 \pm 27.3$   |
| <b>Deduced technical width <math>\Gamma_{\text{laser+rem}}</math> [kHz]</b> | 112.58                 | 328.99             |

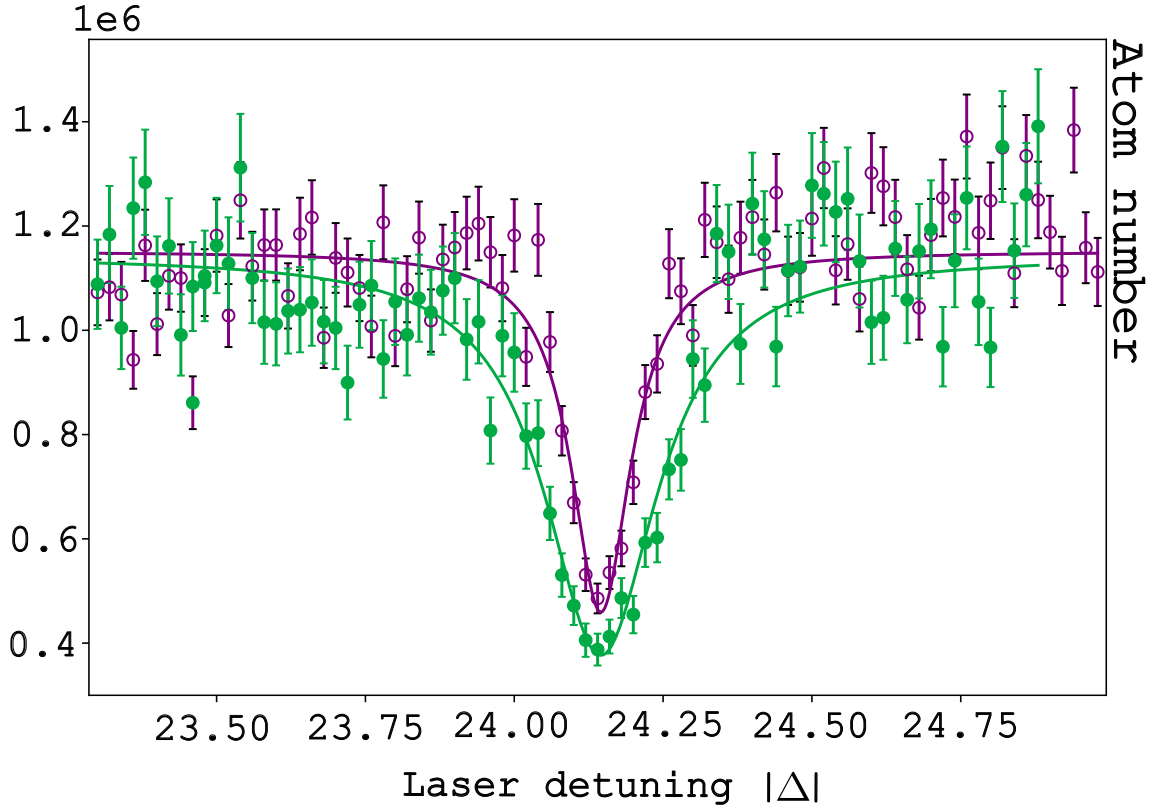


Figure 3.15: Comparison of the  $\nu = -2$  molecular line profile with two different sources. The MOGLabs dataset (deep purple) yields a line three times broader than the stable injection locked laser source (light purple).

The MOGLabs source yields a technical linewidth  $\Gamma_{\text{laser+rem}}$  approximately three times larger than the injection-locked laser beam. Nevertheless, the MOGLabs laser remains essential for broad spectroscopic searches due to its wide frequency tunability.

### 3.2.4.2 Noise of the diode

We compared the molecular line broadening using two different lasers. With the injection-locked source, extra noise peaks appeared. These peaks sit at  $\pm 6$  MHz and  $\pm 12$  MHz from  $f_0$ . Their symmetric position, both red and blue, points to sidebands. These sidebands originate from noise on the diode.

At  $\delta = +6$  MHz, we resolved the response of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ ,  $^3P_1, F = 11/2$  excited state that shows in Fig. 3.16 a lot of fluctuations coming from the heating of the SU(10) gas **ajouter mean temperature of the gas**. The same scan, taken blue-detuned, gave the twelve  $m_F$  sublevels of  $-11/2 \leq m_F \leq 11/2$  structure (Fig. 3.17) at -6 MHz and -12 MHz. This confirms the peaks are atomic, not molecular. Each feature – carrier, red sideband, blue sideband – is not a single line. Instead, each spans a comparatively wide range of detunings. This width results from heating broadening many single-atom transitions, one for each  $m_F$  sublevel, rather than from the laser noise itself. The whole pattern is simply displaced in frequency, appearing at  $\pm 6$  MHz and  $\pm 12$  MHz as a consequence of a sideband in the laser spectrum. As a result, searching for molecular lines near  $\pm 6$  MHz and  $\pm 12$  MHz with the  $F = 11/2$  beam is compromised: a weak molecular signal there would be hidden within this atomic structure.

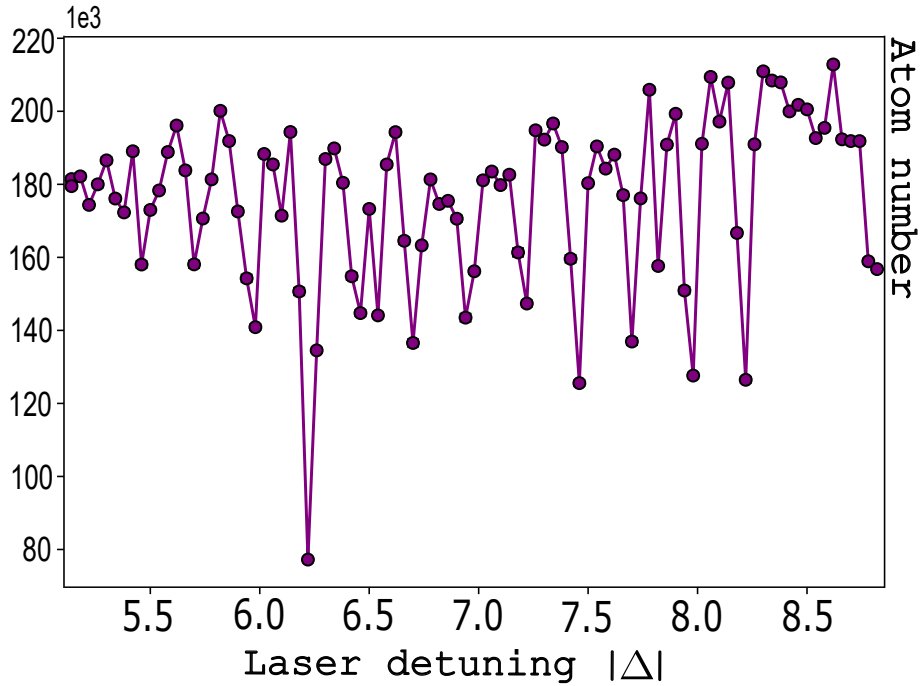


Figure 3.16: Atom number measurement on  $^3P_1, F = 11/2$  hyperfine excited state, measured in an SU(10) gas at  $\delta = +6$  MHz from the atomic resonance. This heating-broadened pattern of single-atom lines is obtained by a sideband in the diode laser spectrum that is addressing the atomic resonance.

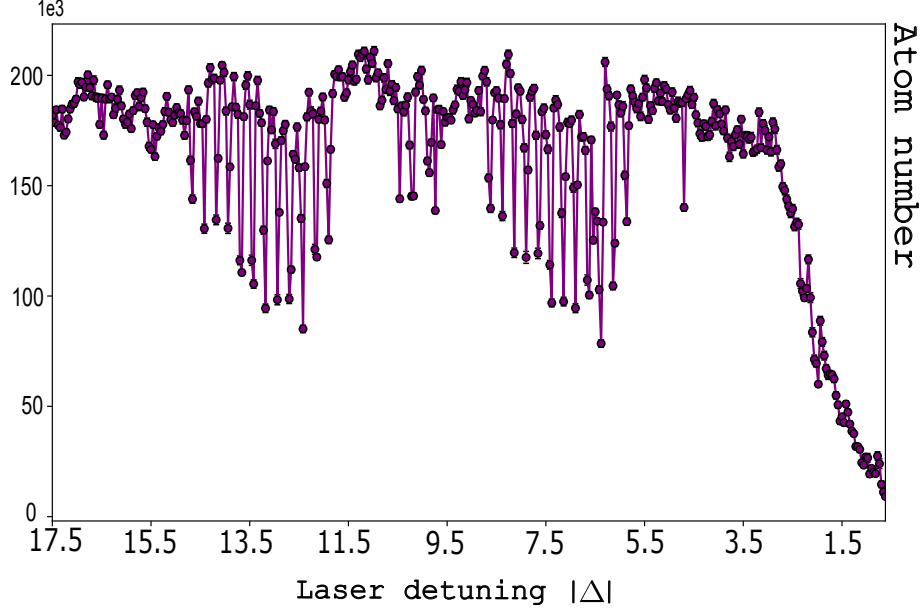


Figure 3.17: Twelve  $m_F$  states of the  $^3P_1, F = 11/2$  hyperfine excited state, measured in an SU(10) gas at  $\delta = -6$  MHz and  $\delta = -12$  MHz from the atomic resonance. This heating-broadened pattern of single-atom lines is displaced in frequency by a sideband in the diode laser spectrum.

The two previous subsections characterized the laser used for photoassociation, highlighting how spectral impurities – additional frequency components beyond the intended carrier – can address free atoms directly rather than binding them into molecules, and can therefore lead to a misinterpretation of the observed inelastic collisions. Building on the theoretical framework introduced in the first part of this chapter, I now turn to the experimental method used to determine  $l_{\text{opt}}$ .

### 3.2.4.3 Determining the optical scattering length $l_{\text{opt}}$

There are two primary methods to determine the optical scattering length  $l_{\text{opt}}$ .

**Method 1: Linewidth and peak analysis of the photoassociation loss resonance** Following the formulation from [4], the microscopic two-body loss rate coefficient near a photoassociation resonance is given by:

$$K_2(\Delta) = \frac{4\pi\hbar}{\mu} \frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}^2 l_{\text{opt}}}{\left(\frac{E}{\hbar} + 2\pi\Delta\right)^2 + \frac{(\Gamma_{\text{stim}} + \Gamma_{\text{mol}})^2}{4}} \quad (3.74)$$

where  $\mu = m_{\text{at}}/2$  is the reduced mass of the atom pair,  $\Gamma_{\text{mol}}$  is the natural molecular linewidth (in rad/s),  $\Gamma_{\text{stim}}$  is the light-induced stimulated width (in rad/s), and  $E$  is the relative collision energy.

Experimentally, we measure the relative atomic loss profile  $f(\Delta) = \frac{n_0 - n(t)}{n_0}$  as a function of the laser detuning  $\Delta$  (in Hz). One demonstrated that considering only the two-body loss term,  $n(t) = \frac{n_0}{1 + K_2(\Delta)t_{\text{pa}}}$  (see 3.67). Then a pulse duration  $t_{\text{pa}}$  and an average atomic density  $\langle n \rangle$ , in the limit of small loss fraction ( $K_2\langle n \rangle t_{\text{pa}} \ll 1$ ), the relative loss amplitude  $f(\Delta)$  is directly proportional to  $K_2(\Delta)$ :

$$f(\Delta) \approx \langle n \rangle t_{\text{pa}} K_2(\Delta) \quad (3.75)$$

Fitting this measured resonance profile with an empirical Lorentzian function yields:

$$f(\Delta) = \frac{A}{1 + \left( \frac{\Delta + \frac{E}{2\pi\hbar}}{\Gamma_{\text{fit}}/2} \right)^2} \quad (3.76)$$

where  $A$  is the dimensionless amplitude of the loss peak and  $\Gamma_{\text{fit}}$  is the full-width at half-maximum (FWHM, in Hz).

We can map the physical parameters directly to our fit observables:

$$\Gamma_{\text{fit}} = \frac{\Gamma_{\text{stim}} + \Gamma_{\text{mol}}}{2\pi} \quad (3.77)$$

$$A = \langle n \rangle t_{\text{pa}} \times \left( \frac{4\hbar}{\pi\mu} \frac{\Gamma_{\text{mol}}^2 l_{\text{opt}}}{\Gamma_{\text{fit}}^2} \right) \quad (3.78)$$

Remarkably, the product  $A \cdot \Gamma_{\text{fit}}^2$  eliminates the total power-broadened and temperature-dependent linewidth terms. The optical scattering length  $l_{\text{opt}}$  can therefore be extracted directly from the fit parameters, taking explicitly into account the exposure time  $t_{\text{pa}}$  and the density  $\langle n \rangle$ :

$$l_{\text{opt}} = \frac{\pi m_{\text{at}}}{8\hbar \Gamma_{\text{mol}}^2 \langle n \rangle t_{\text{pa}}} \times (A \cdot \Gamma_{\text{fit}}^2) \quad (3.79)$$

**Method 2: Direct extraction from two-body loss rate dynamics** Alternatively,  $l_{\text{opt}}$  can be determined by measuring the temporal decay of the atom number  $N(t)$  at resonance. Solving the two-body decay differential equation  $\frac{dn}{dt} = -K_2 n^2$  yields  $K_2$  at resonance. The optical scattering length is then retrieved from the high-intensity limit relation:

$$K_{2,\text{max}} = \frac{16\hbar}{m_{\text{at}}} l_{\text{opt}} \quad (3.80)$$

This approach depends on the evaluation of the coefficient  $K_2$  that necessitates the fit of the atom decay with time, which I demonstrate in the following.

#### 3.2.4.4 Decay dynamics ( $dN/dt$ )

The common verification of inelastic nature of collisions is the time evolution of the atom number  $dN/dt$  discussed in Section 3.1.3. This curve allows one to (i) verify the presence of two-body losses and (ii) determine the value of  $l_{\text{opt}}/I$  which characterizes the strength of the loss rate  $\beta$ . The fitting function is obtained by

integrating the rate equation:

$$\frac{dN(t, T)}{dt} = -\beta(T(t))N(t, T)^2 - \Gamma N(t, T) \quad (3.81)$$

$$\text{Setting } M(t, T) = N(t, T)e^{\Gamma t} \iff N(t, T) = M(t, T)e^{-\Gamma t} \quad (3.82)$$

$$\dot{M}(t, T)e^{-\Gamma t} - \Gamma M(t, T)e^{-\Gamma t} = -\beta(T(t))M(t, T)^2e^{-2\Gamma t} - \Gamma M(t, T)e^{-\Gamma t} \quad (3.83)$$

$$\int_0^t \frac{\dot{M}(t', T)}{M(t', T)^2} dt' = - \int_0^t \beta(T(t'))e^{-\Gamma t'} dt' \quad (3.84)$$

$$-\frac{1}{M(t, T)} + \frac{1}{N_0} = - \int_0^t \beta(T(t'))e^{-\Gamma t'} dt' \quad (3.85)$$

$$M(t, T) = \frac{N_0}{1 + N_0 \int_0^t \beta(T(t'))e^{-\Gamma t'} dt'} \quad (3.86)$$

$$N(t, T) = \frac{N_0 e^{-\Gamma t}}{1 + N_0 \int_0^t \beta(T(t'))e^{-\Gamma t'} dt'} \quad (3.87)$$

Because  $N(t, T)$  depends on the temperature, one wants to re-express Eq. 3.87 by explicitly showing the  $T$ -dependence of  $\beta(T)$ . The atoms are trapped in an ODT with a mean trapping frequency  $\bar{\omega} = (\omega_x \omega_y \omega_z)^{1/3}$ . According to the equipartition theorem, the spatial width  $\sigma_i$  (with  $i = \{x, y, z\}$ ) of the Gaussian distribution relates to the temperature  $T$  via  $\frac{1}{2}m_{\text{at}}\omega_i^2\sigma_i^2 = \frac{1}{2}k_B T$ . This yields the effective volume:

$$V_e(T) = (2\pi)^{3/2} \left( \frac{k_B T}{m_{\text{at}}} \right)^{3/2} \frac{1}{\omega_x \omega_y \omega_z} = (2\pi)^{3/2} \left( \frac{k_B T}{m_{\text{at}} \bar{\omega}^2} \right)^{3/2} \quad (3.88)$$

with  $\bar{\omega}$  the mean frequency of the trap that depends on the final intensity on the ODT. By substituting  $\beta(T(t')) = \frac{K_2}{2\sqrt{2}V_e(T(t'))}$  into the population evolution law, the final fitting equation becomes:

$$N(t, T) = \frac{N_0 e^{-\Gamma t}}{1 + \left[ \frac{K_2}{8\pi^{3/2}} (m_{\text{at}})^{3/2} \omega_x \omega_y \omega_z \right] N_0 \int_0^t \left( \frac{1}{k_B T(t')} \right)^{3/2} e^{-\Gamma t'} dt'} \quad (3.89)$$

This fitting function is used to extract the two-body loss rate coefficient  $K_2$  from the experimental data. The temperature  $T(t)$  is numerically interpolated from the measured temperature. Then for each illumination time, the integrale of 3.89 is calculated and the experimental data are fitted to extract  $K_2$ .

From equation 3.81, one expects two distinct slopes on the decay curve: an initial fast two-body decay regime followed by a slow one-body regime as the atomic density drops.

Figure 3.18 illustrates these two regimes, from which the  $\beta$  value – and hence  $l_{\text{opt}}$  – is extracted for each resonance.

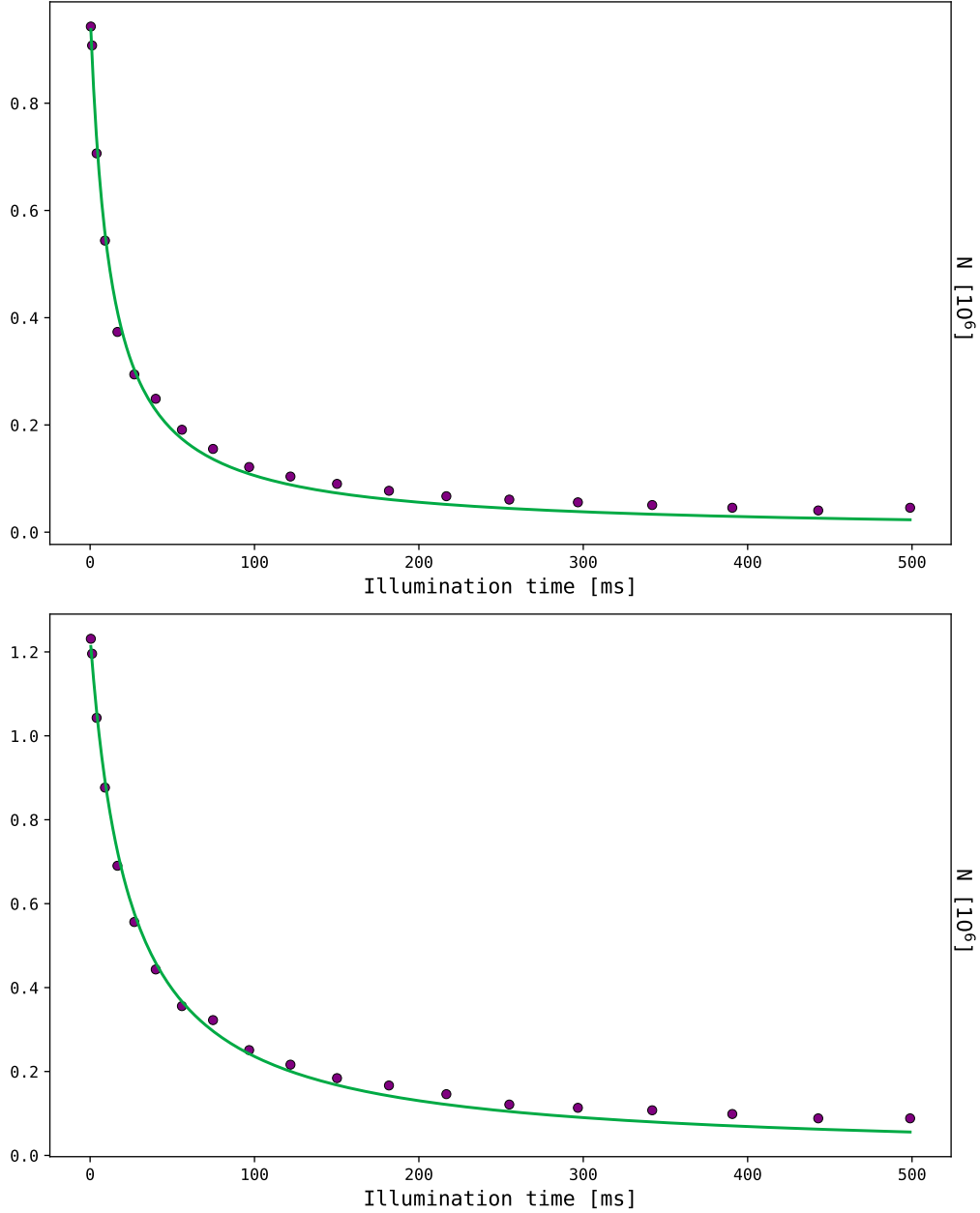


Figure 3.18: Top : atom number decay of  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  of the resonance at  $f = -23.932(33)$  MHz. Bottom: atom decay of resonance at  $f = -222.79(1)$  MHz. Error bars are not shown, as the original raw data could not be recovered.

For the resonance  $f_{\nu=-1} = -23.99$  MHz, the deduced optical length is  $l_{\text{opt}} = 10 a_0$  at a beam power of  $P = 2.8 \mu\text{W}$ , corresponding to an intensity  $I = 2P/(\pi w_0^2) \simeq 1.5 \text{ mW/cm}^2$  for our waist  $w_0 = 340 \mu\text{m}$ , i.e.  $l_{\text{opt}}/I \simeq 6.5 \times 10^3 a_0/(\text{W/cm}^2)$ . This is in good agreement with the theoretical value  $\xi = 6110 a_0/(\text{W/cm}^2)$  reported for the corresponding resonance by Blatt et al. [117] (their  $n = -2$  state).

For the resonance  $f_{\nu=-2} = -222.161(35)$  MHz, we measure  $l_{\text{opt}} = 4 a_0$  at  $I = 300 \text{ mW/cm}^2$ , i.e.  $l_{\text{opt}}/I \simeq 13 a_0/(\text{W/cm}^2)$ . This remains within an order of magnitude of the theoretical value  $\xi = 32.8 a_0/(\text{W/cm}^2)$  reported by Blatt et al. [117] for this line (their  $n = -3$  state), though the agreement is less close than for the first resonance – consistent with Blatt et al.’s own observation that significant ex-

perimental uncertainty can arise from the calibration of the atomic density and of the focused PA laser intensity.

To conclude on this section the results obtained for the  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  isotope are in good agreement with the literature, both in line position and, within an order of magnitude, in optical length. This calibration establishes a reliable baseline to search for  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  molecular lines, provided the following experimental constraints are taken into account:

- **Parasitic RF sidebands:** Measurements performed with the injection-locked laser exhibit noise components at  $\pm 6$  MHz and  $\pm 12$  MHz, which can drive parasitic transitions apart from the main carrier frequency.
- **Laser-induced broadening:** The MOGlabs laser broadens the molecular lines slightly more than the 11/2 beam, though this contribution remains minor.
- **Loss dynamics:** At a variable (or stable) temperature, the time evolution of the atom number is accurately described by Eq. 3.87, derived from the integration of the combined one- and two-body loss equation:  $\frac{dN}{dt} = -\beta N^2 - \Gamma N$ .
- **Blind zones:** The MOGlabs ECDL beam creates a blind zone at 40.38 MHz because of the frequency components of the PDH lock system that excite atoms off resonance

The two-body loss term will be accurately measured provided it sufficiently overcomes the one-body loss term. Having validated our detection, fitting, and calibration procedures on the well-characterized  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  resonances, we now turn to the fermionic isotope  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ , the primary subject of this thesis. Its richer hyperfine structure and  $SU(N)$  symmetry introduce additional spectroscopic complexity – notably the twelve overlapping  $m_F$  resonances identified above – which we address in the following section using the same methodology, while explicitly accounting for the experimental constraints listed here.

### 3.3 $^{87}\text{Sr}$ inelastic collisions

The previous section’s calibration on the well-known  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  isotope allowed us to define the experimental parameters needed for photoassociation – exposure times, laser intensities – before turning to the fermionic species. However, some of the signals subsequently encountered while searching for  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  molecular lines initially misled us into interpreting them as molecular resonances. The various checks performed on these signals, detailed at the beginning of this section, progressively guided us towards a set of measurements to systematically assess the true, non-molecular nature of such resonances.

Molecular line searches on  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  are performed only with the MOGlabs source. To address the fermionic species, the diffraction order of the red optical chain was changed from  $-1$  to  $+1$ , shifting the addressed frequency by 1.441 GHz – the isotopic shift between  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  and the  $F = 11/2$  hyperfine state of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  (see Fig. 3.19).

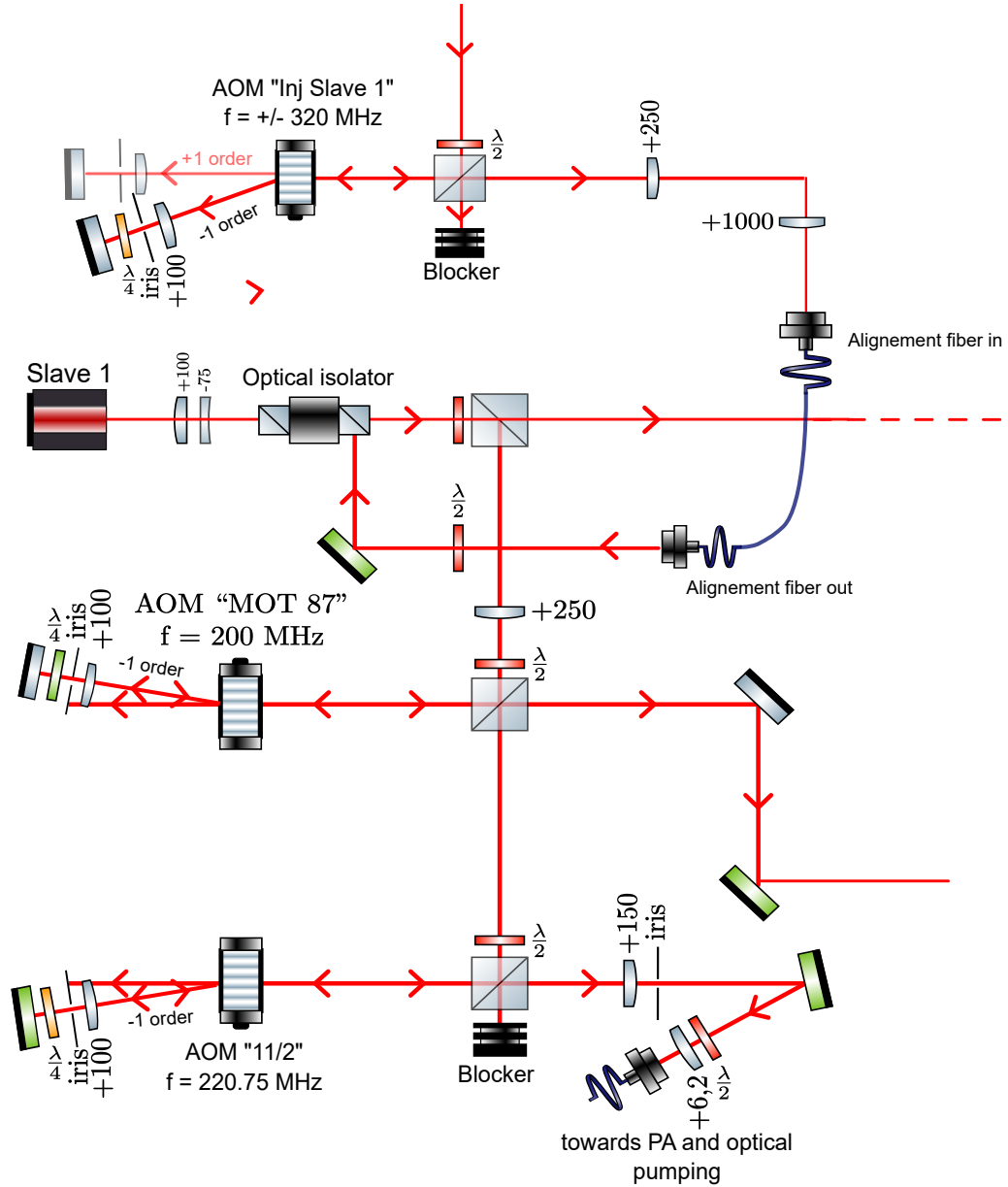


Figure 3.19: Zoom on the section of the red chain dedicated to the PA process. The frequency for both laser configurations is tuned by 'AOM Inj Slave 1', adjusted by 'AOM 11/2' before being sent to the atoms.

All the resonances presented in this section are recorded using a shot-to-shot normalization method, to suppress short-timescale drifts due to experimental fluctuations: the first atom number measured in each cycle is the atomic density in the absence of the PA laser, and the second is the atom number after exposure to it. This is repeated throughout the experiment, and the final signal plotted is the ratio of the perturbed to the unperturbed atom number.

To increase the two-body loss signal, data were collected while varying both the PA beam waist and the atomic cloud density.

For this hyperfine species, hundreds of resonances are expected, as introduced in the theoretical part of this section, each with a linewidth of about 15 kHz. One can estimate from Eq. 3.1.5.2 the energy difference between the dissociation limit and

the first vibrational state to be  $3H_6\epsilon^{2/3} \simeq 266$  MHz. Distributing the 981 accessible molecular configurations over this range, we expect a dense spectrum of molecular lines with a mean separation of only  $\sim 270$  kHz – an order of magnitude narrower than the natural linewidth of a single line, let alone the several-MHz linewidths we actually observe (Sec. 3.3.2). This supports the hypothesis of an unresolved forest of overlapping molecular lines.

The remainder of this section first analyzes the experimental signals that initially misled us, and the verification protocol they led us to establish. The reader will then find the molecular lines obtained for  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ , together with their associated temperature and atom number evolution. The unexpected shape of these lines opens a discussion of their possible technical and physical origins. The section ends with an outlook on the future tests needed to confirm the current hypotheses.

### 3.3.1 Establishment of the molecular lines research protocol from experimental mistakes

This part presents the investigations carried out on the signal 3.17 obtained from red diode noise at -6 MHz, from the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  atomic resonance, a case initially misinterpreted as a molecular resonance. The atoms have been evaporated during 500 ms, recompressed and illuminated during  $T = 2000\text{ms}$ .

These tests resulted in a systematic protocol for identifying molecular lines where we verify the fitting model of the atomic decay and the temperature evolution.

#### 3.3.1.1 $dN/dt$ decay interpretation

On the observation of the atomic decay upon illumination time –discussed in 3.2.4.4– dark purple plot of Fig.3.20 shows the expected two slopes usually signature of two-body losses. In this figure the atom decay is clearly well described by equation 3.44 and presents a change of slope around 3s: the fit of this data leads to a misinterpretation of the collision nature. The same data in the absence of the PA laser plotted in the same figure shows a linear behavior on the atomic decay. As presented in 3.3.2.2 the exponential decay test is done in atomic resonance: this measurement is not reliable to identify with certainty the nature of the losses while no molecule has been enhanced on this experiment.

Our understanding is that for non-recompressed gas it is possible to still have thermalization when the evaporation is not well optimized. For recompressed gas as in 3.20 collisions keep occurring for atoms contained in a smaller volume which explains the slope break on the plot.

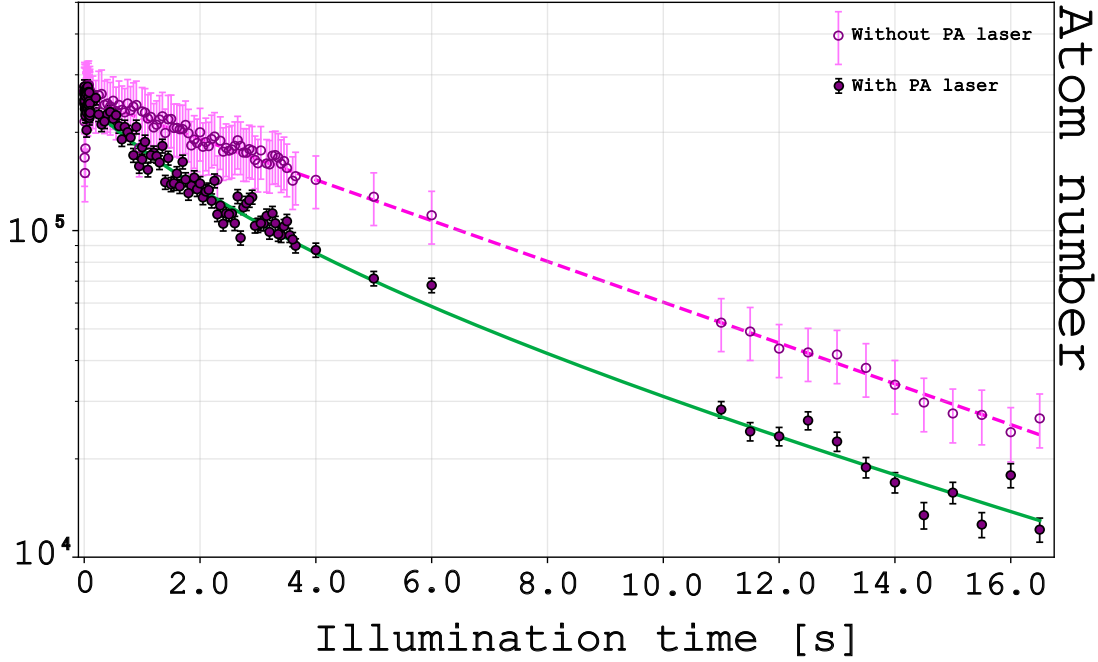


Figure 3.20: Evolution of the atom number (on a logarithmic scale) as a function of the illumination time, measured at a fixed laser detuning of  $f = -6$  MHz from the atomic resonance (see Section 3.2.3.5). Filled circles represent the data in the presence of the photoassociation (PA) laser, adjusted with the fit function (Eq. 3.87) accounting for combined one- and two-body losses. Open circles display the reference measurement at the same frequency in the absence of the PA laser. The distinct decay behaviors observed between the two datasets highlight that relying solely on a single  $dN/dt$  decay measurement is insufficient to unambiguously characterize the loss mechanisms.

### 3.3.1.2 Temperature analysis

Other tests that could indicate inelastic collisions include measuring the temperature of the gas, which we expect to be hotter near the line center. The coldest atoms sit at the bottom of the trap and are therefore most likely to photoassociate; once removed, the remaining atoms re-thermalize via elastic collisions, raising the mean temperature of the gas.

Measuring the temperature as a function of illumination time provides a further test: in the case of genuine inelastic (two-body) loss, we expect  $T(t)$  to follow the saturating exponential

$$T(t) = T_{\infty} - (T_{\infty} - T_0) e^{-\Gamma t} \quad (3.90)$$

with  $T_0$  and  $T_{\infty}$  the temperature without the PA laser and in the limit of infinite exposure time, and  $\Gamma$  the one-body loss rate extracted from the  $N(t)$  fit – since this rate sets the timescale over which the loss dynamics transition from the two-body-dominated regime (responsible for the heating) to the one-body-dominated regime. In contrast, ordinary photon scattering from an off-resonant atomic transition heats the gas at a constant rate, producing a linear  $T(t)$  instead. Note that any saturating exponential is locally linear at short times ( $\Gamma t \ll 1$ ), so a linear trend alone is only

a discriminating test if the observation window is long enough that  $\Gamma t$  would clearly exceed unity – and hence show visible curvature – were the two-body mechanism active.

Figure 3.21 shows  $T(t)$  for the same experiment as Fig. 3.16. The observed trend is linear rather than the saturating exponential expected for two-body photoassociative loss, supporting the interpretation of this 6 MHz signal as resulting from off-resonant atomic scattering rather than genuine molecular photoassociation.

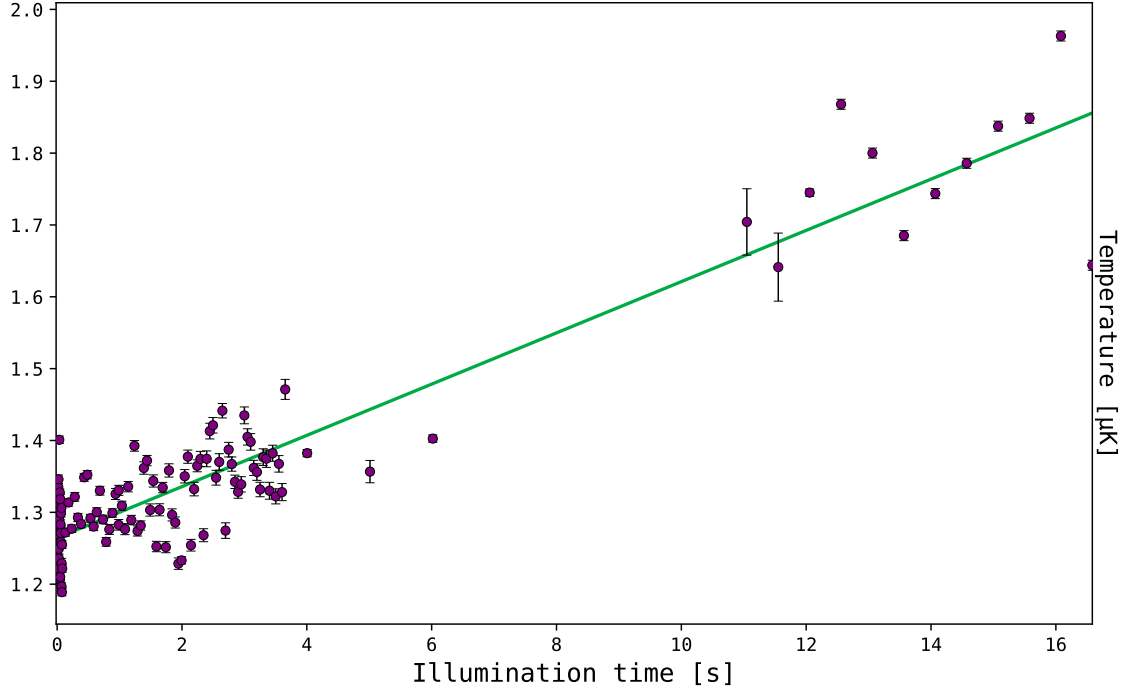


Figure 3.21: Temperature of the gas during the experiment described in Fig. 3.16, where the atom number decays with a two-body-loss-like behavior despite the signal being of atomic, not molecular, origin. The temperature increases linearly rather than following the saturating exponential expected for genuine photoassociative (two-body) loss, consistent with ordinary photon-scattering heating rather than molecule formation.

The cloud temperature of each point of this graph (and all the others) is evaluated by assuming an isotropic thermal velocity distribution. During time-of-flight (TOF), the cloud undergoes isotropic ballistic expansion, where the Gaussian width  $\sigma_y$  measured along a given axis evolves as:

$$\sigma_y^2 = \sigma_{0,y}^2 + v_{\text{th}}^2 \text{TOF}^2 \quad (3.91)$$

where  $\sigma_{0,y}$  is the *in-situ* RMS width of the gas in the optical dipole trap (ODT) intersection, and  $v_{\text{th}}$  is the thermal velocity.

Assuming a Maxwell-Boltzmann velocity distribution, the equipartition theorem links the thermal velocity to the isotropic temperature  $T$  along each degree of freedom via  $\frac{1}{2}m_{\text{at}}v_{\text{th}}^2 = \frac{1}{2}k_B T$ . The temperature is thus extracted from the Gaussian

spatial width  $\sigma_y$  measured on the absorption image:

$$T = \frac{m_{\text{at}} (\sigma_y^2 - \sigma_{0,y}^2)}{k_B \text{TOF}^2} \quad (3.92)$$

Assuming independent uncertainties on both the in-situ size  $\sigma_{0,y}$  and the expanded size  $\sigma_y$ , error propagation in quadrature yields:

$$\delta T = \frac{2m_{\text{at}}}{k_B \text{TOF}^2} \sqrt{(\sigma_y \delta \sigma_y)^2 + (\sigma_{0,y} \delta \sigma_{0,y})^2} \quad (3.93)$$

From the analysis of the red diode noise at  $-6$  MHz, we conclude that three complementary experimental tests can help interpret the elastic or inelastic nature of the collisions observed on the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  signals:

- **$dN/dt$  measurement:** the theoretical part of this chapter derives the two expected slopes of the atomic decay curve. In practice, comparing this decay in the presence and absence of the PA laser was not on its own sufficient to conclude on the nature of the collisions.
- **$T(t)$  measurement:** as detailed above, the temperature is expected to behave linearly at short illumination times and to saturate exponentially as  $t \rightarrow \infty$  in the presence of genuine two-body loss.
- **$T(f)$  measurement:** the reader will find, in the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  results section below, the temperature plotted as a function of laser detuning from the atomic resonance; a symmetric trend with the atom number is expected.

### 3.3.2 Molecular lines on $^{87}\text{Sr}$

#### Line at $-259.01$ MHz

We now present spectra that revealed PA lines.

The closest molecular state red-detuned from the atomic resonance is found at  $f_1 = -259.01 \pm 0.12$  MHz. It was obtained for an illumination time of  $t = 1000$  ms on a recompressed gas at intensity  $I = 19$  W/cm<sup>2</sup>. The Lorentzian shape of the data (Fig. 3.22, top left) reveals a surprisingly large linewidth of  $\Gamma = 2.53 \pm 0.17$  MHz, with a maximum contrast of half the atom number at resonance.

Fig. 3.22 (bottom left) shows the temperature of the cloud measured in the same experiment, intended to help confirm the molecular nature of the losses. While one might expect the temperature to peak sharply at the line center, it instead rises by about  $0.5$   $\mu\text{K}$  over a range symmetric around the resonance, whose width (from the Lorentzian fit) is marked by the green dashed lines.

As for the line discussed below, the temperature fluctuates substantially during illumination, so the atom number decay for this line (Fig. 3.22, top right) is fitted using the interpolated-temperature procedure detailed for the 276.83 MHz line. From the measured trap beam powers, the mean trap frequency is estimated at  $\bar{\omega}/2\pi = 258.6$  Hz, giving an average density  $\langle n \rangle = 7.8 \times 10^{12}$  atoms/cm<sup>3</sup>. The fit yields  $K_2 = 4.10 \times 10^{-13}$  cm<sup>3</sup>/s at  $I = 19$  W/cm<sup>2</sup>, i.e.  $l_{\text{opt}}/I = (4.5 \pm 2.5) \times 10^{-3}$   $a_0/(\text{W}/\text{cm}^2)$ . The saturating-exponential fit of  $T(t)$  (Fig. 3.22, bottom right), with

$\Gamma$  fixed to the value extracted from  $N(t)$ , is consistent with the anti-evaporation heating mechanism discussed in Sec. 3.3.1.2.

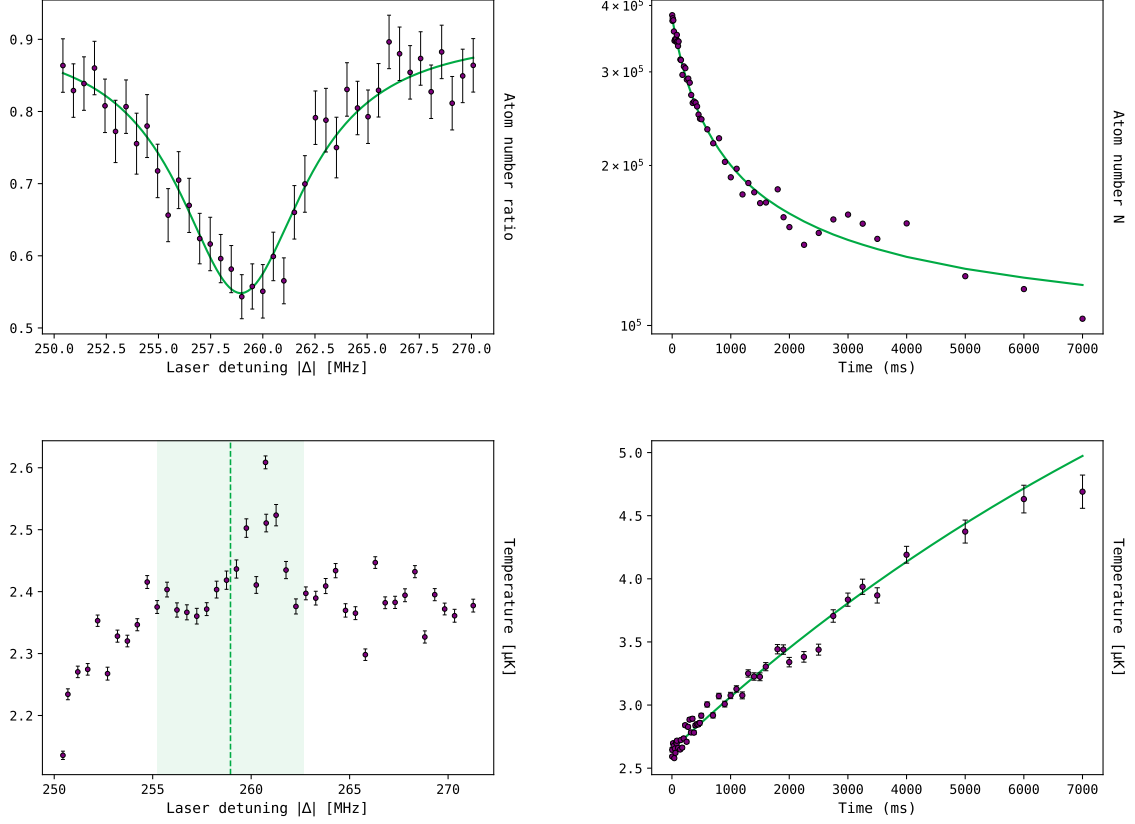


Figure 3.22: Characterization of the molecular line at  $259.01 \pm 0.12$  MHz in  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ . Top left: resonance spectrum ( $I = 19$  W/cm $^2$ ,  $t = 1000$  ms), with Lorentzian fit (green). Top right: atom number decay  $N(t)$ , fitted via Eq. 3.87 with interpolated  $T(t)$ . Bottom left: temperature of the cloud versus detuning; the shaded region and dashed line mark the resonance width and center from the top-left fit. Bottom right: temperature versus illumination time, with a saturating-exponential fit ( $\Gamma$  fixed to the  $N(t)$  value). All detunings are measured from the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  atomic resonance.

### Line at $-276.83$ MHz

The second line is detected at  $f_2 = -276.83 \pm 0.03$  MHz from the atomic resonance (Fig. 3.23, top left). The gas, prepared at a density of  $2 \times 10^{13}$  atoms/cm $^3$  by evaporation at the crossing of the reservoir and dimple beams, was illuminated for 1000 ms. The measured linewidth,  $\Gamma = 7.48 \pm 0.77$  MHz, is again surprisingly large; the points deviating from the fit may result from the laser unlocking, or simply from a poor Gaussian fit of the cloud shape.

The temperature (Fig. 3.23, bottom left) is close to maximal at the line center, but shows an unexplained oscillation of about  $0.1$   $\mu\text{K}$  around  $1.52$   $\mu\text{K}$  just past resonance.

As for the previous line, the atom number decay was first fitted assuming a constant temperature; this fit failed, yielding an implausibly small value of  $l_{\text{opt}}/I = (2.6 \pm 0.9) \times 10^{-6} a_0/(\text{W}/\text{cm}^2)$ .

This misfit was resolved by letting the loss coefficient  $\beta$  depend on the measured temperature, since the gas heats up during photoassociation and the temperature trace shows substantial fluctuations. The temperature measurements are first linearly interpolated into a continuous function  $T(t)$ ; this interpolated temperature is fixed once and for all, independently of the fit that follows. The nonlinear regression then iteratively adjusts four free parameters – the one-body loss rate  $\Gamma$ , the two-body loss coefficient  $K_2$  (equivalently  $l_{\text{opt}}$ ), the initial atom number  $N_0$ , and a constant offset. At each iteration, a candidate value of  $K_2$  is combined with the (fixed) interpolated  $T(t)$  to compute the instantaneous loss rate  $\beta(t) = K_2/(2\sqrt{2} V_e(T(t)))$  at every time step;  $\beta(t)$  is then integrated numerically over time to reconstruct a trial decay curve  $N(t)$  via Eq. 3.87. This trial curve is compared to the measured  $N(t)$  (Fig. 3.23, top right), and the four parameters are updated so as to reduce the resulting  $\chi^2$ ; the procedure repeats until convergence. The final, best-fit  $K_2$  is thus a single constant, common to the entire curve, while  $\beta(t)$  varies throughout the decay solely because it inherits the time-dependence of  $T(t)$  – not because  $K_2$  itself changes with time. This procedure is applied identically to the 259.01 MHz line above.

With this corrected fit, the mean trap frequency is estimated at  $\bar{\omega}/2\pi = 258.6$  **Hz** (same trap powers as for the previous line), giving an average density  $\langle n \rangle = 3.2 \times 10^{13}$  **atoms/cm<sup>3</sup>**. The fit yields  $K_2 = 5.74 \times 10^{-13}$  **cm<sup>3</sup>/s** at  $I = 31$  **W/cm<sup>2</sup>**, i.e.  $l_{\text{opt}}/I = (4.7 \pm 0.4) \times 10^{-3}$   $a_0/(\text{W/cm}^2)$ . The saturating-exponential fit of  $T(t)$  (Fig. 3.23, bottom right) does not reproduce the last three points of the temperature trace, which lie systematically above the model prediction – see the discussion in Sec. 3.3.1.2.

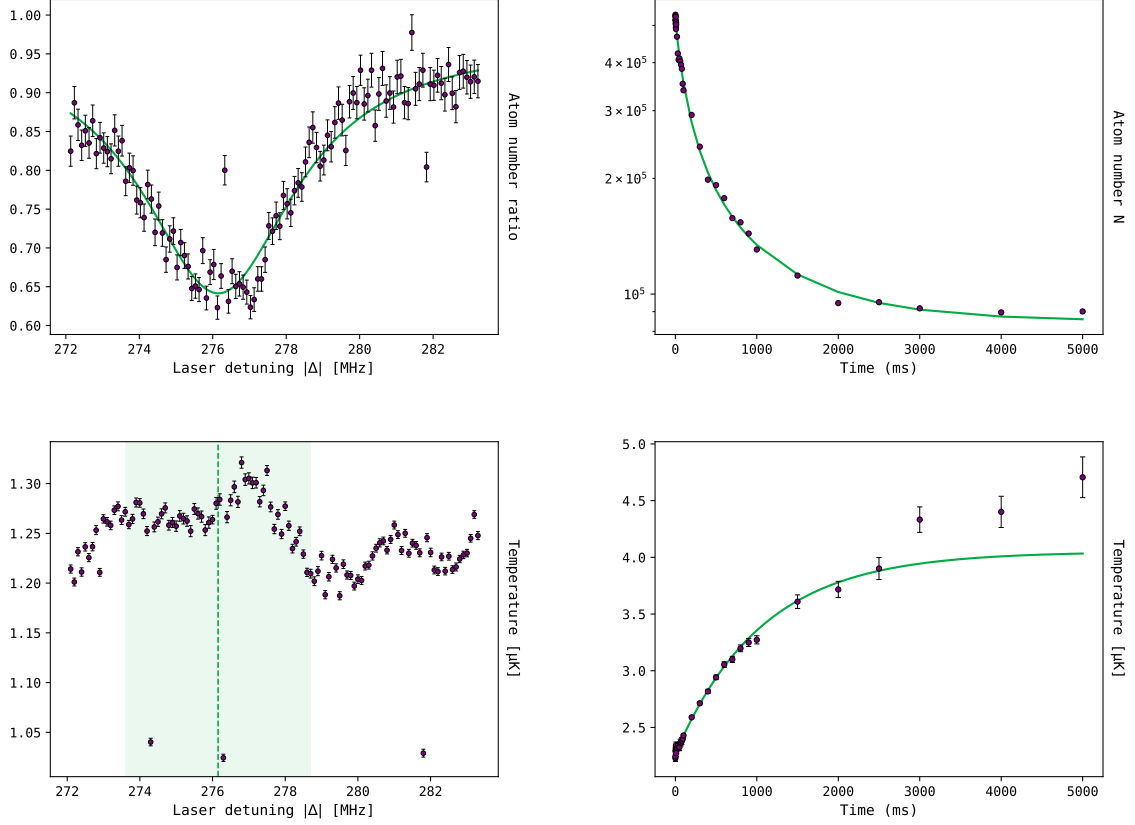


Figure 3.23: Characterization of the molecular line at  $276.83 \pm 0.03$  MHz in  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ . Panel layout as in Fig. 3.22, with  $I = 31$  W/cm $^2$  for the  $N(t)/T(t)$  fits. All detunings are measured from the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  atomic resonance.

### Line at $-375.74$ MHz

The last molecular line is measured at  $f_3 = 375.74 \pm 0.48$  MHz, for a recompressed gas illuminated for 1000 ms at intensity  $I = 5.6$  W/cm $^2$  (Fig. 3.24, top left). It has a notably low contrast and, again, a large linewidth of  $\Gamma = 10.96 \pm 2.68$  MHz. The temperature (Fig. 3.24, bottom left) shows a marked change in slope between the resonance and the red-detuned frequencies, decreasing there by  $\Delta T = 200$  nK. Since the temperature remains essentially constant throughout this resonance's decay measurement,  $dN/dt$  (Fig. 3.24, top right) is well described by Eq. 3.87 in the standard case of a temperature-independent  $\beta$ .

Using the lower trap beam powers for this line, the mean trap frequency is estimated at  $\bar{\omega}/2\pi = 142.7$  Hz, giving an average density  $\langle n \rangle = 1.7 \times 10^{12}$  atoms/cm $^3$ . The fit yields  $K_2 = 1.42 \times 10^{-13}$  cm $^3$ /s at  $I = 19$  W/cm $^2$ , i.e.  $l_{\text{opt}}/I = (1.4 \pm 1.0) \times 10^{-3} a_0/(\text{W/cm}^2)$ . The saturating-exponential fit of  $T(t)$  (Fig. 3.24, bottom right) agrees well with the data over this timescale, though the transition to the  $\Gamma$ -dominated regime is not yet fully resolved given the small value of  $\Gamma$  for this line.

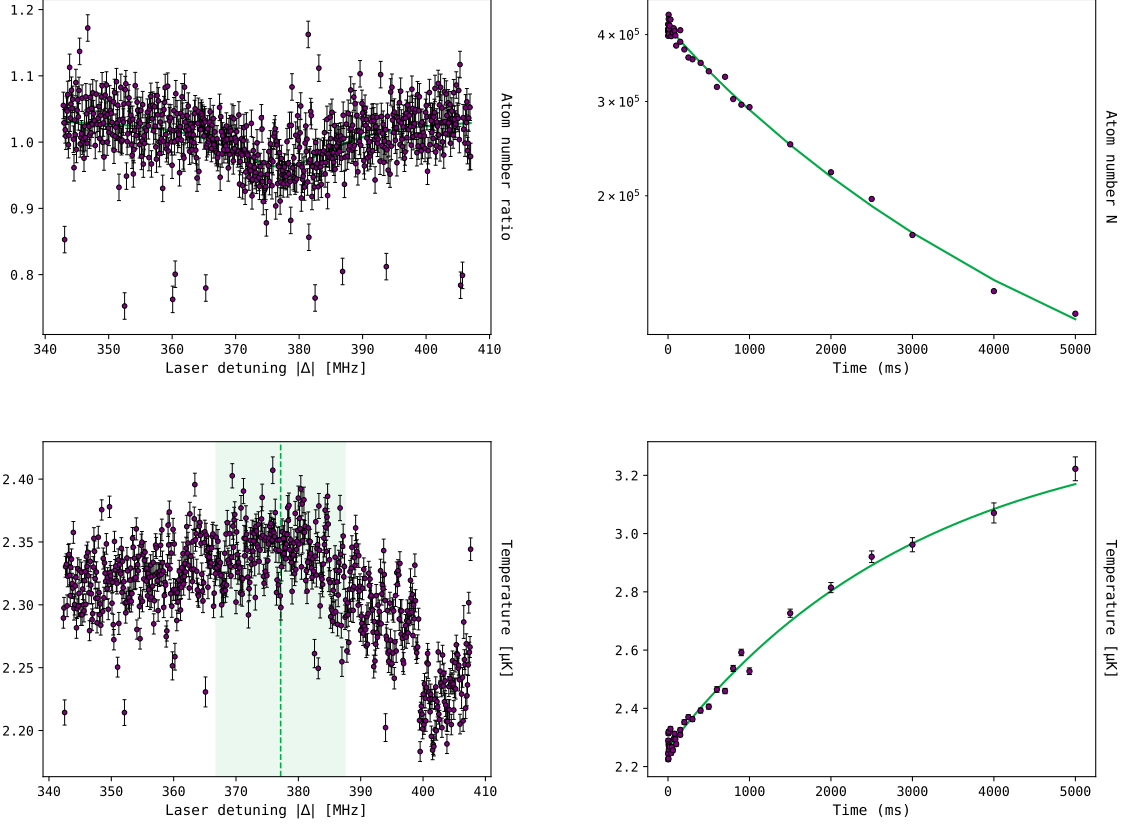


Figure 3.24: Characterization of the molecular line at  $375.74 \pm 0.48$  MHz in  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ . Panel layout as in Fig. 3.22, with  $I = 19$  W/cm<sup>2</sup> for the  $N(t)/T(t)$  fits. All detunings are measured from the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  atomic resonance.

Table 3.3 summarizes the experimental conditions and the resulting fit parameters for the three resonances, together with the derived density  $\langle n \rangle = N/(2\sqrt{2}V_e)$  and characteristic time  $\tau$  (defined in Eq. 3.67). The mean trap oscillation frequency  $\bar{\omega} = (\omega_x\omega_y\omega_z)^{1/3}$ , entering  $V_e(T)$ , is estimated from the measured Reservoir and Dimple beam powers and the trap geometry (see Sec. [ref]); this estimate has not yet been cross-checked against a direct trap-frequency measurement (e.g. parametric heating). 'Depth' refers to the peak amplitude of the fitted Lorentzian line, a proxy for the strength of the transition.

### PA lines found on $^{87}\text{Sr}$

These results show multiple surprising behaviors of our atoms :

- First, contrarely to the 270 kHz energy diffence between the 981 vibrational states estimated under 270 MHz from the atomic transition, we have not been able to detect two-body losses before 259.01 MHz. It is also not consistent with the expected results on 87 isotope from mass scaling discussion of [14].
- Then we hardly exceed 30% of loss: all three datas present small depths from  $8.3 \pm 0.9\%$  to  $36.4 \pm 1.9\%$  for intensities greater than many experiments like [4] and similar atomic densities.
- In addition the linewidth of each line is large :  $2.53 \pm 0.17$ ,  $7.48 \pm 0.77$  MHz and  $10.93 \pm 2.68$  MHz while we expect  $\Gamma = \gamma_{mol} \simeq 2 \times \gamma_{at} \simeq 15$  kHz. **commentaire sur la largeur de certaines expériences déjà grande**

Table 3.3: Summary of fit parameters and experimental conditions for  $^{87}\text{Sr}$

|                                                      |                                |                                |                                |
|------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| <b>Freq. <math>f</math> (MHz)</b>                    | $259.01 \pm 0.12$              | $276.83 \pm 0.03$              | $375.74 \pm 0.48$              |
| Depth                                                | $-0.31 \pm 0.01$               | $-0.37 \pm 0.02$               | $-0.08 \pm 0.01$               |
| Width (MHz)                                          | $2.5 \pm 0.2$                  | $7.5 \pm 0.8$                  | $11.0 \pm 2.7$                 |
| Exposure time $t$ (ms)                               | 1000                           | 1000                           | 1000                           |
| Density $\langle n \rangle$ (atoms/cm <sup>3</sup> ) | $7.8 \times 10^{12}$           | $3.2 \times 10^{13}$           | $1.7 \times 10^{12}$           |
| Intensity for resonance $I$ (W/cm <sup>2</sup> )     | 19                             | 5.2                            | 5.6                            |
| Intensity $I$ for $l_{opt}$ (W/cm <sup>2</sup> )     | 19                             | 31                             | 19                             |
| $\bar{\omega}/2\pi$ (Hz)                             | 258.6                          | 258.6                          | 142.7                          |
| $K_2$ (cm <sup>3</sup> /s)                           | $4.10 \times 10^{-13}$         | $5.74 \times 10^{-13}$         | $1.42 \times 10^{-13}$         |
| Characteristic time $\tau$                           | 393 ms                         | 68.2 ms                        | 5.69 s                         |
| $l_{opt}/I$ ( $a_0/(W/cm^2)$ )                       | $(4.5 \pm 2.5) \times 10^{-3}$ | $(4.7 \pm 0.4) \times 10^{-3}$ | $(1.4 \pm 1.0) \times 10^{-3}$ |

- Also the results have been obtained for similar atomic density of experiment [15] with about 10 times more intensity: still there is five order of magnitude difference on the optical length  $l_{opt}$ . Same conclusion for [119].

One had to use really high values of PA beam intensity compared to the <sup>88</sup>: no signal has been detected with similar intensities.

The plots of PA lines added to the really low estimated  $l_{opt}$  values for high intensity expose multiple unexpected behaviours.

In the next subsection I will discuss the possible interpretation of these characteristics.

### 3.3.3 Interpretation of low contrast and large linewidth

#### 3.3.3.1 Technical possibilities responsible for misbehaving

The first reason of low strength and large linewidth could be the technical limitations of the experiment:

- **Coupling to more energetic state from the ODT laser** The ODT laser at  $\lambda = 1075$  nm can induce unwanted photoassociation (PA) or transitions to higher energy molecular states if it is resonant with excitation pathways originating from the intermediate excited state. To suppress these parasitic multi-photon processes, an out-of-phase chopping sequence between the ODT and the PA laser is implemented (see Fig. 3.25).

This temporal separation addresses three main constraints:

1. **Suppression of multi-photon processes:** Since the ODT (1075 nm) and the PA laser (689 nm) are never turned on simultaneously, photoassociation pathways involving the combined action of both photons are completely eliminated.
2. **Preservation of the atomic cloud:** The trap extinction duration is sufficiently short compared to free-fall expansion so that the atomic cloud does not fall or drop significantly under gravity during the dark phase.
3. **Spectral integrity and AOM response:** The switching time is long

enough for the acousto-optic modulators (AOMs) to respond faithfully, preventing dramatic spectral broadening or alteration of the PA laser line.

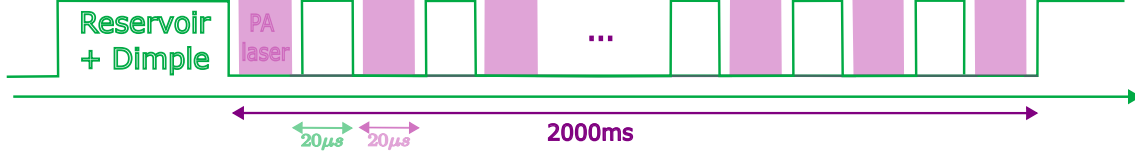


Figure 3.25: Experimental sequence of the ODT and PA laser chopping used to prevent multi-photon transitions to higher energy levels. The RF signals driving the ODT and Raman AOMs are modulated at 25 kHz in opposite phase. This ensures that the two lasers do not overlap while keeping the extinction time short enough to avoid atom loss due to gravity.

This possibility has been ruled out from tests on  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  and  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  molecular line that did not change in the presence of the chopping.

- **Laser noise of the MOGLabs** This laser has been tested on the  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  molecular lines and showed a factor of 20 compared to the expected width  $\simeq 15$  kHz, not enough to explain the large linewidths observed on  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ .
- **Inhomogeneous trap** The atoms could see a different potential from the ODT if they are not all trapped and cooled enough to be at the center of the trap.
- **Thermal width** The temperature of the gas could be a reason of broadening of a resonance when too high. But I demonstrated in Tab.3.2 that the order of magnitude for similar temperature was negligible compared to the few MHz linewidths observed.

These technical possibilities tested bring to the other possible explanation of a true physical effect.

### 3.3.3.2 Physical hypotheses for the low contrast and large linewidth

- **Node of a wavefunction for some vibrational states:** Vibrational states whose wavefunction has a node at the Condon radius cannot be excited by the PA laser. In figure 3.2 the wavefunction of the second bound state crosses the molecular potential at a node. It means that if we try to PA atoms from the free atoms to this molecular state we would not see any atom loss.
- **Coupling to high atomic potentials via potentials crossings:** It exists a possibility that higher atomic potentials of for example the  $^1D_2$  state cross the molecular potential we target on the intercombination line. Then if a vibrational state coincides with the crossing of both potentials then the atoms could be lost by spontaneous emission. Therefore it is less probable that this process occurs because we estimate the probability to be negligible.
- **Predissociation:** The surprising low number of the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  PA lines coupled to the large width and low strength of the lorentzian shape have been observed in [123] where  $^{87}\text{Rb}^{170}\text{Yb}$  bi-alkali molecules are photoassociated on the intercombination line. Only two spectroscopic lines have been observed with a low

contrast while the intensity of the laser reaches  $I = 40 \text{ mW/cm}^2$  corresponding to a two-body loss rate  $\beta = 5 \times 10^{-14} \text{ cm}^3/\text{s}$  corresponding to a really low optical length.

Authors give two interpretations for this result : the first one is the strong dipole at low internuclear distance coming from the rubidium potentials, leading to atomic decay to  $^1S_0$ . Nevertheless this effect is estimated to be less than 10% probable.

The second interpretation is the predissociation process illustrated in Fig.3.26. Two free atoms from potential A are photoassociated to a vibrationnal state of a molecular potential B. Atomic potential C crosses potential B above its dissociation limit which creates a coupling between the two potentials ([124]). In the case of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  this potential is one of the hyperfine structure of the  $^3P_J$  state. The bound atoms then decay to the continuum of the potential C that impacts the lifetime of the excited molecular state as

$$\Gamma_{eff} = \Gamma_{stim} + \Gamma_{predissociation} + \Gamma_{mol} \quad (3.94)$$

with  $\Gamma_{predissociation} \propto \rho(\epsilon_f)$  where  $\rho(\epsilon_f)$  is the kinetic energy continuum of potential C that dilutes the probability of transferring to the excited molecular state B. The predissociation process is then a loss channel for the molecular state that decreases the lifetime of the molecule and increases its linewidth.

In 3.5 the curves do not seem to be affected by the predissociation from the linewidth values. We were thinking that PA on the lowest hyperfine state as for  $\text{Yb}$  would avoid this effect but the data on  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  show the contrary: for a reason we ignore this atom is affected by this process but the  $\text{Yb}$  with hyperfine structure is not.

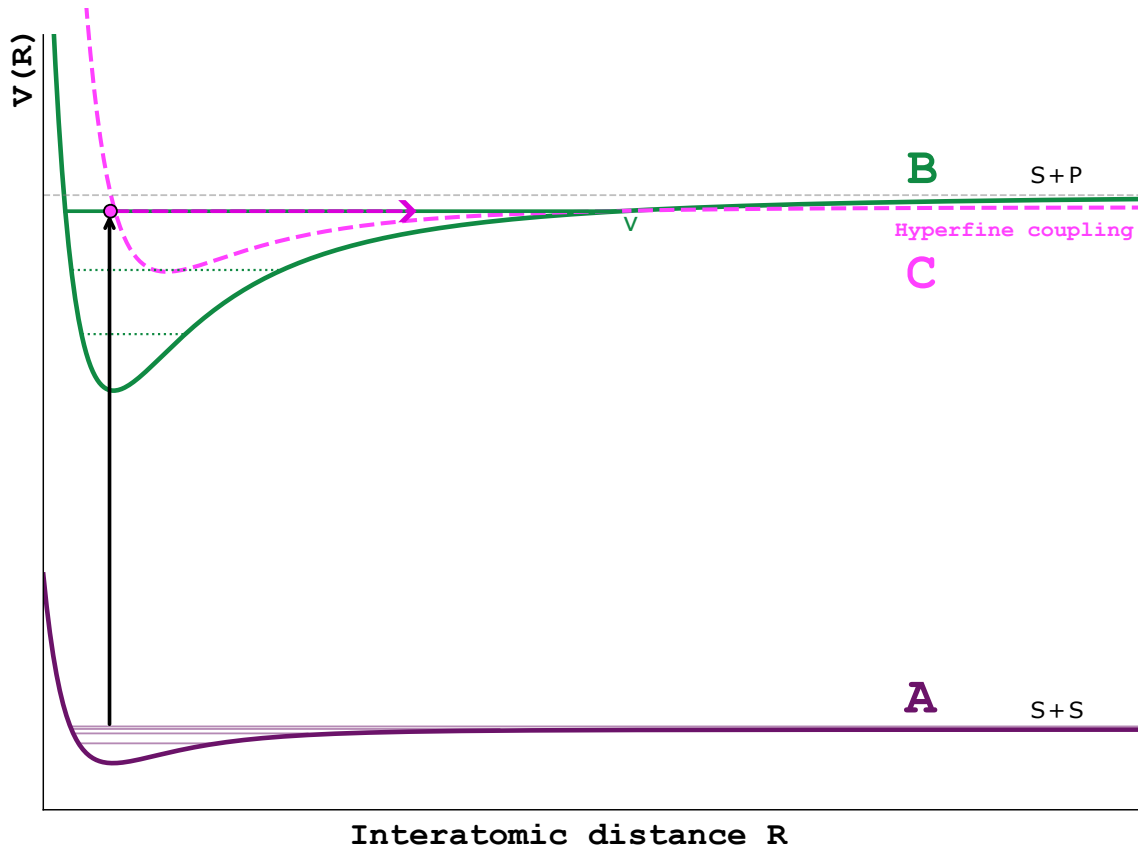


Figure 3.26: Scheme of predissociation which is a phenomenon that occurs when dissociation limit of an excited molecular potential C is under the closed channel of the excited molecule of potential B. Then the  $\nu_B$  state is coupled to a density of states of potential C that modifies the linewidth  $\Gamma_{mol}$  of the molecular state

- **Forest of molecular lines non-resolved** The last hypothesis is the possible high density of molecular lines centered in the frequencies presented in this section.

The two last hypotheses are the most probable ones to explain the broad linewidth and low strength of the molecular lines.

This part of the expose ends with the future experiments to be done to clarify it.

### 3.3.3.3 Tests to be done in the future

At this point of the work, few points have been tested and others merit to be tested on the molecular lines we found:

- Changing the polarization of the PA laser could change the coupling strength with the atomic continuum. This test has been concluded with no significant change on the line.
- Changing the magnetic field could change the energy difference between the hyperfine states and so decrease the density of states. It has also been tested and revealed no significant change on the width -neither frequency shift- and no resolution on eventual molecular lines have been observed.
- Optically pumping the atoms to reduce the size of the Hilbert space would

reduce the number of atomic potentials and so the probability of predissociation. Experiments are in progress to verify this hypothesis. Magnetic field switch has been already implemented in the experiment to fill extremul  $m_F$  states to maximize the value of T.

Both of these possibilities have been tested following this work I presented but no significant change has been observed on the linewidth and the contrast of the molecular lines.

To conclude on this chapter I started to present theoretical aspect of PA process by introducing fundamental material such as scattering length, optical length, atoms evolution time for two-body collisions... Then I presented the experimental results on  $^{88}\text{Sr}$  on intercombination line as a reference to experimentally characterize the process. This chapter ends up with the measurement of molecular lines on an unpolarized gas of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  that comes with low contrast and wide linewidth, explained by predissociation process highly present for numerous molecular potentials such as  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  being an atom with hyperfine structure.

# Conclusion

**Chapter 1** In the first chapter, I presented the physical concepts underlying the cooling scheme of our experiment, providing the elements necessary for a new PhD student – or a similar cold-atom experiment – to operate the setup and understand the physics behind it. Building on the previous theses from our team, this work also presents a new optical setup for filtering the MOGLabs ECDL laser used for the photoassociation (PA) process. The purpose of this filtering cavity is to suppress spontaneous emission on far-detuned states, which otherwise arises from the broadening of the laser spectrum due to amplified spontaneous emission.

**Chapter 2** The second chapter presents the results of our team’s article published in PRX Quantum during my PhD. This work describes the quantum platform we engineered to measure physical properties of our Fermi gas using quantum-enhanced protocols. The article begins with the characterization of the pseudo-spin qubits we engineered: their coherence time reaches more than three seconds, owing to the low sensitivity of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ ’s ground state to external perturbations.

The robustness of these pseudo-spin qubits then allowed us to extend the scheme to a multi-state interferometer – made possible by the large Hilbert space accessible through the nuclear spin  $I = 9/2$  of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  – giving access to physical quantities such as the linear and quadratic components of the light shift induced by the two-photon Raman process used for spin manipulation.

Finally, we demonstrate a measurement scheme for the non-commuting observables  $\hat{s}^x, \hat{s}^y, \hat{s}^z$ , which we show is equivalent to the production of Positive-Operator-Valued Measures (POVMs); this equivalence is derived in a dedicated section following the included article.

**Chapter 3** The last chapter presents our results on the photoassociation of  $^{87}\text{Sr}$ , a process that had remained unexplored prior to this work. The chapter opens with the molecular-physics background necessary to interpret the spectroscopic measurements, complemented by the analysis of temperature and atom-number decay as a function of illumination time. We encountered numerous technical difficulties along the way, which are documented here for the reader’s reference and should be kept in mind more generally when performing this type of spectroscopy.

The observed lines display a surprisingly rich structure in both their strength and linewidth. The most plausible interpretation is a predissociation mechanism: free atoms are excited to a vibrational state close in energy to a coupled atomic potential, so that instead of forming a bound photoassociated molecule, they decay into an atomic kinetic continuum.

**Outcome** Several improvements to the experiment are already underway. To improve the resolution of the cloud imaging, a microscope has been built by a member of the team and is ready to be implemented; this system would also give access to the atom number before time-of-flight, providing a more accurate estimate at every step of the sequence. In parallel, a full replacement for the current transverse cooling system has been constructed and is ready to be installed on the main experiment table, which will consequently increase the number of atoms delivered to the vacuum cell.

On the scientific side, the interferometry scheme developed in this thesis also suggests a way to probe the  $SU(N)$  symmetry of the fermionic species [compléter : lien précis avec la mesure des interactions](#), opening a possible new diagnostic tool for interactions in this system.

Understanding the physical origin of the line broadening – expected from the ongoing optical pumping studies – is the next necessary step: it should make a larger fraction of the  $^{87}\text{Sr}$  spectroscopy accessible, and in turn allow the observed molecular lines to be unambiguously assigned to their associated molecular potentials. This identification is the last missing piece toward the original goal of this work: driving the system, through spin-selective photoassociative losses, into a highly-entangled Dicke state with well-defined spin components.

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